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ISSUES FIERY NEW THREAT AGAINST IRAN

Trump says Iran deal possible by today, claims Tehran is negotiating

US Airman rescued in ‘life-or-death’ mission in Iranian territory

ASSOCIATED PRESS

WASHINGTON: US President Donald Trump on Sunday said that he believes there is a “good chance” of making a deal with Iran on Monday, ahead of his deadline for Tehran to reopen the Strait of Hormuz or face heavy bombing. “I think there is a good chance tomorrow (Monday), they are negotiating now,” the president told a Fox News journalist.

US-Israeli strikes hit an airport in southwestern Iran on Sunday. The state media reported that Shahid (Qasem) Soleimani International Airport was hit in an airstrike.

Trump on Sunday made new, expletive-laden threats to escalate strikes on Iran and its infrastructure if it doesn’t open the Strait of Hormuz by his deadline, after American forces rescued an aviator whose Iran-downed plane fell behind enemy lines.



A man looks at a destroyed building within the Grand Hosseiniyeh complex that officials say was hit by US-Israeli airstrikes in Zanjan, Iran, Saturday

HIGHLIGHTS

- » US-Israeli strikes hit Soleimani International Airport in southwest Iran
- » Trump threatens expanded strikes on Iran’s infrastructure, including power plants and bridges
- » Iran retaliates, targeting infrastructure in Gulf Arab countries
- » Tehran disputes US account of downed pilot rescue mission
- » Trump warns Iran will be “living in Hell” if strait remains closed
- » War, now over five weeks, has killed thousands and disrupted global trade
- » Fuel prices surge as key shipping routes remain blocked

A defiant Iran showed no sign of backing down, striking infrastructure targets in neighbouring Gulf Arab countries and challenging the US account of the rescue.

In a social media post, Trump promised strikes on Iran’s power plants and bridges and said the country would be “living in Hell” if the strait, a crucial waterway for global

trade, isn’t opened to marine traffic by Tuesday. He ended with “Praise be to Allah.”

Trump has issued such deadlines before but extended them when mediators have

claimed progress toward ending the war, which has killed thousands, shaken global markets, cut off key shipping routes and spiked fuel prices in just over five weeks. **Continued on P4**

Govt steps up LPG supply, urges calm amid Hormuz concerns

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Amid rising tensions in West Asia and concerns over global energy routes, the government has stepped up measures to maintain uninterrupted fuel supplies, strengthen enforcement against irregularities and support Indian nationals in the region, even as authorities urged the public to avoid panic buying and rely on verified information.

In a coordinated response involving multiple ministries, officials said domestic energy supply chains remain stable despite uncertainties around key transit points such as the Strait of Hormuz. The Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas reported that petrol, diesel and LPG supplies continue without disruption, with refineries operating at high capacity and maintaining adequate crude inventories. Petrol pumps across the country remain fully stocked, and retail fuel prices have been kept unchanged, supported by a Rs 10 per litre cut in excise duty on petrol and diesel and export levies on diesel and aviation turbine fuel to ensure domestic availability.



KEY POINTS

- » 5 kg LPG cylinders widely available without address proof
- » 6.6 lakh small cylinders sold since March 23; 90,000 sold on April 4
- » Over 51 lakh domestic LPG cylinders delivered in a single day
- » Online bookings account for 95 per cent of LPG demand
- » LPG refill interval extended to 25 days urban, 45 days rural
- » Commercial LPG supply capped at 70 per cent of pre-crisis levels
- » Over 50,000 cylinders seized; 1,400 notices issued; 36 dealerships suspended

To manage demand for cooking gas, the government has expanded the availability of smaller 5 kg LPG cylinders, also known as free trade LPG (FTL) cylinders, which are sold at market rates and can be purchased over the counter without address proof. Since March 23, about 6.6 lakh of these cylinders have been sold, including more than 90,000

on April 4 alone. Officials said the move is aimed at easing pressure on regular domestic LPG supplies, especially in urban areas and among migrant populations.

Authorities reported that more than 51 lakh domestic LPG cylinders were delivered in a single day, with online bookings accounting for 95 percent **Continued on P4**

PM Modi makes 33% reservation pitch to Bengal’s women voters

Says benefit from 2029 LS polls

MPOST BUREAU

COOCH BEHAR: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday said that the proposed 33 per cent reservation for women in the Lok Sabha and state assemblies could begin to take effect from the 2029 general elections, as he addressed a rally in Cooch Behar in north Bengal.

Speaking at his first public meeting in the region after the election schedule was announced, Modi directed his message at women voters, a key constituency in West Bengal’s politics. Referring to the state’s tradition of worshipping “Shakti”, he positioned the BJP as a party committed to women’s “security, dignity and empowerment.”

“It is important for the country that women have a greater role in decisions made for the country. Therefore, our government has enacted a law providing 33 per cent reservation for women in the Lok Sabha and state assemblies,” Modi said.

The Prime Minister noted that the NDA government is working to operationalise the



quota law, passed in 2023, in time for the next Lok Sabha elections due in 2029. “The sisters of West Bengal and of the entire country should begin getting its benefit from the 2029 Lok Sabha elections itself. We are trying to ensure this. Therefore, the government has convened a special session of Parliament this month,” he said, adding that the measure had been pending for four decades.

Earlier, Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju had indicated in the Rajya Sabha that Parliament would meet again soon to consider key legislation. The ongoing Budget session has been extended by three days and will resume on April 16 after a short recess. The Centre is planning to **Continued on P4**

Cong alleges Assam CM’s wife holds three passports, properties worth Rs. 52K cr

Sarma rejects claims, vows legal action

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

NEW DELHI: The Congress on Sunday alleged that Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma’s wife possesses passports of three countries and that he concealed information about her properties, but the BJP leader “categorically rejected” the claims as “malicious” and “fabricated” and vowed to take legal action “within 48 hours.”

Targeting Sarma as the campaign peaks for the April 9 assembly election in Assam, Congress’ media and publicity department head Pawan Khara showed, at a press conference, purported documents to support the allegations and demanded that the Election Commission cancel his nomination for allegedly concealing information in his poll affidavit.

Hitting back at Khara, Sarma said that as Assam moves decisively towards a historic mandate, such desperate and baseless attacks only expose the Congress’ sinking ground.

“These are malicious, fabricated, and politically motivated

TAKEAWAYS

- » Alleged passports: UAE (2022–2027), Antigua & Barbuda (2021–2031), Egypt (2022–2029)
- » Allegations include two Dubai properties and a Wyoming-based company

lies aimed at misleading the people of Assam,” the Assam chief minister said.

He alleged that “documents being circulated show multiple glaring inconsistencies, suggesting a crude and poorly executed attempt at digital manipulation.”

Sarma said his wife and he will be filing both criminal and civil defamation cases within the next 48 hours against Khara for making “reckless and defamatory statements.”

At his press conference, Khara said Assam Chief Minister Sarma and his wife “have faced numerous allegations over time -- such as land grabbing, misappropriation of temple donations, siphoning off government subsidies.” **Continued on P4**

WESTERN DISTURBANCES TO PEAK ON APRIL 7–9

IMD warns of widespread rain, hail and storms across India this week

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Unseasonal weather driven by successive western disturbances is set to sweep across large parts of India this week, prompting alerts for heavy rainfall, thunderstorms, hail and strong winds, while already causing casualties and crop damage in several states. The India Meteorological Department has warned that the current spell, which has brought rain and hail to parts of the country, will intensify between April 7 and 9, affecting a wide swathe of north, northwest and central India as well as



Vehicles ply on a road amid heavy rain, in Kolkata, on Sunday

parts of the northeast and southern peninsula.

The weather agency has

issued alerts for heavy rainfall in isolated areas of Arunachal Pradesh and Tamil Nadu over

the next 24 hours, with continued wet conditions expected across northeastern states for the next five days. According to the IMD, scattered to fairly widespread light to moderate rainfall accompanied by thunderstorms, lightning and gusty winds of 30 to 40 kmph is likely across the region, with stronger winds in some southern states reaching up to 50 kmph. Heavy rainfall is forecast at isolated locations in Arunachal Pradesh on April 5, 6, 8 and 9, and in Assam and Meghalaya on April 7, 9 and 11.

Southern states including Tamil Nadu, Kerala, coastal **Continued on P4**



SEBI भारतीय प्रतिष्ठान और विनिवेश बोर्ड Securities and Exchange Board of India

NSE IPFT

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SEBI INTRODUCES “VALIDATED UPI HANDLES” TO ENABLE SECURED PAYMENTS

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MULE ACCOUNTS, CRYPTO CHANNELS USED TO ROUTE FUNDS

Cops bust Rs 300 crore int’l cyber fraud syndicate, nab mastermind

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Police has busted a major international cyber fraud syndicate -- linked with over 2,000 complaints and scams worth over Rs 300 crore -- with the arrest of its alleged mastermind and 10 others, an official said on Sunday.

During the investigation, police uncovered a well-organised network operating across multiple states with links to international cyber fraud syndicates, particularly in Cambodia.

“We have so far identified over 260 bank accounts linked to more than 100 fictitious companies used to channel the proceeds of crime. The total number of complaints linked to the syndicate stands at 2,567,” police said.

The key accused, Karan Kajaria, was apprehended at Kolkata airport on April 3 after a Look Out Circular was issued against him. He was brought to Delhi a day later for further investigation, Deputy Commissioner of Police (Crime



Branch) Aditya Gautam said.

The case came to light following a complaint by a city resident, Sultan, who alleged that he was duped of Rs 31.45 lakh after being lured into an investment scheme.

Police said the victim was persuaded to download a fake trading application and invest money with promises of high returns. However, when he attempted to withdraw the profits, the application stopped functioning, and the group became inaccessible.

“An FIR was registered at the cyber police station in northeast and later transferred to the crime branch for a detailed probe,” the officer said.

The syndicate created fake investment platforms and messaging groups to lure victims. They used mule bank accounts arranged through intermediaries and deployed malicious applications to capture sensitive banking details, including OTPs. Funds collected from victims were routed through a complex web of bank accounts

HIGHLIGHTS

- » The case came to light following a complaint by a city resident, Sultan, who alleged that he was duped of Rs 31.45 lakh after being lured into an investment scheme
- » Police said the victim was persuaded to download a fake trading application and invest money with promises of high returns

and shell companies to conceal the trail, police said.

Police said Kajaria frequently travelled abroad to establish and strengthen links with overseas fraud networks and had attempted to evade arrest by staying outside India.

Technical surveillance helped investigators trace the network to Kolkata, where several bank accounts and shell entities were found to be operating. Upon his arrival in India, Kajaria was intercepted at the airport and taken into custody.

During interrogation, he allegedly confessed to his involvement in the syndicate, police said, adding that accounts linked to his network were associated with more than 2,500 complaints registered on the National Cybercrime Reporting Portal and fraud of Rs 300 crore, the DCP said.

Probe found the syndicate active for 4–5 years across states. Police seized 48 phones, 258 SIMs, laptops and banking documents, froze Rs 19 lakh, and arrested 11; further investigation is underway.

Six apprehended as Rs 2 cr spurious medicines seized

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Police has busted an organised interstate racket involved in manufacturing and supplying spurious life-saving medicines, arresting six persons and seizing counterfeit drugs worth around Rs 2 crore, an official said on Sunday.

During the operation, the police also exposed a network of fake GST firms used to generate bogus invoices and launder proceeds of the illegal trade, with investigators estimating the fake billing to the tune of nearly Rs 50 crore.

According to the police, the racket was engaged in large-scale manufacturing, storage and distribution of counterfeit Schedule-H drugs, which are commonly prescribed for ailments such as diabetes, hypertension, and liver disorders, posing a serious risk to public health.

The accused have been identified as Nikhil Arora alias Sunny, a wholesale medicine dealer based in Shahdara, Shivam Tyagi and Mayank Aggarwal, both suppliers from Uttar Pradesh, Mohit Kumar Sharma, a key supplier from Uttarakhand, and Shahrulkh and Rahul, who allegedly operated fake GST firms to facilitate



“Over 1.2 lakh counterfeit tablets and capsules were recovered during the raid”

the illegal trade.

“The case came to light following specific inputs, after which a raid was conducted on March 11 in Bihari Colony in Shahdara. During the operation, Arora, who ran a wholesale medical shop in Bhagirathi Palace, was apprehended,” a senior police officer said.

He said that over 1.2 lakh counterfeit tablets and capsules were recovered during the raid, including fake versions of widely used medicines such as Rabemac-DSR, Telma-AM, Sporolac-DS, Signoflam, Chymoral Forte, Ursocol-300, Gluconorm, Jalra-50 and several others. These medicines are frequently prescribed and consumed by patients suffering from chronic illnesses, the officer said.

“The circulation of counterfeit drugs of this nature can have severe and potentially fatal consequences,” he added. Further investigation

revealed that the accused had developed a modus operandi to evade detection. The counterfeit medicines were supplied using fake invoices generated through fictitious GST firms that existed only on paper. All these shell entities were created to conceal the actual nature of business operations, evade tax scrutiny and lend a semblance of legitimacy to illegal transactions, the officer said. “The financial trail was deliberately routed through these fake firms to mask both the origin and destination of the spurious medicines,” the officer said.

Shahrulkh and Rahul ran a fake GST network using shell firms, generating Rs 50 crore in bogus invoices, police said. Probe traced the racket to an illegal Muzaffarnagar unit, recovering raw materials, machinery and fake packaging. The unlicensed operation spanned multiple states; one accused has prior NCB cases.

Shopkeeper killed, 2 injured as neighbours clash in Shakurpur

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: A 50-year-old grocery shop owner was stabbed to death and two others injured after a violent quarrel between neighbours in northwest Delhi’s Shakurpur area on Saturday night, police said.

The incident occurred around 9.10 pm on April 4 at Sanjay Park in K-Block, within the jurisdiction of Subhash Place police station. Police received a PCR call reporting a dispute between neighbours that escalated into a serious assault.

When officers reached the spot, they found multiple individuals involved in the clash. According to police, the



“The accused allegedly attacked the victims using lathis, iron rods and knives”

accused allegedly attacked the victims using lathis, iron rods and knives.

Rajkumar (50), who ran a grocery shop in the locality,

sustained multiple stab injuries. He was rushed to a hospital but was declared brought dead. Two others also suffered injuries and were provided medical treatment.

An FIR has been registered at Subhash Place police station under relevant sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS). Crime team and forensic science laboratory (FSL) experts inspected the scene and collected evidence.

During preliminary investigation, one accused was detained, while the identities of other suspects have been established. Some are undergoing treatment, and further legal action will follow. Police said efforts are ongoing to reconstruct the sequence of events.

NEW DELHI: A 19-year-old man was killed after being hit by a Delhi Transport Corporation (DTC) bus in northwest Delhi’s Azadpur area on Sunday, an official said.

The incident was reported to the Adarsh Nagar police station at around 5.30 pm via a PCR call.

Upon reaching the spot, police found the victim, identified as Akash, a resident of Sahipur village in Shalimar Bagh, lying on the road in a severely injured condition and was later declared dead, police in a statement said.

The victim was allegedly hit by a speeding DTC bus, following which the driver fled the scene, leaving the vehicle. The sudden nature of the col-

CCTV footage from nearby roads, traffic signals & commercial establishments is being scanned: Cops

lision led to chaos at the site, with locals gathering at the spot soon after the incident.

“A crime team was immediately called to inspect the scene, and a forensic examination of the spot was carried out. The body was later shifted to the BJRM mortuary for post-mortem. The family members of the deceased have been informed,” read the statement.

According to the police, preliminary inquiry indicates that the accident occurred on a

busy stretch in Azadpur, where traffic congestion and heavy vehicular movement are common during evening hours.

Police are examining whether the victim was crossing the road at the time of the accident or if other factors contributed to the incident.

As part of the probe, multiple police teams have been deployed to identify the offending bus and trace its driver.

Police are scanning CCTV footage from nearby roads and establishments to trace the vehicle’s route and verify the DTC bus involved. Eyewitness statements are being recorded to establish the sequence of events. A case is being registered, and further investigation is underway, officials said. MP05T

News at a Glance

COP SLAPS 78-YEAR-OLD SHOPKEEPER

NEW DELHI: A Delhi Police woman sub-inspector allegedly slapped a 78-year-old shopkeeper after a parking dispute in Rohini Sector 7. The pregnant officer, visiting for a medical check-up, reportedly argued after he objected to her car. A PCR call was made, and police are investigating the incident.

RACKET INVOLVED IN DIVERTING GOVT-SUPPLIED MEDICINES UNEARTHED, FIVE CAUGHT

NEW DELHI: Delhi Police busted a racket diverting government-supplied medicines and arrested five, including a DDU Hospital pharmacist and helper. Drugs worth Rs 70 lakh, marked “not for sale”, were seized in Tis Hazari. The network allegedly operated for over a year, siphoning hospital stocks and selling them across cities.

Ggm-based gangster held, weapon seized

Habitual offender with 25 cases intercepted in Haiderpur

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Delhi Police has arrested a man allegedly associated with the Surrender Fauji gang and recovered a pistol along with three bullets from his possession, an officer said on Sunday.

Rakesh Banjara, a resident of Gurugram, is a habitual offender with over 25 criminal cases against him, including murder, attempt to murder and robbery.

Police said information was received on April 3 that Banjara would visit Haiderpur village to meet his relatives and would be carrying an illegal firearm. Acting on the tip-off, a team laid a trap near a hotel.

“At around 3.15 pm, a car approaching the spot was intercepted and the



accused, who was inside the vehicle, was arrested,” the officer said.

During interrogation, Banjara reportedly disclosed that he is a gangster operating in Gurugram and adjoining regions and has long been involved in criminal activities.

He told police that he had procured

Rakesh Banjara reportedly disclosed that he is a gangster operating in Ggm and adjoining regions and has long been involved in criminal activities: Cops

the weapon illegally about three years ago from a man in Uttar Pradesh and had been carrying it due to ongoing gang rivalry and personal enmity.

Verification revealed that his in-laws reside in Haiderpur village and he had come there for a visit,” the officer said.

Members of ‘Doodh Chor’ gang arrested

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Two members of a ‘Doodh Chor’ gang were arrested in southwest Delhi’s Uttam Nagar after a viral video exposed dairy thefts, police said.

The accused, Mohit alias Patha (27) and Ayush Maan Pandey (19), trailed milk vans and stole crates using stolen vehicles.

Acting on a tip-off, police nabbed them near Vikas Nagar on April 3 and recovered 14 empty crates from a stolen three-wheeler.

Further recoveries included a scooter and motorcycle. Mohit, a habitual offender with 38 cases, had recently been released from jail.

NEW DELHI: The Central Information Commission has pulled up the IRCTC, the catering arm of the Indian Railways, over the denial of information on an RTI plea seeking to know if companies bidding for railway tenders had disclosed their alleged links to the Rail Neer ‘scam’ and related cases probed by central agencies.

The RTI applicant had asked the Indian Railway Catering and Tourism Corporation (IRCTC) if the bidders clearly mentioned the CBI or ED cases against their names, if any, in their tender documents.

The Rail Neer ‘scam’ was a 2015 corruption case investigated by the CBI, in which private catering companies



“Overall, the RTI aimed to check if the companies were transparent about the investigations against them while participating in government tenders”

supplied cheap bottled water instead of the mandated ‘Rail Neer’ on premium trains (Rajdhani and Shatabdi), causing the Indian Railways a loss of about Rs 19.5 crore.

The RTI specifically asked if the bidders declared that they were “accused in the famous Rail Neer scam” and that the CBI had “registered an FIR (RC-DAI-2015-A-0032)

against them”.

It also asked if they disclosed that the ED had “registered a case under sections 120B read with Section 420 of the IPC and 13(2) read with 13(1)(d) of the Prevention of Corruption Act”.

The applicant also sought to know if the bidders informed the authorities about the key developments in these cases,

such as raids, cash seizures, and whether a “chargesheet” or “complaint” had been filed in the court by the agencies.

Overall, the RTI aimed to check if the companies were transparent about the investigations against them while participating in government tenders.

The IRCTC, however, denied the data, saying, “The information sought is exempted from disclosure as per Section 8 (d) of the Right to Information Act, 2005”.

Section 8(1)(d) of the RTI Act, 2005, exempts information from disclosure that includes commercial confidence, trade secrets, or intellectual property, if revealing it would harm

the competitive position of a third party.

It protects sensitive business data held by public authorities unless a larger public interest warrants its disclosure.

During the hearing, the appellant argued that the information was sought in “larger public interest” and had been “wrongly denied”, maintaining that he was entitled to access such details under the RTI law.

The CIC found the response inadequate, saying merely citing an exemption without justification violates the RTI Act. It held denial must be reasoned, with the burden on the authority, and directed IRCTC to provide a fresh, speaking reply. AGENCIES

Hero Realty acquires Rs 218 cr land parcel

DIPIKA KIROLA

GREATER NOIDA: The Greater Noida Authority has allotted a residential land parcel to Hero Realty in Sector MU, underlining rising developer interest in the region.

The company acquired the 18,215 square metre plot through an auction conducted by the Greater Noida Industrial Development Authority in early April 2026. Industry sources estimate the deal at around Rs 218 crore, with competitive bidding pushing the final price well above the reserve.

The parcel is earmarked for residential development and marks Hero Realty’s first project in Greater Noida. The acquisition aligns with the company’s strategy to expand across high-growth corridors in the National Capital Region (NCR), where infrastructure-led development is fuelling housing demand.

Located along a 60-metre-wide road in Sector MU, the site offers strong connectivity to key routes, including the Noida–Greater Noida Expressway and the upcoming FNG Expressway. Its proximity to the under-construction Noida International Airport is expected to enhance the project’s long-term investment appeal.

Officials said the deal reflects a broader trend of developers targeting emerging micro-markets supported by infrastructure upgrades. Greater Noida, in particular, has seen increased traction due to improved connectivity, planned metro expan-

TAKEAWAYS

» Located along a 60-metre-wide road in Sector MU, the site offers strong connectivity to key routes, including the Noida–Greater Noida Expressway and the upcoming FNG Expressway

» Its proximity to the under-construction Noida Int’l Airport is expected to enhance the project’s long-term investment appeal

» The proposed proj will cater to mid- to premium-housing segment, addressing evolving buyer preferences

sion and expanding social infrastructure.

Company officials indicated that the timing of the investment aligns with rapid urbanisation around major infrastructure projects, especially airport-led development corridors. The proposed project is expected to cater to the mid- to premium-housing segment, addressing evolving buyer preferences for integrated and well-connected communities.

With this acquisition, Hero Realty joins a growing list of developers investing in Greater Noida, signalling confidence in the region’s long-term growth prospects and its emergence as a key real estate destination in NCR.

RS 22K CRORE MAPPED; YAMUNA, E-BUSES IN FOCUS

Delhi plugs 17 depts into green circuit

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: In a strong policy shift towards environmental sustainability, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Sunday unveiled a Rs 22,236 crore Green Budget for 2026–27, marking one of the most ambitious clean air and climate-focused financial plans for the Capital. With over 21 per cent of the total Rs 1,03,700 crore state budget dedicated to green initiatives, the government has laid out a clear roadmap to tackle pollution and build a sustainable urban ecosystem.

Announcing the plan, the Chief Minister emphasised that environmental protection is now central to governance, with all departmental spending aligned to green goals. She said this approach ensures accountability and measurable

GREEN DRIVE

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» Announcing the plan, the CM emphasised that environmental protection is now central



to governance, with all departmental spending aligned to green goals

implementation, 17 departments have been assigned specific roles under the Green Budget framework

» To ensure coordinated

Budget framework. The Planning Department has been allocated Rs.2,350 crore to streamline project execution, while Urban Development and DUSIB together will receive Rs.2,273 crore for targeted interventions. The Power Department has been earmarked Rs.1,410 crore to promote solar energy and renewable sources.

Additional support will be provided through a dedicated 'Green Fund' covering departments such as Environment, Irrigation and Flood Control, Development, Forest, Tourism, and Education, among others. Allocations have also been made for industrial pollution control, green initiatives in hospitals, disaster management, and environmental education.

Highlighting the broader vision, Gupta said, "Clean Delhi, Green Delhi is no lon-

ger just a slogan, but a decisive policy response to toxic air and rising temperatures." She added, "This approach goes beyond accounting, it establishes a robust framework to combat pollution and tackle climate change."

The Chief Minister further stressed that environmental protection is a collective responsibility. "We recognise climate change, pollution and the depletion of natural resources as serious and immediate challenges, and through this Green Budget, public spending will be aligned to support sustainable development and protect biodiversity," she said. With a comprehensive, department-wise strategy and clear funding priorities, the Green Budget 2026–27 aims to transform Delhi into a cleaner, greener, and more resilient city for the future.

No LPG sales from GODOWNS: Govt

5-kg LPG expansion eases migrant woes

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: In a strong move to curb irregularities and ensure smooth LPG distribution, the Delhi government has imposed a strict ban on the sale of LPG cylinders directly from godowns, while simultaneously expanding access to 5-kg cylinders across the city to ease consumer demand.

Announcing the measures, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said the government is focused on making the LPG supply system more transparent, efficient, and accessible, particularly for vulnerable sections such as migrant workers. "LPG supply in Delhi is fully stable and under control," she said, urging residents not to panic and to rely on the existing home delivery system.

Under the new directive, Oil Marketing Companies have instructed all distributors that selling cylinders from storage godowns is illegal and will invite strict action. The step aims to prevent hoarding, black marketing, and unauthorised sales.

To improve accessibility, 5-kg LPG cylinders are now widely available at gas agencies across Delhi. These smaller cylinders can be purchased with a valid ID, without the need for address verification, making them especially useful for migrant workers and temporary residents. Additionally, 11 help desks have been set up at select HPCL outlets to guide consumers on nearby distributors and services.

Officials said supply remains steady, supported by efficient delivery systems. Data from April 4 shows that 1,14,679 LPG bookings were recorded, while 1,31,335 cylinders were delivered, indicating that pending demand is being cleared. The average delivery time currently stands at 4.24 days.

The government has also

Supply remains smooth; average delivery in 4.24 days; 17 raids, 76 agencies inspected

LPG supply in Delhi is fully stable and under control

— Chief Minister Rekha Gupta



intensified enforcement to tackle illegal activities. Delhi Police carried out raids at 17 locations, and the Food and Supplies Department inspected 76 gas agencies and storage points across the city.

A dedicated control room has been made operational to receive complaints related to hoarding and black marketing. Residents can report issues via helpline numbers, with authorities assuring prompt action and confidentiality.

Reiterating the government's stance, Gupta said, "Citizens should stay calm, avoid rumours, and cooperate with the administration while relying on the established delivery system."

Bawana sees launch of seven infra works

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Development work in Delhi's Bawana Assembly constituency received a boost on Sunday as Social Welfare Minister Ravinder Indraj Singh inaugurated seven infrastructure projects simultaneously, aimed at improving basic civic amenities in the area.

The projects, launched under the Chief Minister Development Fund, include construction of roads and drainage systems in multiple pockets of Sector-24, Rohini. Officials said the works will be executed by the Municipal Corporation of Delhi with a focus on strengthening local infrastructure and enhancing the quality of life for residents.

Addressing the gathering, the Minister described the initiative as a major step towards comprehensive development of the constituency. "This is a significant step towards the holistic development of the area," he said.

Highlighting the broader vision of the government, he added, "Under the leadership of the Hon'ble Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, development works across the capital are progressing at an unprecedented pace." He noted that several projects have already been approved under the CM Development Fund to improve

This is a significant step towards the holistic development of the area

— Minister Indraj

roads, drainage, water supply, street lighting, parks, and other essential services.

Emphasising accountability, Singh said there would be no tolerance for delays or negligence in execution. "There is no shortage of funds and any negligence or delay in development works will not be tolerated," he stated, directing officials to ensure timely completion while maintaining quality standards.

The Minister also underlined that development is being carried out across both urban and rural parts of Delhi. "Rapid development is taking place in both rural and urban areas, and the government is committed to ensuring that progress is visible on the ground in every locality," he said. He added that multiple agencies, including MCD, Delhi Jal Board, Public Works Department, and others, are working in coordination to implement these projects effectively, while continuous inaugurations are being undertaken to sustain development momentum.



Chief Minister Rekha Gupta flags off 'Saksham Yatra' 2026, in New Delhi, on Sunday

PTI

EWS, DG, CWSN seats draw today

NEW DELHI: The first computerised draw of lots for admissions under the EWS, DG and CWSN categories for the 2026-27 academic session will be held on Monday at 10 am, according to guidelines issued by the Delhi government. According to the notified schedule, scrutiny of documents for selected candidates will be carried out by zonal authorities between April 9 and 22, while admissions in allotted schools will take place from April 9 to May 20.

The Directorate of Education (DoE) said candidates selected in the draw will be informed through SMS on their registered mobile numbers, along with details of the verification process.

The guidelines lay down a standard operating procedure for document verification, to be conducted by 29 zonal teams

under the supervision of district authorities. Applicants are required to upload mandatory documents on the online portal, including proof of date of birth, income certificate, ration card for EWS category, caste certificate for DG category, disability certificate for CWSN applicants, and proof of residence, it stated.

In case of discrepancies, candidates will be issued a deficiency memo and allowed to submit valid documents by May 2. A final opportunity for non-reported candidates to appear for verification will be provided between April 23 and April 28, the guideline read. The DoE said a reasoned order will be issued by the zonal authority after verification, with an appeal mechanism available before the District Admission Monitoring Committee between May 7 and May 12.

PTI

MCD clears 18K MT waste from tracks

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Municipal Corporation of Delhi has cleared 18,495 metric tonnes of waste from railway tracks across the city, covering nearly half of the 102.9-km stretch identified for a major sanitation drive, officials said on Sunday.

According to a statement, the clean-up, carried out in coordination with railway authorities, targeted 123 locations where garbage had accumulated over time due to indiscriminate dumping, posing sanitation concerns and affecting the city's image.

So far, around 49.74 km of railway track has been cleared, with the total waste burden initially estimated between 18,000 and 20,000 metric tonnes, the statement read.

Among the zones, Karol Bagh and Keshavpuram emerged as the top performers, each with 4,100 metric

KEY POINTS

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Officials said the operation involved the deployment of over 550 personnel and heavy machinery, including tippers, Hyva trucks, JCB machines, and refuse compactors.

At the Zakhira stretch in Karol Bagh, where waste removal was challenging due to a triangular convergence of railway lines, 20 railway wagons were deployed to facilitate large-scale evacuation, the statement read.

To prevent fresh dumping, 61 twin dustbins have been



installed along railway corridors, along with awareness campaigns, it added.

MCD Commissioner Sanjeev Khirwar said the drive aims not only to remove legacy waste but also to ensure long-term cleanliness through better infrastructure and public participation.

KEJRIWAL moves HC for Judge's recusal; May argue case himself

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: Aam Aadmi Party chief Arvind Kejriwal has filed an application before the Delhi High Court seeking recusal of Justice Swarana Kanta Sharma from hearing a plea related to the alleged excise policy scam.

The application pertains to a petition filed by the Central Bureau of Investigation challenging a trial court order that discharged Kejriwal and other accused in the case. The matter is expected to be taken up soon, with Kejriwal likely to appear in person and argue his case before the court.

Earlier, Kejriwal had approached the Chief Justice of the High Court on the administrative side, requesting that the case be transferred to another bench. However, the request was declined by the court registry. Following



this, he moved the Supreme Court of India seeking transfer of the case.

The recusal plea is based on concerns over impartiality. Kejriwal has cited "grave, bona fide, and reasonable apprehension" that the matter may not receive a neutral hearing. He also referred to earlier observa-

tions made by the judge during proceedings on the CBI's revision petition, where the trial court's findings were termed prima facie erroneous.

The controversy stems from the excise policy case linked to the now-scrapped 2021–22 liquor policy of the Delhi government. On Febru-

ary 27, a trial court discharged 23 accused, including Kejriwal, Manish Sisodia, and K. Kavitha, while also criticising the CBI's investigation.

The case has remained politically sensitive, particularly as Kejriwal was arrested in 2024 during the Lok Sabha election period and later granted bail after spending over five months in custody. Sisodia also spent over a year in jail before securing relief.

Investigations into the policy were initiated after allegations of irregularities surfaced, following which Delhi's then Lieutenant Governor Vinai Kumar Saxena recommended a CBI probe. Central agencies have alleged that the policy was designed to favour private entities, a claim consistently denied by AAP leaders. The High Court is now expected to decide on the recusal plea before proceeding further in the matter.

Vehicles break down due to water-contaminated petrol from fuel station

NOIDA: Several vehicle owners protested at a fuel station in Greater Noida after their cars and two-wheelers broke down allegedly after being refuelled with its water-contaminated petrol, police said on Sunday.

Preliminary inquiry suggested that rainwater had seeped into the petrol storage tank due to leakage in the pipeline, leading to contamination of fuel being dispensed to customers, according to the police.

The incident occurred at a petrol pump in Sector Pi-1 under the Beeta 2 police station limits on Saturday, when around 10 vehicles stalled after travelling a short distance post-refuelling, triggering protests by affected customers against the pump owner and staff.

"Vehicle owners complained about choking of vehicles due to water-mixed petrol," a police official at Beeta 2 Police Station said.

They returned to the petrol pump and lodged complaints

Preliminary inquiry suggested that rainwater had seeped into the petrol storage tank due to leakage in the pipeline: Police

with the staff and management.

According to the police, the situation was brought under control after their intervention and the agitating vehicle owners dispersed.

Staff at the petrol pump also claimed that the issue occurred due to a leakage in the tank, which allowed water to mix with petrol.

As many as four cars and six motorcycles were rendered inoperable due to the contaminated fuel. Mechanics were called to the spot and some vehicles were repaired, according to the police.

City Briefs

DELHI RECORDS HIGH OF 32.7 DEG C; AQI REMAINS 'MODERATE'

NEW DELHI: The maximum temperature in Delhi settled at 32.7 degrees Celsius on Sunday, 1.3 notches below the seasonal average, according to the India Meteorological Department. The minimum temperature was recorded at 20.1 degrees Celsius on Sunday, 1.3 notches below the average for the season, while the relative humidity stood at 46 per cent at 5.30 pm, the IMD said. The weather department has forecast a partly cloudy sky for Monday with the maximum and minimum temperatures expected to hover around 34 and 19 degrees Celsius, respectively. The air quality remained 'moderate' at 4 pm, with an AQI reading of 134, a slight drop from Saturday's 137, CPCB data showed.

MAN VIDEO CALLS GIRLFRIEND, HANGS HIMSELF TO DEATH ON CAMERA

FARIDABAD: A 28-year-old man hanged himself to death while on a video call with his girlfriend here on Sunday, police said. The deceased was identified as Nikhil, a resident of Jawahar Colony in Faridabad, they said. After being informed of the incident, police arrived at the spot, took the body into custody and sent it to Badshah Khan hospital for post-mortem, an officer said. According to police, Nikhil was in a relationship with a woman from Sanjay Colony for about five years.

WEST ASIA HAS BEEN MAJOR SOURCE OF INDIA'S ENERGY PROCUREMENT

West Asia crisis: Jaishankar speaks to Qatari PM, UAE foreign minister

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: External Affairs minister S Jaishankar spoke with Qatari Prime Minister Sheikh Mohammed bin Abdulrahman bin Jassim Al Thani on Sunday to discuss the West Asia conflict and its impact on global energy supplies.

The external affairs minister also held a phone conversation with the Foreign Minister of the United Arab Emirates, Sheikh Abdullah bin Zayed Al Nahyan.

Jaishankar's phone conversations with the Qatari prime minister and the UAE foreign minister came amid a spike in tensions in West Asia after US President Donald Trump renewed ultimatum to Tehran, threatening to destroy Iranian power plants and bridges if the Strait of Hormuz is not reopened for shipping.



External Affairs minister S Jaishankar

PTI

shipping.

"Had a telecon on the ongoing conflict with PM & FM @MBA_AlThani_of Qatar this evening," Jaishankar said on social media. Al Thani is also Qatar's foreign minister.

Following his talks with Al Nahyan, the external affairs minister, without sharing much details, said the evolving situation in West Asia was

discussed.

"Discussed the evolving situation in West Asia with DPM & FM @ABZayed of UAE," he said. Al Nahyan is also the deputy prime minister of the UAE.

Global oil and gas prices have surged after Iran virtually blocked the Strait of Hormuz, a narrow shipping lane between the Persian Gulf and the Gulf of Oman, that han-

Highlights

» Jaishankar's phone conversations with the Qatari prime minister and the UAE foreign minister came amid a spike in tensions in West Asia after US President Donald Trump renewed ultimatum to Tehran

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dles roughly 20 per cent of global oil and LNG (Liquefied Natural Gas).

West Asia has been a major source of India's energy procurement.

There have been growing global concerns over disruptions in commercial shipping through the Strait of Hormuz, with many leading powers pressing for the full reopening of the waterway.

Iran has allowed ships belonging to its friendly

countries, including India, to transit through the waterway.

In the last couple of weeks, India has made diplomatic efforts focusing on ending the conflict in West Asia as soon as possible and ensuring the unimpeded flow of energy through the Strait of Hormuz.

New Delhi thinks there could be serious ramifications for fuel and fertiliser security for many countries, including India, if the blockade of the shipping lane continues.

Chandigarh BJP office blast: Two main perpetrators arrested

Attack was backed by ISI, says Punjab DGP

OUR CORRESPONDENT

CHANDIGARH: Punjab Police has arrested two alleged perpetrators of a recent blast outside the BJP headquarters in Chandigarh, taking the total number of arrests in the case to seven, a senior police officer said on Sunday.

The accused were allegedly part of a module backed by Pakistan's Inter-Services Intelligence (ISI), and were taking directions from their handlers in Germany and Portugal, police said.

The latest arrests were made in Haryana's Rewari on Saturday night in a joint operation with Haryana Police's Special Task Force (STF), Punjab DGP Gaurav Yadav said.

"The duo has been identified as Gurtej Singh and Amanpreet Singh, both residents of Ratangarh village in Punjab's Rupnagar district. They were working as bike operators for ride-hailing service provider Rapido," the police chief said at a press conference.



National Investigation Agency officials inspect the site after a blast outside the Punjab BJP headquarters, in Chandigarh PTI

ISI-backed handlers, Baljot Singh alias Jot in Portugal and Harjeet Singh Laadi in Germany, motivated the accused to carry out the attack in exchange for a monetary reward of Rs 2 lakh, the DGP said.

On April 1, a blast occurred outside the Punjab BJP headquarters in Chandigarh's Sector 37 around 5 pm, shattering the windowpanes of a few cars and damaging a scooter. There were no casualties.

Police initially suspected it to be a crude bomb attack, which later turned out to be a

hand grenade explosion.

"Amanpreet was previously involved in a theft case in Mohali. He was also booked for snatching in Himachal's Bilaspur," the DGP said at the presser.

According to police, Gurtej came in contact with Portugal-based Baljot Singh, the main handler of the module, six months ago through social media.

"On March 28, Gurtej was tasked with collecting a consignment of grenades and other weapons from Balachaur in Punjab's Nawanshahr," the DGP said.

The consignment was collected by Gurtej, Mandeep and Rubal Chauhan from Jasvir Singh alias Jassi. It contained two grenades, one pistol and 10 cartridges, the officer said.

Mandeep, Rubal and Jasvir were among the five people arrested in the case earlier.

"Baltoj tasked Gurtej with target identification and conducting a recce. Amanpreet was roped in by Gurtej," Yadav said.

About 71 lakh Ladki Bahin beneficiaries disqualified, says Sena (UBT) leader

OUR CORRESPONDENT

PUNE: Shiv Sena (UBT) leader Sushma Andhare claimed 71 lakh women have been disqualified from Maharashtra government's flagship Mukhyamantri Ladki Bahin Yojana, under which beneficiaries get Rs 1,500 as monthly aid. Addressing a news conference on Saturday, Andhare said Women and Child Development Minister Aditi Tatkare should first explain why 71 lakh women were disqualified.

She claimed these 71 lakh women were paid a cumulative sum of Rs 255.60 crore since the scheme began ahead of the assembly polls in late 2024 and asked who will compensate for

the loss suffered by the state exchequer.

Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis, Deputy Chief Minister Eknath Shinde and Aditi Tatkare should respond to this, Andhare said.

Why shouldn't a fraud case be registered against them, she asked while alleging that public money was used to lure voters and win polls.

Around 68 lakh accounts under Ladki Bahin Yojana were closed after beneficiaries failed to complete the mandatory e-KYC process before the deadline, reducing the number of active accounts to about 1.75 crore, state government officials had said on Wednesday.

Haryana State Anaj Mandi Arhtiya Association meets CM

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Sunday met a delegation of the Haryana State Anaj Mandi Arhtiya Association at the PWD Rest House in Jind and discussed various issues related to public interest and trade.

During the meeting, representatives of the Arhtiya association placed their demands and suggestions regarding the crop procurement process before the Chief Minister.

The Chief Minister listened to their concerns carefully and assured that the procurement process in the state would be

conducted in a smooth, transparent and well-organised manner.

The Chief Minister said that dedicated efforts are being made to ensure smooth procurement of crop. He directed officers concerned to ensure that all necessary arrangements in mandis are made in a timely manner so that both farmers and Arhtiyas do not encounter any difficulties.

He said the state government is fully committed to protecting the interests of both farmers and Arhtiyas, adding that ensuring smooth functioning and ease for all stakeholders involved in the procurement process remains a priority.

RS polls cross-voting: Haryana Cong disciplinary panel recommends suspension of 5 MLAs

OUR CORRESPONDENT

CHANDIGARH: Haryana Congress' Disciplinary Action Committee (DAC) recommended suspension of the five party MLAs who allegedly cross-voted during last month's Rajya Sabha elections.

After the committee met here on Friday evening, its chairman, Dharampal Malik, had told mediapersons that the panel would prepare a report and convey its decision to the party high command concerning the issue of alleged cross-voting by five party MLAs in favour of BJP-backed Independent candidate Satish Nandal.

According to party sources on Sunday, the committee has recommended suspension of

the legislators after examining their responses to show-cause notices.

Earlier, the Congress issued a show-cause notice to its five legislators from Haryana for alleged cross-voting.

The showcause was served for "anti-party activities by deliberately not casting a vote in favour of Congress's official candidate..." Polling for the two Rajya Sabha seats in Haryana was held on March 16.

BJP's Sanjay Bhatia won a seat comfortably, while the Congress candidate, Karamvir Singh Boudh, secured the second seat in a close contest against Independent candidate Satish Nandal.

The alleged cross-voting by five Congress MLAs dented the

otherwise comfortable position of the party for securing an easy victory. Four of the Congress's votes were also declared invalid during counting.

The party had named five legislators – Naraingarh MLA Shalli Chaudhary, Sadhaura MLA Renu Bala, Punhana MLA Mohammad Ilyas, Hathin MLA Mohammad Israil and Ratia legislator Jarnail Singh suspected of defying the official line.

Shalli Chaudhary, Renu Bala and Jarnail Singh had later denied the allegations, saying their names were being dragged into the controversy unnecessarily and maintained that they had voted for the party candidate.

When contacted over the

phone on Sunday, Dharampal Malik, without going into the specifics of what has been recommended by the DAC, said, "We have sent our report to State president Rao Narendra Singh, party general secretary in charge B K Hariprasad and party senior leader K C Venugopal".

"We have explained the situation and given complete details of the circumstances from the very beginning to the end. We finalised our report, and a decision (on what action is to be taken against the five MLAs) will be taken by the party," Malik told news agency.

Earlier, only Chaudhary, Bala and Jarnail Singh replied to the show-cause notice.

From Page 1 Trump says

Meanwhile, a US Air Force officer whose jet was shot down in Iran hid in a mountain crevice and hiked up to 7,000 feet to evade the enemy before he was rescued by the American forces after a two-day "life-or-death" mission, the New York Times said. On Sunday, President Trump called an "amazing show of bravery and talent" by all the rescue operation for the pilot for whom the Iranian regime had offered a reward.

"We have rescued the seriously wounded, and really brave, F-15 crew member/officer from deep inside the mountains of Iran. The Iranian Military was looking hard, in big numbers, and getting close," Trump said in a post on Truth Social, calling the rescued crew as "a highly respected Colonel."

A senior US administration official said that prior to locating the pilot, the CIA spread word inside Iran that US forces had found him and were moving him on the ground for exfiltration, confusing Iranian officials. The official spoke on the condition of anonymity to discuss details not yet made public.

The fighter jet was the first known American aircraft to crash in Iranian territory since the US and Israel launched the war with strikes on Iran on Feb 28. Iran's Revolutionary Guards claimed responsibility for attacks on petrochemical plants in the UAE, Kuwait, Israel and Bahrain.

In a statement, the IRGC warned its attacks against US economic interests would be intensified if attacks on civilian targets in Iran are repeated.

Iranian drone attacks hit various targets in Kuwait on, with state energy company, Kuwait Petroleum Corporation, reporting fires and "severe material damage" at some operating units.

Iran's military on Sunday said that the US operation to rescue a missing airman from a downed American fighter jet, used an abandoned airport in southern Isfahan province.

"The so-called US military rescue operation, planned as a deception and escape mission at an abandoned airport in southern Isfahan under the pretext of recovering the pilot of a downed aircraft, was completely foiled," claimed Ebrahim Zolfaghari, spokesman for the military's central command, Khatam Al-Anbiya.

Iran said that it had shot down two C-130 aircraft and also destroyed several "flying objects" during a US operation aimed at locating a stranded airman.

Meanwhile, authorities in Abu Dhabi are responding to multiple fires that broke out at the Borouge Petrochemicals Factory after debris fell following successful interceptions.

Oman's Foreign Ministry said that deputy foreign ministers and experts from Iran and Oman met to discuss proposals to ensure "smooth transit" through the strait. Oman has often served as a mediator between the US and Iran.

Egypt said that Foreign Minister Badr Abdelatty had spoken by phone with US envoy Steve Witkoff and Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi, as well as with Turkish and Pakistani counterparts who are helping to mediate.

Pakistan's Foreign Ministry said it had conveyed to Araghchi that Islamabad supports "all efforts aimed at de-escalation." Islamabad has said that it would soon host talks between the US and Iran.

An escalation, however, could see Iranian-backed Houthi rebels in Yemen resuming attacks on vessels in the Bab el-Mandeb strait, a key waterway to and from the Suez Canal.

In Kuwait, Iranian drone attacks caused significant damage to power plants and a petrochemical plant. They also put a water desalination station out of service, according to the Ministry of Electricity.

Meanwhile, more than 1,900 people have been killed in Iran since the war began. In Gulf Arab states and the occupied West Bank, more than two dozen people have died, while 19 have been reported dead in Israel and 13 US service members have been killed. In Lebanon, more than 1,400 people have been killed and more than 1 million people have been displaced. Ten Israeli soldiers have died there.

Govt steps up LPG supply

of total demand. "There are no reports of shortages at LPG distributor points," the ministry said, adding that distribution systems have been strengthened with delivery authentication improving from 53 per cent in February to around 90 per cent now.

To further regulate consumption, LPG refill intervals have been extended to 25 days in urban areas

and up to 45 days in rural regions. Domestic LPG and piped natural gas supplies have been prioritised for households and essential services such as hospitals and educational institutions. At the same time, commercial LPG allocations have been capped at 70 per cent of pre-crisis levels, with 78,833 metric tonnes supplied since mid-March.

Enforcement agencies have intensified action against hoarding and black marketing. Since March, more than 50,000 LPG cylinders have been seized during joint inspections, while over 1,400 show-cause notices have been issued to distributors. So far, 36 LPG dealerships have been suspended for irregularities.

To reduce dependence on LPG, alternative fuels such as kerosene and coal are being deployed. The government has allocated an additional 48,000 kilolitres of kerosene to states and union territories, along with revised guidelines allowing limited storage at designated fuel stations. Efforts are also underway to expand the use of cleaner fuels through city gas distribution networks. Since March, about 3.6 lakh piped natural gas connections have been activated, with another 3.9 lakh registrations in progress.

On the natural gas front, authorities said full supplies are being maintained for households and transport, including 100 per cent allocation for PNG and CNG segments. Supply to fertiliser plants is expected to increase to around 90 per cent of recent average consumption from April 6, supported by incoming liquefied natural gas cargoes, while industrial and commercial allocations are set to rise by about 10 per cent.

Beyond domestic energy management, the government is also monitoring maritime operations and the safety of Indian nationals in the region. The Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways said shipping activity remains normal, with no incidents reported involving Indian-flagged vessels in the past 24 hours. Seventeen Indian vessels carrying 460 seafarers are currently operating in the western Persian Gulf, under close observation. A control room set up by the Directorate General of Shipping has handled more than 5,000 calls and over 10,500 emails since it became operational. Authorities have repatriated 1,479 Indian seafarers so far, including 159 in the last 24 hours.

Efforts to assist Indian citizens abroad are also ongoing. The Ministry of External Affairs confirmed that 345 Indian fishermen stranded in Iran have returned home via Armenia. Indian missions across the region are maintaining contact with local communities, providing consular assistance, travel support and safety advisories. Air connectivity to India is gradually stabilising, with around 7.02 lakh passengers having returned since February 28. While flights continue to operate from countries such as Saudi Arabia and Oman, routes from Iran, Israel and Iraq are being managed through alternative transit points.

Officials said a central control room continues to coordinate with state governments and overseas missions to ensure timely responses to emerging issues. Reiterating its advisory, the government called on citizens to conserve energy and avoid unnecessary consumption, stating that cooperation from the public remains critical to maintaining stability during the ongoing situation.

Cong alleges

"However, the documents we are presenting before you today pertain to matters extending beyond India's borders," Khera said.

"Riniki Bhuyan Sharma, the wife of the Assam Chief Minister, holds three passports," he alleged. Khera claimed that she has a UAE Passport, which was issued on March 14, 2022 and expires on March 13, 2027.

He claimed the second passport in her name is from Antigua and Barbuda, which was issued from August 26, 2021, and expires on August 25, 2031. Khera also alleged that the third passport in her name is from Egypt which was issued on February 13, 2022 and expires on February 12, 2029. "Himanta Biswa Sarma's entire politics is predicated on hatred against Muslims; yet, his wife holds passports from two Muslim countries?" Khera alleged.

Rejecting Khera's claims, Riniki Bhuyan Sharma said she will take legal action against him.

"I expected a spokesperson of a national party to exercise basic due diligence, rather than circulate poorly fabricated images of imaginary passports and documents. I will now be letting the law take over. Criminal charges are being initiated. We can continue this in court," she said on X.

Khera also alleged that Sarma's wife owns two properties in Dubai. Why did he fail to disclose his wife's Dubai properties in his affidavit, the Congress leader asked.

Khera also alleged that Sarma's wife owns a company based in Wyo-

ming, USA. The list of members for this company includes the names of the couple and their son, he claimed. "Himanta Biswa Sarma has stashed his money in Wyoming by setting up shell companies," he alleged. He further charged that the stashed away amount in such shell company was worth Rs. 52,000 crores.

Home Minister Amit Shah must answer as to whether he will constitute an SIT to investigate these matters, Khera said. "When will CEC Gyanesh Kumar take cognisance of the concealment of information in the affidavit?" he said "I categorically reject every allegation made by him. These are malicious, fabricated, and politically motivated lies aimed at misleading the people of Assam," Sarma said on X. "We remain focused, determined, and confident of securing a decisive mandate of more than 100 seats from the people," Sarma said. The BJP leader said the truth will prevail and those spreading misinformation will be held accountable.

PM Modi

introduce a bill to increase Lok Sabha seats from 543 to 816, a move linked to implementing the women's reservation law.

Addressing concerns about seat redistribution, Modi said states that have effectively controlled population growth would not lose representation. "Everyone will benefit. The participation and rights of all states will remain protected," he said.

With women forming a decisive voting bloc in West Bengal, the Prime Minister urged them to press political parties to support the legislation unanimously. According to Election Commission data, women voters number about 3.44 crore compared to 3.60 crore men, within a total electorate of 7.04 crore.

Women voters have been central to Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee's electoral success, supported by welfare schemes such as Lakshmi Bhandar, Kanyashree and Swasthya Sathi. The BJP, which has gained among male and younger voters, has increasingly focused on women-centric issues in its campaign. At the rally, Modi reiterated this approach. "Our Bengal is the land of the worship of Shakti... the BJP is in the field for your honour and prosperity," he said.

Polling for the 294-member West Bengal Assembly will be held on April 23 and April 29, with counting scheduled for May 4.

IMD warns of ...

Continued from Page 1

Andhra Pradesh, Telangana and Karnataka are also expected to witness thunderstorms and gusty winds over the next five days. Isolated heavy rainfall is likely over ghat areas of Tamil Nadu, coastal Andhra Pradesh and Kerala on April 5 and 6.

In north India, unstable weather conditions are expected to persist. Himachal Pradesh and Uttarakhand are likely to receive light to moderate rainfall or snowfall along with thunderstorms and gusty winds on April 5 and 6. Uttar Pradesh may see similar activity on April 5, followed by Punjab and Rajasthan on April 6, with wind speeds potentially gusting up to 60 kmph.

The IMD had earlier issued an orange warning for multiple states including Punjab, Haryana, Uttarakhand, Himachal Pradesh, Uttar Pradesh, Rajasthan, Maharashtra and Chhattisgarh, forecasting widespread thunderstorms, lightning, hailstorms and winds reaching 60 to 70 kmph over a 24-hour period.

The impact of the ongoing system has already been severe in some areas. In Madhya Pradesh's Bhind district, intense storms accompanied by heavy rain and large hailstones killed at least six people and injured several others, including local councillor Pooja Kushwah. Fields and roads were covered with thick layers of hail, causing extensive damage in rural areas. The storms, triggered by a western disturbance, brought lemon and chickpea-sized hail along with strong winds and lightning across parts of the state.

The influence of the weather system is also being felt in the Delhi-NCR region, where isolated thunderstorms with rain and hail are likely, particularly in areas such as Gurgaon, South Delhi, Faridabad and Noida. Meteorologists estimate a 50 to 70 per cent probability of such activity, although a significant portion of the region may remain dry. The lingering effects of a recent disturbance have led to unusually cool conditions and heavy cloud cover for this time of year.

Meteorologists have cautioned that the current spell is only a precursor to a more intense system expected to arrive shortly.

A stronger western disturbance is forecast to impact the plains between April 7 and 10, bringing heavier rain, widespread thunderstorms and large hail across Rajasthan, Delhi-NCR, Haryana, Uttarakhand, Himachal Pradesh, Jammu, Punjab, western Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, Jharkhand, northern Madhya Pradesh and parts of northeast India. This system could affect nearly 30 to 40 per cent of the country's land area.

Agricultural regions are particularly vulnerable. Farmers in several northern states have been advised to harvest ready wheat crops before April 6 to minimise losses. Earlier this week, golf ball-sized hailstones flattened standing crops across Rajasthan, Punjab, Haryana and Uttar Pradesh, raising concerns about further damage from the incoming system.

In Himachal Pradesh, the higher reaches have already witnessed fresh snowfall. Gondla in Lahaul and Spiti recorded 28.2 cm of snow, while Keylong received 20 cm. Rainfall was also recorded across multiple locations, including 23.5 mm in Sarahan and over 18 mm in Dharamshala and Sundernagar. Hailstorms and thunderstorms were reported in several districts, with gusty winds reaching up to 48 kmph. Authorities have issued an orange alert for April 7 and 8 in districts including Chamba, Kangra, Kullu, Mandi and Shimla.

Rajasthan has also reported rain and thunderstorm activity in both eastern and western regions, with Bari in Dholpur district receiving 40 mm of rainfall. The Jaipur Meteorological Centre has warned of fresh spells of storms, rain and hail between April 6 and 8, with peak intensity expected on April 7. Wind speeds could reach 50 to 60 kmph, accompanied by moderate to heavy rainfall and isolated hailstorms across several divisions. Weather officials have advised farmers to take precautions such as covering harvested crops and safeguarding stored grains to reduce potential losses. Conditions are expected to stabilise after April 8 to 10, with forecasts indicating a return to dry and significantly hotter weather across much of the country in the latter half of April.

SAYS THAT KERALA WILL GET ITS FIRST AIIMS

Shah reaches out to Christians; seeks support to form govt in Kerala

OUR CORRESPONDENT

KOCHI/THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: Union Home minister Amit Shah on Sunday reached out to the Christian community on the occasion of Easter, requesting them to stand with the BJP-led NDA and help it form a government in Kerala where Assembly elections will be held on April 9.

Shah, speaking at a public meeting in Kunnathunadu constituency in Ernakulam, also referred to the alleged misappropriation of gold from Sabarimala and said the culprits behind it would be jailed within two months if the NDA forms a government in Kerala.

He also said that Kerala will get its first AIIMS and it will be operational within two years of an NDA government coming in the state.

The Union Home minister also attacked Congress leader Rahul Gandhi, calling him a



Union Home minister Amit Shah during a roadshow ahead of the Kerala Assembly election, in Kozhikode, Kerala PTI

“liar” and took a dig at Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan, claiming that the Marxist veteran has begun a ‘name change startup’ whereby he changes the names of centrally sponsored schemes and projects to take credit.

He made similar allegations and claims at the public meeting in Kattakada in Thiruvanantha-

puram district in the evening.

Campaigning for the BJP-led NDA, Shah, on the occasion of Easter, wished the Christian community and requested them to stand with the NDA.

“I appeal to my brothers and sisters in the Christian community to stand with the NDA and help form a prosperous Kerala,” he said. His appeal comes amidst

Highlights

» Campaigning for the BJP-led NDA, Shah, on the occasion of Easter, wished the Christian community and requested them to stand with the NDA

» Shah said that when the PFI allegedly started doing anti-India activities, ‘within one day we put all their cadres behind bars’

concerns among the Christian community with regard to the recent amendments proposed by the Centre in the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Act (FCRA).

He further said that the NDA stand was “justice for all and appeasement of none” and this was evident in the work they are doing across India.

‘After taking money, BJP asking where money is going’

THIRUMANGALAM/ VIRUDHUNAGAR: Launching a scathing attack on the BJP-led Centre, Tamil Nadu Chief Minister M K Stalin on Sunday accused the BJP of harbouring “hatred” toward the state by “consistently depriving” it of its fair share of tax revenue.

“After taking our money, you ask us where the money is going; is this fair? It is like pinching the baby and rocking the cradle,” Stalin said during a campaign rally at Thirumangalam near Madurai.

While campaigning in Tamil Nadu on April 4, Union Minister Piyush Goyal sounded an alarm bell that “Tamil Nadu is going to go bankrupt”, if the DMK continued to rule.

However, Stalin asserted that if Tamil Nadu received



Tamil Nadu Chief Minister MK Stalin addresses a public meeting, in Virudhunagar, Sunday PTI

funding parity with northern states, its debt would be cleared immediately.

He challenged Goyal to publicly disclose the return-on-investment for every rupee Tamil Nadu contributes to the Union compared to BJP-ruled northern states like Uttar Pradesh and Bihar.

Dismissing Goyal’s claims

that the state was heading toward bankruptcy as a “lack of understanding,” Stalin said that government funds go directly to the people through various welfare schemes.

He further contrasted his “Dravidian Model” of religious harmony against the NDA’s “Aryan Model”, which he claimed seeks to divide people and turn “Madurai into Manipur”.

Earlier in the day, speaking in Virudhunagar, CM Stalin called the DMK’s election manifesto the “superstar of the 2026 polls”.

He said, “From age six to 60, from women to men, from youth to the elderly -- everyone likes the DMK election manifesto. There cannot be anyone who dislikes it.”

“I introduced this as the superstar of the 2026 electoral field,” Stalin told the crowd here, noting that its appeal spans all demographics.

He emphasised that the credibility of a promise depends on who makes it and said, “Whoever wants to can make a promise. But people only believe the promise given by the DMK. Whatever others say, there is no value to it.”

Stalin, who is also DMK president, detailed several ‘superstar’ highlights, most notably the ‘Ilaltharasi’ (Homemaker) scheme.

The CM described this as an “ultimate announcement” involving a Rs 8,000 coupon for women to purchase household appliances. MPOST

Like Zubeen Garg, Congress works to unite people: Rahul in Assam

BISWANATH CHARIALI/ GOLAGHAT: Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Sunday said the philosophy of his party is that of the celebrated musician Zubeen Garg, who worked his entire life to unite Assam.

Addressing election rallies in Biswanath and Golaghat districts, he alleged that Himanta Biswa Sarma is the “most corrupt CM” in India, and action will be taken against him after the Congress forms a government in the state.

“Zubeen Garg worked his entire life to unite people of Assam; he never misbehaved with anyone. The Congress philosophy is also like that, to spread love against hatred,” Gandhi said.

He alleged that the BJP government led by Sarma is spreading hatred against people and communities.

“Let him speak for some



Lok Sabha Leader of Opposition and Congress MP Rahul Gandhi, left, addresses a public meeting ahead of Assam Assembly Election PTI

more days. After that, the Congress will form a government in Assam, and legal action will follow even if he asks for forgiveness. The Congress government will put him in jail for 10-15 years,” Gandhi said.

The Congress leader alleged Sarma, along with Prime Minister Narendra

Modi and Union Home minister Amit Shah, has created a “land ATM” to snatch land from the public to give it to a few big industrialists.

He said not only Sarma but corruption allegations against his family will be investigated, and action will be taken accordingly.

Gandhi claimed that three big corporate houses have been handed over a total of 98,400 bighas of land in Assam.

“It is a land-grabbing syndicate in Assam. But they don’t get land for free. These corporates are the financing machine of the BJP,” he alleged.

Raking up India’s trade pact with the US, the leader of the Opposition in Lok Sabha claimed it is a loss for New Delhi as taxes on American goods were lowered and the Indian market was opened to them. MPOST

AAP foot march; Sanjay Singh slams govt for unemployment

HATHRAS: Aam Aadmi Party’s “Rozgar Do, Samajik Nyay Do” foot march reached Hathras on Sunday, where it accused the Central government of diverting attention from core issues such as employment, education and social justice.

The fourth leg of the statewide protest march, led by Rajya Sabha MP and AAP’s Uttar Pradesh in-charge Sanjay Singh, began in Agra on April 3 and is scheduled to end in Mathura on April 9.

Talking to reporters, Singh criticised the BJP and Prime Minister Narendra Modi, alleging that efforts were being made to spread hatred in the name of caste and religion instead of addressing pressing concerns. AGENCIES

SIR: Out of 60 lakh adjudications, 57 lakh adjudicated; over 25 lakh deleted

OUR CORRESPONDENT

KOLKATA: Over 25 lakh voters have been deleted from the rolls following scrutiny by judicial officers, even as Bengal Chief Electoral Officer Manoj Agarwal on Sunday visited sensitive pockets of Nandigram in East Midnapore to assess the ground situation firsthand ahead of the polls.

According to Election Commission sources, the deletions were part of a large-scale verification exercise, with affected electors allowed to seek redressal before the tribunal.

Officials said that of the 60 lakh cases under adjudication, 57 lakh had been disposed of till Saturday, while around 3 lakh cases are expected to be cleared by Monday.

Eleven supplementary electoral rolls have already been published.

The CEO, who reached East Midnapore on Saturday afternoon, began his field visit

Key Points

» According to Election Commission sources, the deletions were part of a large-scale verification exercise

» Affected electors have been allowed to seek redressal before the tribunal

» Eleven supplementary electoral rolls have already been published by the Election Commission

A day earlier, Agarwal had held a marathon meeting with the district’s top administrative and police officials.

Sunday’s visit followed that review, with a focus on confidence-building measures in areas identified as sensitive.

“We will ensure that people do not carry any fear or anxiety in their minds. I will personally visit every place where disturbances had occurred or where there is a possibility of trouble, and I will speak to the common people,” Agarwal said.

For the first phase of elections scheduled across 152 Assembly constituencies on April 23, the last date for filing nominations is March 6 till 3 pm.

The electoral rolls for this phase will also freeze at that time.

Meanwhile, uncertainty over the candidature of Congress nominee Motab Shaikh from Farakka was resolved after the SIR Tribunal ruled in his favour.

While discrepancies were found in records linked to the applicant and his father, the tribunal held there was no legal bar in his own name.

As per the directions of the appellate tribunal, his name is to be included in the supplementary list by 8 pm on Sunday, enabling him to file his nomination on Monday.

Reacting to the development, Trinamool Congress leader Arup Chakraborty questioned whether it would be feasible to adjudicate each of the 25 lakh deleted voters within such a limited timeframe.

“While the case of the Congress candidate may have been treated as a special instance, the pertinent question remains: is it at all feasible to individually adjudicate the cases of each of the 25 lakh deleted voters within such a limited timeframe?” he said.

He further alleged that the exercise was aimed at disenfranchising legitimate voters.

Weapon of mass distraction: Cong slams govt’s delimitation proposal

‘Nation facing serious economic, foreign policy crisis’

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Congress launched a scathing attack on the Modi government on Sunday over its delimitation proposal related to the implementation of the women’s reservation law, saying it will benefit larger and populous states more and is nothing but a “weapon of mass distraction”.

The Opposition party also alleged that Prime Minister Narendra Modi is “hoodwinking” people by claiming that the strength of the southern states in the Lok Sabha will not go down under the proposed changes as the gap in the number of seats between the more populous states and others will increase.

In a post on X, Congress general secretary in-charge communications Jairam

Closer Look

» This is hoodwinking the people of country in which the PM has unique expertise, said Ramesh

» ‘It is not just south India but states like Punjab and Haryana and those in the northeast that will also see their relative influence decline’

Ramesh said, “The PM is up to his usual tricks of making misleading statements that are meant to deceive. He says South Indian states will not be hurt in any way if the strength of the Lok Sabha is increased by 50 per cent and the number of seats of each state in the Lok Sabha is also increased by 50 per cent.”

“This is hoodwinking the

people of the country in which the PM has unique expertise,” he said.

For example, the difference between Uttar Pradesh’s and Kerala’s seats in the Lok Sabha is now 60 and Modi’s proposal will increase it to 90, he said.

Similarly, the difference between Uttar Pradesh and Tamil Nadu will increase from 41 to at least 61, Ramesh said, adding that such examples can be multiplied.

“Mr. Modi is bulldozing a proposal that will work more to the benefit of larger and populous states since their already large numbers will get further magnified,” the Congress leader said.

It is not just south India but states like Punjab and Haryana and those in the northeast that will also see their relative influence decline, he argued.

Format C-7

(for political parties to publish in the newspapers, social media platforms & website of the party)

Information regarding individuals with pending criminal cases, who

have been selected as candidates, along with the reasons for such selection, as also as to why other individuals without criminal antecedents could not be selected as candidates

(As per the Commission’s directions issued in pursuance of the Order dated 13.02.2020 of the Hon’ble Supreme Court in contempt petition (C) no. 2192 of 2018 in WP(C) No. 536 of 2011)

Name of Political Party: ALL INDIA TRINAMOOOL CONGRESS

*Name of the Election: GENERAL ELECTION TO THE LEGISLATIVE ASSEMBLY OF WEST BENGAL 2026

Name of State/UT: WEST BENGAL

(1) Name of the Constituency - 57- Suti Assembly Constituency

(2) Name of the candidate – Emani Biswas

Sl.no.		
1.	Criminal antecedents	
i)	a.	Nature of the offences
		Offences alleged under: Sections 143/186/323/325/506 of IPC, 1860.
	b.	Case no.
		GR. No. 769/2013, (in connection with FIR No. 181/2013dated 02.05.2013, Suti Police Station)
	c.	Name of the Court
		Learned A.C.J.M, Jangipur Court (Murshidabad)
	d.	Whether charges have been framed or not (Yes/No)
2.	e.	Date of conviction, if any
		Not Applicable
	f.	Details of punishment undergone, if any
		Not Applicable
	g.	Any other information required to be given
		Not Applicable
3.	The reasons for the selection of the candidate. Selection shall be with reference to the qualifications, achievements and merit of the candidate, and not mere “winnability” at the polls (not more than 100 words)	
	The candidate has a strong connection with the local community and has been actively involved in addressing public issues and concerns at the grassroots level. His conduct reflects responsibility, integrity, and awareness of public needs. The disclosures made in the affidavit are complete and in compliance with legal requirements, indicating transparency in public life. His continued engagement with people and understanding of constituency matters reflects his capability to represent the interests of the electorate effectively. The decision is based on hispublic involvement, credibility, and overall suitability for legislative responsibilities.	
3.	Reasons as to why other individuals without criminal antecedents could not be selected as candidates (not more than 100 words)	
	Same as above.	

(3) Name of the Constituency – 57- SUTI ASSEMBLY CONSTITUENCY

(4) Name of the candidate: Emani Biswas

* In the case of election to Council of States or States or election to Legislative Council by MLAs, mention the election concerned in place of name of Constituency.

Signature of office bearer of the Political Party
Name and Designation

Derek O’Brien
National Working Committee Member
All India Trinamool Congress

OPEN TO TALKS WITH GOVT

Wangchuk justifies Ladakh agitation, urges ‘sincere’ talks

MPOST BUREAU

KARGIL: Activist Sonam Wangchuk on Sunday defended the agitation for statehood and safeguards under the Sixth Schedule for Ladakh, and said he would not back out from joining talks with the government if the need for it arises.

Addressing a press conference, Wangchuk, who was released on March 14 after nearly six months of detention under the National Security Act, called for “open-minded and sincere” negotiations and striking a middle path.

He also expressed hope that the ongoing protests would lead to a positive and amicable solution.

“The demand for safeguards under the Sixth Schedule and statehood is based on democratic rights entailed in the Constitution and is completely legitimate. I have always maintained that for the last 5-6 years, we have been engaged in discussions with the government on these issues, yet no solution has emerged. This is because the other side seems to have adopted a rigid stance,” Wangchuk told reporters here.

He stressed that the negotiations should be held with an open mind, in all sincerity.

“Neither side should insist ‘we alone will win and you will lose’. What is needed is a middle path, a win-win approach. This is what I personally believe and have conveyed to many people, including the (agitating) leaders: the negotiations should move forward gradually,” he said.

Wangchuk said they were ready to adopt such an



HIGHLIGHTS

- » He expressed hope that the ongoing protests would lead to a positive and amicable solution
- » He stressed that the negotiations should be held with an open mind, in all sincerity

approach, but it should not be one-sided. He said the protesters have conveyed this thinking to fair-minded people across the country, and cautioned that if the upcoming talks once again result in their concerns being overlooked and only the other side’s position prevails, it would prompt questions on why a more accommodative approach – like that adopted by Ladakh’s leaders -- is not being followed.

The government has not yet announced the date for the next round of talks.

The Ladakh-based activist expressed hope that the ongoing protests would lead to a positive and amicable resolution, enabling them to move forward and partake in the country’s progress and nation-building.

Asked about charges under the National Security Act (NSA) that were levelled against him, he said, “If a person like me, who has always worked for the country -- whether in education, environment, or improving facilities for the armed forces -- can face such allegations, then what might not be said about others, not just in Ladakh but elsewhere as well?”

The activist said he was disturbed by a video related to his arrest that he came across recently, questioning how such claims could be made, especially as the contents “appeared” to be backed by evidence.

“If the allegations are true, I did not deserve to be free. But if they are false, they must be clearly refuted,” Wangchuk said, cautioning against making sweeping accusations about Ladakh, which has been a pillar of India’s defence, especially Kargil, whose people have supported the armed forces in every war and made significant sacrifices in the 1999 Kargil War. Making such allegations will only create distance among people, he said, adding, “If mistakes are being made, they should be corrected.”

SP pivots to ‘digital battleground’ ahead of 2027 UP Assembly polls

Party ropes in influencers & I-PAC to strengthen campaign

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

LUCKNOW: The Samajwadi Party has sharpened its focus on the digital space ahead of the 2027 Uttar Pradesh assembly elections, rolling out a structured strategy that seeks to counter the Bharatiya Janata Party’s dominance on social media and reshape political messaging at the grassroots level.

Led by party chief Akhilesh Yadav, the initiative centres on building a network of social media influencers, creating an in-house media ecosystem and ensuring tighter control over content. The effort signals a shift in the party’s campaign style as electoral politics in the state increasingly plays out online.

The strategy came into focus

during a ‘Digital Democracy Dialogue’ organised in Lucknow on March 18, where nearly 200 YouTubers and social media influencers were invited. A significant number of participants were regional content creators working in Awadhi, Bhojpuri and Bundeli, with the party banking on their deeper connect with rural and semi-urban audiences.

At the interaction, Akhilesh Yadav urged content creators to prioritise factual and responsible communication, cautioning against sensationalism. Party sources said around 250 influencers are being identified and gradually integrated into a coordinated outreach network.

The party’s changing media approach is also visible in its press

interactions, where digital creators are increasingly being given prominence alongside traditional media organisations.

The party has also engaged I-PAC to strengthen its campaign. The consultancy firm is expected to assist with data-driven strategies, messaging and targeted voter engagement.

As part of its digital push, the SP has launched ‘Samajwadi Party TV’ on YouTube and is also working to develop a ‘digital cadre’.

During the March 18 meeting, influencers raised concerns about possible administrative action over critical content. Party leaders assured them of support, including legal assistance, provided their content remains factual and responsible.

FEARS OF ‘REGULAR SURVEILLANCE’

Begging, sex work, forced into oblivion: Activists warn amended Trans law could reverse progress

NEW DELHI: The amended transgender law has triggered fears of “regular surveillance” among members of the community, with many worrying that they could be repeatedly subjected to scrutiny, harassment, and even stripping in the name of verification.

For many transgender persons, activists say, the anxiety is not limited to appearing before a medical board for certification. They fear that with self-identification now abolished under the amended law, they could be forced to repeatedly “prove” their gender identity before police, employers, hospitals and other authorities.

The Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Amendment Bill, 2026, was passed by Parliament on March 25 and received President Droupadi Murmu’s assent on March 30.

Ritu, a non-binary transfeminine person, said the law could subject transgender persons to scrutiny and harassment at every stage of life. “Not just the medical panel, but also the way it criminalises trans

KEY POINTS

- » The Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Amendment Bill, 2026, was passed by Parliament on March 25 and received President Droupadi Murmu’s assent on March 30
- » Ritu, a non-binary transfeminine person,



said the law could subject transgender persons to scrutiny and harassment at every stage of life

folks -- they could be stripped or harassed by police,” she said. “Any day, someone can challenge your identity at work, in a hospital or elsewhere. This is not a one-time process; it is a regular surveillance that the community has faced for centuries,” she said.

A top government functionary, however, defended the new certification process, arguing that self-identification could be misused and that some form of verification is necessary. “Imagine someone having raped a woman and telling the police that he is a self-declared trans-

gender and therefore he can’t rape,” the government functionary said.

Speaking to PTI, Laxmi Narayan Tripathi, the first transgender person from the Asia-Pacific region to address the United Nations General Assembly, said a petition has been filed in the Supreme Court to fight for the community’s rights, aiming to ensure that the NALSA (National Legal Services Authority) judgment is implemented. The 2014 NALSA judgment, a landmark Supreme Court decision recognising transgender people as

the “third gender” in India, had upheld the right to self-identify as male, female, or third gender without medical testing, affirming fundamental rights to equality and dignity under Articles 14, 15, 19, and 21 of the Constitution.

NCP(SP) leader Anish Gawande criticised the requirement of certification by medical boards and district authorities. Gawande, who is the first gay national spokesperson of a political party in the country, said: “We have thousands of other crises to deal with, but you want a district magistrate and a district medical officer to sit around and certify who is a transgender and who is not. Why is the government obsessed with what is between somebody’s legs?”

Gawande said he had been receiving calls from transgender persons fearful about their future. “The number of phone calls I’ve received over the last week from people who are scared -- ki meri kya hoga, mujhe police arrest kar degi kya, main agar transgender

hoon toh mujhe surgery karwane hi padegi kya? (What will happen to me? Will the police arrest me? If I am transgender, do I necessarily have to do surgery?) These are real concerns that people have shared,” he said, adding, “This is creating a mental health crisis and also driving people to suicide.”

Citing the story of Kabir Mann, a Dalit Transman who has obtained all necessary certifications to become a teacher but failed to land a job, Gawande said the amended law could block thousands of transgender persons from accessing education and employment.

“When documents don’t match a person’s gender identity, opportunities vanish, and people are forced back into secrecy. For many, this could push them into begging or sex work, the only spaces where identification is not questioned,” he said.

Meera Parida, transgender activist and a BJD politician, said that the community was deeply disturbed by the sudden passage of the Bill.

While referring to the 2015 sacrilege incidents and police firing at anti-sacrilege protesters in Faridkot, Mann accused the Akalis of bruising the psyche of every individual through the desecration of Guru Granth Sahib.

“They (Akalis) disrespected the ‘bani’ of the great Guru Sahiban and ordered firing on the innocents in Behbal Kalan and Bargari. They have shown grave disrespect to Sri Akal Takht Sahib,” he added.

“The former Deputy Chief Minister (Sukhbir Badal) claims that massive development of the state took place during their regime, but turns a blind eye towards Kotakpura, Behbal Kalan, where sacrilege of Guru Granth Sahib took place, and innocents were killed,” he said.

“Every vote given to Akalis will be a mandate in favour of sacrilege of Guru and Gurbani,” he alleged.

Collection of district-level infra data to begin after Census phase 1 completion

‘For the first time, data will be collected through a mobile application’

MPOST BUREAU

INSIGHT

- » The DCHB forms an integral part of the Census Operations and is prepared separately for each district
- » It presents key

demographic and socio-economic characteristics, along with detailed information on the availability of civic amenities and infrastructural facilities for every village and town in the district

systems, electricity connections, roads, banks and dozens of other amenities, noting not only whether a facility exists but how far residents must travel if it does not.

Published continuously since the first population census conducted after independence in 1951, the handbook will see a significant methodological shift. For the first time, the data shall be collected through a mobile application rather than paper schedules, which were used in every

previous round.

“The DCHB forms an integral part of the Census Operations and is prepared separately for each district. It presents key demographic and socio-economic characteristics, along with detailed information on the availability of civic amenities and infrastructural facilities for every village and town in the district,” it said.

The handbook is prepared separately for each of the country’s 784 districts, making it a thorough record of the civic

infrastructure of each village and town.

“The reference date for the collection of DCHB data for 784 districts shall be 31-12-2025, and the information for villages and towns shall reflect their status as of that date,” it said.

The data is collected in two parts: a Village and Town Directory, and a Primary Census Abstract by field functionaries -- patwaris, panchayat secretaries, and village development officers -- in rural areas.

The Village Directory will collate data in nine fields, comprising educational and medical facilities, water and sanitation, transport and communication, banking and credit, electricity supply, land utilisation and irrigation, principal agricultural commodities, and manufactures and handicrafts.

Bihar ‘hooch’ tragedy death toll rises to nine

The first death was reported on April 2

already been discharged after treatment,” he said.

“The bodies of the deceased have been sent for post-mortem examination. The exact cause of the deaths can only be known after the reports arrive,” he said.

The SHO of Turkauliya police station has already been suspended on charge of dereliction of duty, and a special investigation team has been constituted to probe the incident, officials said.

The deaths have led to a political slugfest in the state, where the sale and consumption of alcohol has been banned since 2016.

AGENCIES

MP lodge collapse toll rises to 3; CM announces compensation

ANUPPUR (MP): The death toll in the collapse of a four-storey lodge in Madhya Pradesh’s Anuppur district has risen to three, with three others seriously injured, a police official said on Sunday.

Relief and rescue operations by agencies, including the NDRF, are ongoing at the site in Kotma town, as some persons are still feared trapped under the debris, he said.

Chief Minister Mohan Yadav expressed grief and announced Rs 9 lakh in compensation for the kin of each deceased, and Rs 2.5 lakh each for the injured.

Anuppur collector Harshal Pancholi said that seven persons were pulled out of the debris overnight, of which three died.



Rescue operations underway at the site of a building collapse in MP’s Anuppur PTI

Officials said the building, called ‘Aggarwal Lodge’, near the Kotma bus stand, collapsed around 5.30 pm on Saturday.

The bus stand area was teeming with commuters at the time of the incident, and construction work was underway on a nearby plot of land, they said.

Anuppur Superintendent

Sabotage bid at Lucknow’s Charbagh Rly station foiled

OUR CORRESPONDENT

LUCKNOW: A major conspiracy to sabotage railway signal systems and infrastructure at Charbagh Railway Station was foiled by the UP Anti-Terrorist Squad, officials said on Sunday.

Four accused were arrested from the station premises. According to officials, the suspects were acting on instructions from a Pakistan-based handler and were in contact through social media platforms and encrypted messaging applications.

Security agencies recovered flammable substances and electronic equipment from their possession, raising concerns about a possible attempt to disrupt railway operations and endanger passenger safety.

Railways commended the ATS for its swift action in preventing a potential incident.

of Police (SP) Moti Ur Rahman said the deceased persons have been identified as Hanuman Deen Yadav (55), Ramkripal Yadav (50) and Radha Kaul (45).

Of the four injured persons, three were in critical condition, and they have been referred to Shahdol for advanced care, the SP said.

AGENCIES

Over 6K UP workers in Israel safe, say officials

LUCKNOW: Over 6,000 workers from Uttar Pradesh currently in Israel are safe despite the prevailing tense situation, with the state government maintaining continuous contact with Indian authorities on the ground, officials said on Sunday.

Principal Secretary Labour and Employment Department, Uttar Pradesh, Shanmuga Sundaram, is in regular contact with the Indian Embassy in Israel to track developments and ensure the safety of Indian nationals, particularly those from the state.

Acting on the directions of Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath, the state government is closely monitoring the well-being of all workers.

MPOST

Jind: CM Saini unveils Rs 253 crore projects

CHANDIGARH: Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Sunday unveiled development projects worth Rs 253 crore in Jind, significantly enhancing irrigation, roads, health services, and water supply in the region.

Saini laid the foundation stones for 12 projects worth over Rs 140 crore and inaugurated three projects with a combined cost of over Rs 112 crore, an official statement said.

Among the key inaugurations are the reconstruction of Jind Tributary No 4, completed by the Irrigation and Water Resources Department for Rs 16.28 crore.

Additional projects inaugurated included modern micro-irrigation systems at the village level, solar-powered irrigation facilities, and a balancing reservoir for water storage in Intal Khurd village, constructed for Rs 56.36 crore.

Saini, who addressed a public rally in Jind, also dedicated the Dr B R Ambedkar Library building at Chaudhary Ranbir Singh University, built for Rs 56.36 crore.

Furthering the infrastructure initiative, the chief minister laid the foundation stone for projects covering agriculture marketing, housing, roads, health, drainage,

and water supply. This includes a purchase centre at Manoharpur village, developed by the Haryana State Agricultural Marketing Board for Rs 3.18 crore, as well as 56 residential units for revenue officers in the officers’ colony, to be constructed by the Public Works Department for Rs 16.61 crore.

Saini also laid the foundation for the widening and strengthening of the Nirjan approach road and the Kandela route via Safidon, covering the villages of Haibatpur, Khokhri, Bohatwala, and Dalamwala, from Parshuram Chowk to the bypass. This work will be undertaken for Rs 4.56 crore.

To enhance drainage infrastructure, the Irrigation and Water Resources Department has commenced the Manoharpur drain excavation project for Rs 1.09 crore.

The chief minister also laid the foundation for Public Health Engineering Department projects worth over Rs 35 crore. These include three canal-based water supply schemes in Jalalpura Kalan, Intal Kalan and Intal Khurd villages, along with the expansion of two existing schemes.

MPOST



EDITORIAL
BATTLEFIELD
TO
BARGAINING

For a brief but fraught window, the possibility that an American pilot might be captured inside Iran injected a new and dangerous uncertainty into an already combustible confrontation. Even in an age of precision warfare and remote engagement, the fate of a single individual can alter the strategic temperature of a conflict. The downing of an aircraft is, by itself, a serious escalation; the prospect of a live captive transforms it into something far more volatile. It creates a human focal point around which politics, propaganda and pressure converge. Had the pilot fallen into Iranian custody, the crisis would have acquired a sharper edge, one defined not just by military calculations but by the urgency, symbolism and unpredictability that accompany such moments.

A captured pilot is never just a prisoner. He becomes a narrative. In conflicts marked by asymmetry, where one side cannot match the other in conventional terms, symbolic victories carry immense value. For Iran, the detention of an American serviceman would have been presented as proof that it can impose costs, pierce technological superiority and hold its ground against a far more powerful adversary. The optics alone—images, statements, controlled appearances—would have travelled far beyond the immediate theatre, shaping perceptions across the region and beyond. Such episodes are designed to do precisely that: compress complex conflicts into a single, compelling image that tilts the psychological balance, if only momentarily.

For the United States, the consequences would have been immediate and uncomfortable. Washington's long-standing commitment to bringing its personnel home is not merely a moral stance; it is central to military cohesion and public trust. But that commitment becomes a constraint when an adversary holds the leverage. Any move towards negotiation risks being read as a concession; any refusal risks prolonging the crisis and hardening domestic pressure. This is the trap that hostage situations, formal or otherwise, are meant to create. They force a superpower to operate within a narrower band of options, where every decision carries reputational costs. In such circumstances, strategy is often pulled in two directions—towards urgency on the one hand and restraint on the other.

The operational dimension only deepens the stakes. A captured pilot potentially carries fragments of information—about flight paths, mission patterns, technological systems—that, even if limited, can prove valuable in an active conflict. More importantly, the mere possibility of such compromise can compel adjustments in ongoing operations, introducing caution where aggression might otherwise prevail. Then there is the question of recovery. Rescue missions are among the most complex and high-risk undertakings in modern warfare, requiring precision, coordination and a willingness to escalate. A successful extraction reinforces credibility; a failed one can widen the conflict dramatically. The decision to attempt such an operation is never purely tactical—it is political, psychological and strategic all at once.

What makes such incidents especially dangerous is their capacity to collapse the distance between battlefield events and diplomatic consequences. A downed aircraft can be absorbed into the rhythms of conflict; a captured pilot cannot. He becomes a live variable, one that demands attention at the highest levels and invites constant recalibration. In a media-saturated environment, the timeline of escalation compresses further. Narratives harden quickly, public expectations crystallise, and the space for quiet, incremental de-escalation shrinks. The crisis begins to feed on its own momentum, driven as much by perception as by policy.

The fact that this particular episode did not culminate in a capture should not obscure how close it came to doing so. It is precisely these near-misses that reveal the fragility of control in modern conflicts. They expose how thin the margin is between a contained incident and a wider crisis, how quickly contingency can overtake planning. If anything, the lesson is sobering. In confrontations defined by mistrust and high capability, it is often not the planned strike or the calculated move that raises the stakes, but the unforeseen turn—the aircraft that goes down, the pilot who goes missing, the moment that becomes a symbol. That is where escalation begins to slip its leash, and where the cost of miscalculation becomes hardest to contain.

TALKING SHOP



RAJEEV NARAYAN

THE WRITER IS A VETERAN JOURNALIST AND COMMUNICATIONS SPECIALIST

AI and cloud infrastructure are rapidly becoming one of the planet's largest and mostly unseen water consumers, raising some tough questions for water-stressed countries like India. Do we realize we are drying up the planet?

PAST IMPERATIVE



SHANTANU MUKHARJI

THE WRITER IS A RETIRED IPS OFFICER, ADVISER NATSTRAT, AND A FORMER NATIONAL SECURITY ADVISOR IN MAURITIUS

Even decades later, thousands of killing sites remain undocumented, underscoring how the full scale of the 1971 atrocities is still being uncovered

Thirsty Machines

Behind the dazzling rise of Artificial Intelligence worldwide lies a squelchy crisis – the massive volumes of freshwater being consumed to cool our digital brains

“Thousands have lived without love, not one without water...”
— W.H. Auden

We are the new, modern world. We pride ourselves on miracles that seemingly occur without effort. Our messages travel across continents in milliseconds. Artificial intelligence drafts treatises, diagnoses disease and composes music on demand. Cloud servers remember everything we deign to forget. The digital age, we have been informed, is immaterial; it is just an elegant realm of code and computation floating somewhere in the ether. In reality, though, the cloud is anything but weightless. It is built from steel, silicon, copper and water. A hell of a lot of water.

Every day, vast warehouses filled with humming servers generate immense heat while processing the world's digital traffic. Cooling these machines requires astonishing volumes of water. Research bodies have estimated that 800 billion litres of freshwater are used worldwide every single day to cool our computing infrastructure, industrial systems and digital networks—those machines that sustain the globe's modern economies. Just one large data centre can consume around 18.9 million litres of water each day, roughly the amount used by a town of 50,000 people.

And the numbers are climbing rapidly as artificial intelligence flexes muscle. Analysts warn that AI-led data centre operations alone will consume hundreds of billions of litres annually within the next few years, some even suggesting that global demand will cross trillions of litres by Year 2030. If you still haven't figured out what these words are saying, here's an unabridged version to scare the pants off your revered bottoms: the same tech that promise to transform civilisation is quietly sucking the planet dry. Consider the irony of asking an algorithm about global sustainability; and then imagine it evaporating water somewhere to keep itself cool while it figures out what answer to throw at us.

Heat of Intelligence
For all of its mathematical elegance, artificial intelligence has a rather unpoetic offshoot. It runs hot. Very hot. Training large AI models requires enormous clusters of specialised processors, all packed tightly into server racks that generate massive amounts of intense heat. Without constant cooling, the hardware would cook and fail. Water is the most efficient way to counter this heat. Most data centres use evaporative cooling systems—essentially industry-scale versions of the human body's perspiration mechanism. Water absorbs heat and evaporates into the air, carrying thermal energy away from delicate electronics. The problem is that just like sweat, the water used up does not magically return to the body (the industrial tank in this case). It vanishes into the atmosphere and needs repeated replenishing. Again, and again, and again. In perpetuity.



For water-rich regions, the water problem is somewhat manageable. For India, it is alarming, for the country is among the most water-stressed in the world

India's Digital Dilemma
For water-rich regions, the water problem is somewhat manageable. For India, it is alarming, for the country is among the most water-stressed in the world. Groundwater tables are falling across large parts of the nation, with many major cities periodically facing acute shortages. If this backdrop weren't scary enough, India has also embarked on an ambitious mission to become a global hub for artificial intelligence, cloud computing and digital infrastructure.

The result is a collision of aspirations. India hosts around 250 data centres, with clusters concentrated in Mumbai, Chennai, Hyderabad and Bengaluru. These cities are already struggling with water scarcity. Thus, 60-80 per cent of all data centres in India will face critical water stress in just a few years, given current water usage trends. The scale is staggering. Data centre water usage in India is projected to rise from 150 billion litres in 2025 to more than 358 billion litres by 2030.

That is not a mere statistic. It represents water that might otherwise supply households, agriculture or ecosystems. Policymakers are finally beginning to understand the quandary, and some states are reassessing data centre policies, weighing the economic benefits of digital infrastructure against the hidden environmental costs. While industry promises investment and technological prestige, only a few hoarse whispers reveal that data centres generate relatively modest employment, especially when compared to their enormous resource footprint.

While promising, these innovations are far from universal. In many regions, the simplest and cheapest solution remains traditional evaporative cooling, which means freshwater usage. This brutal reality means that companies build facilities where land, electricity and water are easily available; not where ecosystems can afford the extra demand. That has led to warnings that water scarcity will become a serious financial risk for the industry soon. If local communities or governments impose restrictions on water use, data centre expansion may slow or shift locations. In effect, the availability of water may end up determining the geography of the digital economy.

That leads to a fascinating reversal of history. For centuries, civilisations formed around rivers because humans needed water to survive. In the 21st century, rivers may again shape the map; this time because computers do.

Responsible Future
None of this suggests that AI or digital infrastructure should be abandoned. The technologies powering the Internet have brought undeniable benefits: from telemedicine and financial inclusion to scientific discovery and climate modelling. The challenge is not deciding whether the digital revolution should continue, but how it should unfold responsibly. Some steps are clear, provided we accept reality and begin implementing. One, transparency must improve. Data centre firms disclose electricity use but seldom provide details on water consumption, especially indirect use through energy supply chains; truthful reporting will allow an understanding of the actual impact. Two, tech innovation must accelerate. Cooling systems that need less freshwater are being developed, such as closed-loop liquid cooling, immersion cooling and air-based systems. These require higher upfront investment, but can dramatically reduce water demand. Three, location. Building data centres in regions with ready water resources or cool climes will lower 'green' pressure. Conversely, putting up computing clusters in water-scarce areas is asking for trouble.

The policy implications are clear. India's digital ambitions are legitimate, but they must be balanced against the reality of water security. Pushing the use of treated wastewater, mandating water-efficient cooling tech and integrating data-centre planning with urban water management are essential steps.

The lesson is simple yet profound. Technology does not exist outside nature. Every algorithm, every cloud server, every AI prompt is anchored in the physical world. It draws electricity, minerals and water from a finite planet. The illusion that digital progress floats above ecological limits may be convenient, but it is nonsense; it is dangerous too. The future of AI depends not only on faster chips and smarter code, it also banks on something far older and simpler. And sweeter. Water.

The writer can be reached on narayanrajeev2006@gmail.com. Views expressed are personal

Echoes of 1971

Through state articulation and media discourse, Bangladesh reasserts the centrality of Liberation War memory, countering assumptions that political transition would soften historical accountability

Bangladesh, under the premiership of Tarique Rahman, seems to be charting on the right course, as per the initial indications. It also appears that the Prime Minister has set out his priorities well, particularly in his approach towards Pakistan. This naturally gives comfort to a large section of Bangladeshis who are pro-liberation and value Indo-Bangladesh relations, as well as India's contribution to the freedom struggle.

Commemorating Genocide Day on March 25, Prime Minister Tarique Rahman described March 25, 1971, as one of the darkest and most brutal days in the history of freedom-loving Bangladesh. Significantly, he urged the nation to uphold the spirit of the Liberation War and remember the horrors of the March 25 genocide, calling for united efforts to build a just, democratic, and prosperous Bangladesh. He also stressed the need to pass on the history and true meaning of independence to future generations, urging them to strive to honour the sacrifices of the martyrs by upholding the spirit of the great Liberation War.

Importantly, he recalled that on the night of March 25, Pakistani occupation forces carried out one of the most heinous genocides under 'Operation Searchlight', targeting unarmed people across the country. The Prime Minister further reminded that the occupation forces indiscriminately opened fire on teachers, intellectuals, and innocent civilians at various places, including Dhaka University, Palkhana, and Rajarbagh Police Lines, killing many, and he also described the genocide of March 25 as a pre-planned massacre. He questioned why this organised killing spree could not be resisted, which remains a matter of historical research regarding the visible role of the political leadership of that time. Further, he prayed for the salvation and eternal peace of the departed souls of the martyrs and wished success to all programmes organised to observe Genocide Day.

In this context, we see that promi-



Targeting civilians, intellectuals and minorities, Operation Searchlight triggered widespread violence and mass displacement

nent Bangladeshi newspapers have also reminded the nation about Genocide Day. "Daily Star", a much-read newspaper, carried an opinion piece stating that in the post-1971 period, a significant amount of information about Pakistan-sponsored murders, assaults, rapes, and other atrocities has come to light. Much of it came from interviews, personal narratives, confessions, and individual experiences, rather than systematic, professional, or scientific research. I have written that around 30 lakh people were martyred in the Liberation War. While the precise figures may be debated, the scale of mass killings is beyond dispute. Estimates suggest there are around 5,000 small and large killing grounds across the country, many of which remain unaccounted for. Among these, approximately 1,200 killing sites and mass graves have been identified. The evidence gathered from these sites points clearly to the perpetrators responsible for the killing of lakhs of Bengalis. After independence, the government of Bangladesh announced that around two lakh women had been assaulted by Pakistani forces dur-

ing the war. Also, research conducted at Sweden's Uppsala University revealed figures ranging from two to four lakh and concluded that most of the assaulted women were Muslims. Dr Geoffrey Davis, an Australian physician who worked in Bangladesh as part of an international humanitarian programme assisting women who had been raped during the Liberation War, estimated the number of rape victims at 450,000. Subsequently, research by a professional team in Bangladesh placed the figure at more than 467,000, noting that many Hindus as well as Muslim women had been excluded from earlier estimates. According to the Bangladesh Documents published by India's Ministry of External Affairs, between March and the end of May 1971, some 69.71 lakh Hindu refugees were registered in India. Many of those who fled during this period had been attacked during the brutal Operation Searchlight and were assaulted either by Pakistani forces or their collaborators in Bangladesh. Statistics indicate that 871,000 Hindu families fled to India during that

time, including around 2,625,000 female refugees over the age of ten. If even one in ten of them were subjected to sexual violence, the number of victims among refugees alone would be 262,500. Even the most conservative estimates suggest that no fewer than two lakh Hindu women and girls never returned to Bangladesh, as rape was systematically used as a weapon of war and as the intent of the campaign was to target and eliminate Hindus in particular. It is further commented that the Pakistan Army committed some 39 counts of war crimes and crimes against humanity, including genocide by killing, genocide by causing serious bodily or mental harm, genocide by deliberately inflicting conditions of life calculated to bring about physical destruction, and genocidal rape.

From Prime Minister Tarique Rahman's condemnation of the genocide that occurred 55 years ago, and his detailed articulation of the events while reminding the nation about the gravity of the occasion, it would appear that the new Bangladesh regime under Tarique Rahman wants to keep the spirit of the Liberation War alive. Contrary to the opinion of a section in Bangladesh, the leadership does not appear inclined to forget the sacrifices and the indiscriminate killings by Pakistan's occupation forces during the liberation struggle.

Similarly, the press and public opinion also want the people not to forget the massacre. More importantly, such utterances and views carried in the mainstream media will place the factual history in the right and objective perspective, keeping the present generation well informed. This appears to be a welcome development, putting Pakistan under pressure, as it was perhaps under the illusion that the post-Hasina regime might forget the genocide and the excesses committed against Bangladeshis, and that the issue would lie buried. Such expectations have now been belied.

Views expressed are personal

UN SAYS IT'S THE MOST SIGNIFICANT SUPPLY CHAIN DISRUPTION SINCE COVID

Iran war disrupts global food, medicine supply: Aid groups

TEL AVIV: Aid groups warned that the war in the Middle East has upended their ability to get food and medicine to millions of people around the world in need, and that the suffering will deepen if the violence continues.

Not only has the conflict cut off vital shipping routes, creating a global energy crisis, it's also disrupting supply chains for aid groups, forcing them to use costlier, more time-consuming routes.

Key pathways such as the Strait of Hormuz have been effectively shuttered and routes from strategic hubs such as Dubai, Doha and Abu Dhabi have also been impacted. Transport costs have spiked with higher fuel and insurance rates, meaning less supplies can be delivered with the same amount of money.

The World Food Programme says it has tens of thousands of metric tons of food heavily delayed in transit.

The International Rescue Committee has \$130,000 worth of pharmaceuticals intended for war-torn Sudan stranded in Dubai and nearly 670 boxes of therapeutic food meant for severely malnourished children in Somalia stuck in India. The UN Population Fund says it's delayed sending equipment to 16



A portrait of Iran's late Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei being seen near a building damaged in an Israeli airstrike in Dahiyeh

Key pathways such as the Strait of Hormuz have been effectively shuttered and routes from strategic hubs such as Dubai, Doha and Abu Dhabi have also been impacted

countries.

Steep US cuts to foreign aid already had hobbled many aid groups, who say the war is exacerbating the problem.

The United Nations says this is the most significant

supply chain disruption since COVID, with up to a 20 per cent cost increase on shipments and delays as goods are rerouted. And the war is creating new emergencies, such as in Iran, and also in Lebanon

where at least one million people have been displaced.

"The war on Iran and disruption to the Strait of Hormuz risk pushing humanitarian operations beyond their limits," said Madiha Raza, associate director for public affairs and communications for Africa for the International Rescue Committee.

Even when the fighting stops, the shock to global sup-

longer and more costly routes

The war has forced organizations to find new ways to transport goods, with some bypassing the Strait of Hormuz and the Suez Canal and rerouting vessels around Africa, adding weeks to the delivery.

Others are using a hybrid of methods, including land, sea and air, increasing costs. Jean-Cedric Meeus, chief of global transport and logistics for UNICEF, said his agency is using a mix of land and air routes to send vaccines to Nigeria and Iran in order to get them there in time for the vaccination campaigns, but the costs have soared.

Before the war, UNICEF sent vaccines to Iran by plane directly from vendors around the world. Now it's flying the vaccines to Turkey and driving them into Iran, which has increased costs by 20 per cent and has added 10 days to the delivery time, he said. AGENCIES

ply chains could continue to delay lifesaving aid for months, she said. AGENCIES

Long Mideast war could take away US' support for Ukraine: Zelenskyy

ISTANBUL: Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy expressed concern that a prolonged US-Israeli war on Iran could further erode America's support for Ukraine as Washington's global priorities shift and Kyiv braces for reduced deliveries of critically needed Patriot air defence missiles.

Ukraine desperately needs more US-made Patriot air defence systems to help it counter Russia's daily barrages, Zelenskyy said, speaking to The Associated Press in an exclusive interview late Saturday in Istanbul.

Russia's relentless pounding of urban areas behind the front line following its full-scale



Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy

invasion of Ukraine more than four years ago has killed thousands of civilians. It has also targeted Ukraine's energy supply to disrupt the industrial production of Ukraine's newly developed drones and mis-

siles, while also denying civilians heat and running water in winter. "We have to recognise that we are not the priority for today," Zelenskyy said. "That's why I am afraid a long (Iran) war will give us less support."

The latest US-brokered talks between envoys from Moscow and Kyiv ended in February with no sign of a breakthrough. Zelenskyy, who has accused Russia of "trying to drag out negotiations" while it presses on with its invasion, said Ukraine remains in contact with US negotiators about a potential deal to end the war and has continued to press for stronger security guarantees. AGENCIES

Sweden frees sanctioned tanker due to lack of evidence it caused oil spill

FRANKFURT: Swedish authorities have released a tanker sanctioned by the European Union that had been boarded and detained on suspicion of causing an oil spill in the Baltic Sea.

The Swedish Coast Guard said they had not found sufficient evidence that the Flora 1 tanker was at fault for the 12-kilometre (8-mile) long spill that had been discovered on Thursday. Investigators also established that Cameroon had confirmed the vessel was sailing under that country's flag, which had not been clear when the vessel and its 24-member

crew were stopped Friday, the coast guard said. The Flora 1 was put on the EU's list of sanctioned vessels for carrying Russian oil while "practising irregular and high-risk shipping practices." Unsafe practices can include turning off the automatic tracking system that transmits the vessel's location to other ships.

The sanctions are aimed at the "shadow fleet" that emerged in response to a price cap on Russian oil imposed by the Group of Seven democracies to limit the revenues that fund Russia's invasion of Ukraine. AGENCIES

Nepal's RSP leader Aryal elected as Parl Speaker

KATHMANDU: Leader of the ruling Rastriya Swatantra Party (RSP), Dol Prasad Aryal, on Sunday, was elected as the Speaker of Nepal's Parliament.

President Ramchandra Paudel administered the oath of office and secrecy to the newly elected Speaker of the Parliament, Aryal, at a special function at his office on Sunday afternoon.

Aryal, also the Vice President of RSP, was elected unopposed during a meeting of the members of the House of Representatives (HoR), the lower house of the Federal Parliament, according to a notice issued by the Parliament secretariat.

Rabi Lamichhane, chairman of the RSP and a Parliament member, had presented a proposal seeking Aryal's election as the Speaker.

The proposal was seconded by MPs Sobita Gautam, Dr Swarnim Wagle and Sunil Lamsal.

The senior-most member of the HoR, Arjun Narsingh KC, announced that Aryal was elected as the Speaker after the meeting. AGENCIES

Nearly 800 TTP terrorists killed in Afghanistan: Pak

ISLAMABAD: Pakistan on Sunday said nearly 800 Afghan Taliban terrorists have been killed in the ongoing operation launched by the security forces in Afghanistan. Information Minister Attaullah Tarar shared the latest update on operation Ghazab lil-Haq, giving a summary of the losses

suffered by the Tehreek-e-Taliban Pakistan (TTP), also called Fitna Al Khawarij (FAK) and Afghan Taliban.

Tarar said that at least 796 Fitna Al Khawarij and the Afghan Taliban personnel have been killed and more than 1,043 injured since the launch of the operation. AGENCIES

महाराष्ट्र शासन
कार्यकारी अभियंता सा. बां. विद्युत विभाग छत्रपती संभाजी नगर
ई-निविदा सूचना क्र. 01 सन - 2026-27
कार्यकारी अभियंता, औरंगाबाद सा. बां. विद्युत विभाग, ब-1 टक्केवारीच्या ई-प्रणालीद्वारे निविदा मागविण्यात येत आहेत. को-या निविदा नमुना <http://mahatenders.gov.in> या संकेत स्थळावर दि. 06.04.2026 चेळ 10.00 ते दि. 11.04.2026 चेळ 17.30 पर्यंत ऑनलाईन डाऊनलोड करण्याकरीता उपलब्ध होतील.
टिप :- सदर निविदा सूचनेमध्ये 03 कामे प्रस्तावित करण्यात आली आहेत.
जा.क्र. काअ/छसंविनि/निविदा/ 1314 /2026 दि.01.04.2026
सहरी कार्यकारी अभियंता
Dgipr/2026-27/43 सा.बां. विद्युत विभाग छत्रपती संभाजी नगर

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
See Section 84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023
Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person **Deepak Chadda @ Harish S/o** Nareesh Kumar, R/o H. No. M-104, Shakurpur, Delhi, has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 17087/2024, U/S 411 IPC, PS Sarai Rohilla, North Distt., Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Deepak Chadda @ Harish** cannot be found, and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Deepak Chadda @ Harish** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant);
Proclamation is hereby made that **Deepak Chadda @ Harish** the said accused of **FIR No. 17087/2024, U/S 411 IPC, PS Sarai Rohilla, North Distt., Delhi**, is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **06.05.2026**.
By Order
Sh. Rangat Ghirra
Judicial Magistrate First Class-04,
Central Distt., Room No.-37,
Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
See Section 82 CrPC / 84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023
Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person **Ibran S/o** Safatulla R/o H.No. E-305, JJ Colony, Bawana, Delhi, has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 83/2023, Dt. 12.01.2023, U/S 394/411 IPC, PS Narela Industrial Area, Outer-North Distt., Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Ibran** cannot be found, and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Ibran** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant);
Proclamation is hereby made that **Ibran** the said accused of **FIR No. 83/2023, Dt. 12.01.2023, U/S 394/411 IPC, PS Narela Industrial Area, Outer-North Distt., Delhi**, is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **19.05.2026**.
By Order
Ms. Jyoti Nain
Judicial Magistrate First Class-07,
North Distt., Court No.-06, 1st Floor,
Rohini Courts, Delhi

Congo to receive third-country deportees from US under new deal

KINSHASA: Congo will receive some migrants as part of a new deal under the Trump administration's third-country program, its government said Sunday, the latest such African nation to receive migrants being deported from the US.

The deportees will start arriving in Congo this month, the Congolese Ministry of Communications said in a statement, without further details on the date or the number of deportees expected.

KEY POINTS

- » The deportees will start arriving in Congo this month
- » The US has struck such third-country deportation deals with at least seven other African nations
- » Lawyers and activists have raised questions over nature of the deals with countries in Africa and elsewhere

It described the arrangement as a "temporary" one that reflects Congo's "commitment to human dignity and international solidarity." It would come

with zero costs to the government with the US covering the needed logistics, it said. The US has struck such third-country deportation deals with at least

seven other African nations, many of them among countries hit the most by the Trump administration's policies that have restricted trade, aid and migration.

US has spent at least \$40 million to deport about 300 migrants to countries other than their own, according to a report released recently by the Democratic staff of the Senate FRC. Lawyers and activists have raised questions over the nature of the deals with countries in

Africa and elsewhere. Several of the African nations that have signed such deals have notoriously repressive governments and poor human rights records — including Eswatini, South Sudan and Equatorial Guinea.

A key bone of contention in many such agreements is that they involve many migrants with protection orders from a US immigration judge not to be returned to their home countries over major safety concerns. AGENCIES

Pam Bondi's extreme political loyalty to Trump wasn't enough to save her job

MASSACHUSETTS: After President Donald Trump fired Attorney General Pam Bondi on April 2, 2026, news reports suggested that she fell from grace, not for being too independent, but for not being effective enough at defending him and prosecuting his political enemies.

As The New York Times reported the previous day, Trump was disappointed with "Ms. Bondi's handling of the Jeffrey Epstein files, which has become a political liability for Mr. Trump among his supporters. He has also complained about her shortcomings as a communicator and vented about what he sees as the Department of Justice's lack



President Donald Trump

of aggressiveness in going after his foes."

The president has long indicated that whoever served as attorney general

Key Points

- » Trump was reportedly disappointed with 'Ms. Bondi's handling of the Jeffrey Epstein files
- » Trump set out to find a political ally and loyalist to take the helm at Justice Dept

BONDI REPLACED SESSIONS WITH WILLIAM BARR

in his administration should see themselves as his lawyer rather than as someone representing the US government. During his first presidential term, Trump was gravely dis-

appointed with Jeff Sessions, his first attorney general, who recused himself from the investigation into alleged political interference in the 2016 election. He replaced Sessions with William Barr, who abandoned Trump when the president did not accept the results of the 2020 election.

Having learned from those mistakes, Trump set out to find a political ally and loyalist to take the helm at the Justice Department in his second administration.

As a scholar of law and politics, and someone who has written about the role of the attorney general, I think Trump's desire has a familiar ring to it. AGENCIES

B'desh: 94 kids died in 19 days due to measles

DHAKA: Bangladesh on Sunday said a severe measles outbreak has claimed lives of at least 94 children in the past 19 days, prompting the government to launch an emergency remedial campaign for the infectious disease.

As the outbreak affected 56 out of the 64 administrative districts, Prime Minister Tarique Rahman's government blamed the Interim government of Muhammad Yunus for its failure to provide vaccines on time for measles.

Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS) said 10 of the total 94 measles related deaths occurred in 24 hours ending at 8 am Sunday even as the number

of suspected measles cases detected grew to 5,792 during the 19 days, 974 of them since Saturday.

"The highly infectious disease has seen a sharp rise this year, particularly since March," a DGHS statement said, attributing the phenomenon to vaccination gap last year.

The DGHS report suggests the outbreak has hit the hardest in the northwestern Rajshahi region where health officials have stepped up surveillance and case-tracking.

Health Minister Sardar Shakhawat Hossain Bakul said the emergency vaccination drive would cover the "worst affected areas" before being expanded throughout Bangladesh. AGENCIES

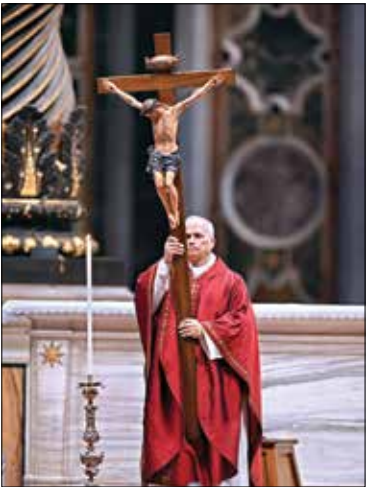
AMID GLOBAL CONFLICTS

Pope marks first Easter as pontiff with call for hope

VATICAN CITY: Pope Leo celebrated his first Easter Mass as pontiff with a call Sunday to exercise hope against "the violence of war that kills and destroys," saying "we need this song of hope today" as conflicts spread around the world.

With the US-Israeli war on Iran in its second month and Russia's ongoing campaign in Ukraine, Leo has repeatedly called for a halt in hostilities. In his Easter homily, the pope singled out those who wage war, abuse the weak and prioritise profits. Leo, the first US-born pope, addressed the faithful from an open-air altar in St. Peter's Square flanked with white roses, while the steps leading down to the piazza where the faithful gathered were filled with spring perennials, symbolically resonating with the pope's message of hope.

The pontiff implored the faithful to keep their hope in the face of death, which lurks "in injustices, in partisan selfishness, in the oppression of the poor, in the lack of attention given to the most vulnerable. "We see it in violence, in the wounds of the world, in the cry of pain that rises from every corner because of the abuses that crush the weakest among us, because of the idolatry of profit that



REPRESENTATIONAL IMAGE

plunders the earth's resources, because of the violence of war that kills and destroys," he said.

He quoted his predecessor Pope Francis in warning against falling into indifference in the face of "persistent injustice, evil, indifference and cruelty." AGENCIES

Artemis II crew speeds toward moon to break Apollo 13's record

A version of the Artemis II toilet was tested on ISS several years ago

HOUSTON: Now more than halfway to the moon, the Artemis II astronauts prepared for their historic lunar fly-around to push deeper into space than even the Apollo astronauts. On the downside, their toilet is on the blink again.

The three Americans and one Canadian are set to reach their destination Monday, photographing the mysterious lunar far side as they zoom around. It is the first moon-bound crew in more than 53 years, picking up where NASA's Apollo programme left off.

"The Earth is quite small, and the moon is definitely getting bigger," pilot Victor Glover reported. Until the Orion capsule's bathroom is fixed, Mission Control has instructed the astronauts



Moon being seen in picture released by NASA as part of updates on Artemis II mission

to break out more of the backup urine collection bags. The so-called lunar loo malfunctioned following Wednesday's liftoff and has been hit-and-miss ever since. A version of the Artemis II toilet was tested on the International Space Station several years ago.

Engineers suspect ice may be blocking the line that is preventing urine from completely flushing overboard. The toilet is still open for No. 2 business. Debbie Korth, NASA's Orion program deputy

KEY POINTS

- » Engineers suspect ice may be blocking the line that is preventing urine from completely flushing overboard
- » The so-called lunar loo malfunctioned following Wednesday's liftoff and has been hit-and-miss ever since

manager, said the astronauts have also reported a smell coming from the bathroom, which is buried in the floor of the capsule with a door and curtain for privacy.

"Space toilets and bathrooms are something everybody can understand... it's always a challenge," she said, noting that the space shuttle toilet was also often on the fritz.

John Honeycutt, chair of the mission management team, said it is human nature to be interested in

the space commode, and even though it is "in a good state right now," he'd like it to be working at 100%.

"They're OK," he said of the astronauts. "They trained to manage through the situation."

Artemis II is poised to set a distance record for humans, travelling more than 252,000 miles (400,000 km) from Earth before hanging a U-turn behind the moon and heading home without stopping or entering lunar orbit. AGENCIES

Format C-7

(for political parties to publish in the newspapers, social media platforms & website of the party)

Information regarding individuals with pending criminal cases, who have been selected as candidates, along with the reasons for such selection, as also as to why other individuals without criminal antecedents could not be selected as candidates (As per the Commission’s directions issued in pursuance of the Order dated 13.02.2020 of the Hon’ble Supreme Court in contempt petition (C) no. 2192 of 2018 in WP(C) No. 536 of 2011)

Name of Political Party: ALL INDIA TRINAMOOOL CONGRESS

*Name of the Election: GENERAL ELECTION TO THE LEGISLATIVE ASSEMBLY OF WEST BENGAL, 2026

Name of State/UT: WEST BENGAL

(1) Name of the Constituency - 212- Patashpur Assembly Constituency

Name of the candidate – Pijus Kanti Panda

Sl.no.			
1.	Criminal antecedents		
i)	a.	Nature of the offences	Offences alleged under: 1.Section 323of Indian Penal Code, 1860 2.Sections 447/188/34 of the Indian Penal Code, 1860 3.Sections 341/323/324/379/34 of the Indian Penal Code, 1860 4.Sections 147/148/149/341/323/506/427/34 of the Indian Penal Code 5.Section 500 of the Indian Penal Code, 1860
	b.	Case no.	1.N.G.R.(E) Case No. 103/2021 (arising out of GDE No. 736/2021, Patashpur Police Station, Purba Medinipur). 2.G.R.(E) Case No. 1117/2020 (arising out of P.S. Case No. 408/2020, Patashpur Police Station, Purba Medinipur). 3.G.R.(E). Case No. 527/2019 (arising out of P.S. Case No. 189/2019, Patashpur Police Station,Purba Medinipur). 4.G.R(E) Case No. 13/2013 (arising out of P.S. Case number No. 5/2013, Patashpur Police Station, Purba Medinipur) 5.CR No. 266/2022, Contai
	c.	Name of the Court	1.Learned 2nd Judicial Magistrate, Contai. 2.Learned 3rd Judicial Magistrate, Contai 3.Learned 2nd Judicial Magistrate, Contai. 4.Learned 1st Judicial Magistrate, Contai. 5.Learned 1nd Judicial Magistrate, Contai.
	d.	Whether charges have been framed or not (Yes/No)	1. Yes, on 24.02.2026 2. Yes, on 20.06.2024 3. Yes, on 04.01.2024 4. No 5. No
	e.	Date of conviction, if any	Not Applicable
	f.	Details of punishment undergone, if any	Not Applicable
	g.	Any other information required to be given	Not Applicable
2.	The reasons for the selection of the candidate. Selection shall be with reference to the qualifications, achievements and merit of the candidate, and not mere “winnability” at the polls (not more than 100 words)		The candidate’s extensive experience in agriculture has provided him with a profound understanding of rural challenges and opportunities. His practical knowledge and connection to the land enable him to effectively represent community interests and address pressing local needs, making him a strong and relatable representative.The proceedings initiated against him are false, frivolous, and devoid of merit, and therefore deserve no consideration. His selection is founded on his commitment to social welfare, integrity, and demonstrated contributions to society, rather than on mere electoral considerations.
3.	Reasons as to why other individuals without criminal antecedents could not be selected as candidates (not more than 100 words)		Same as above.

(2) Name of the Constituency – 212- Patashpur Assembly Constituency

Name of the candidate: Pijus Kanti Panda

* In the case of election to Council of States or States or election to Legislative Council by MLAs, mention the election concerned in place of name of Constituency.

Signature of office bearer of the Political Party

Name and Designation

Derek O’Brien

Member, National Working Committee

All India Trinamool Congress

Format C-7

(for political parties to publish in the newspapers, social media platforms & website of the party)

Information regarding individuals with pending criminal cases, who have been selected as candidates, along with the reasons for such selection, as also as to why other individuals without criminal antecedents could not be selected as candidates (As per the Commission’s directions issued in pursuance of the Order dated 13.02.2020 of the Hon’ble Supreme Court in contempt petition (C) no. 2192 of 2018 in WP(C) No. 536 of 2011)

Name of Political Party: ALL INDIA TRINAMOOOL CONGRESS

*Name of the Election: GENERAL ELECTION TO THE LEGISLATIVE ASSEMBLY OF WEST BENGAL, 2026

Name of State/UT: WEST BENGAL

(1) Name of the Constituency - 215- KhejuriAssembly Constituency

Name of the candidate –Rabin Chandra Mandal

Sl.no.			
1.	Criminal antecedents		
i)	a.	Nature of the offences	Offences alleged under Sections: 1.Sections406/418/420/468/474/471/506 /120B/34 of the Indian Penal Code, 1860. 2.Offences under NDPS Act, sections are unknown
	b.	Case no.	1.PalashiparaP.S. No. 62/2025, dated 03.02.2025, Police Station – Palashipara. 2.NDPS Case No. 41/2022 (arising out of NabagramP.S. Case Number 32/2022, dated 01.02.2022, Nabagram Police Station), and an adjudication proceeding bearing Memo No. STF/ Dy.SP (F.I.)/25/04, dated 11.04.2025, is pending before competent authority, in this connection.
	c.	Name of the Court	1.Learned Additional Chief Judicial Magistrate atTehatta, Nadia. 2.Learned 2nd Additional Session Judge, Murshidabad.
	d.	Whether charges have been framed or not (Yes/No)	1. No 2. No
	e.	Date of conviction, if any	Not Applicable
	f.	Details of punishment undergone, if any	Not Applicable
	g.	Any other information required to be given	Not Applicable
2.	The reasons for the selection of the candidate. Selection shall be with reference to the qualifications, achievements and merit of the candidate, and not mere “winnability” at the polls (not more than 100 words)		As a social worker, the candidate has demonstrated a deep commitment to community welfare, addressing issues and empowering individuals. His experience has equipped him with the empathy, understanding, and leadership skills necessary to effectively represent and serve the community’s interests.
3.	Reasons as to why other individuals without criminal antecedents could not be selected as candidates (not more than 100 words)		Same as above.

(2) Name of the Constituency – 215- KHEJURIASSEMBLY CONSTITUENCY

Name of the candidate: Rabin Chandra Mandal

* In the case of election to Council of States or States or election to Legislative Council by MLAs, mention the election concerned in place of name of Constituency.

Signature of office bearer of the Political Party

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Name of Political Party: ALL INDIA TRINAMOOOL CONGRESS

*Name of the Election: GENERAL ELECTION TO THE LEGISLATIVE ASSEMBLY OF WEST BENGAL 2026

Name of State/UT: WEST BENGAL

(1) Name of the Constituency - 55 - Farakka Assembly Constituency

(2) Name of the candidate – Md. Amirul Islam

Sl.no.			
1.	Criminal antecedents		
i)	a.	Nature of the offences	Offences alleged under: 1. Sections 341/324/325/427/109/34 of the Indian Penal Code, 1860. 2. Sections 341/323/324/325/379/506/34 of the Indian Penal Code, 1860. 3. Sections 341/325/354/506/509/34 of the Indian Penal Code, 1860.
	b.	Case no.	1. G.R. Case No.946/2016 (arising out of P.S. Case NO. 104/2016, dated 16.04.2016, Samserganj Police Station, Murshidabad). 2. G.R. Case No. 182/2015 (arising out of P.S. case no. 40/2015, dated 22.01.2015,Samserganj Police Station, Murshidabad) 3. G.R. Case No. 2332/2024 (arising out of P.S. Case No. 420/2014, dated 03.11.2014,Samserganj Police Station)
	c.	Name of the Court	1. Jangipur Court. 2. Jangupur Court. 3. Jangipur Court.
	d.	Whether charges have been framed or not (Yes/No)	1. No 2. No 3. No
	e.	Date of conviction, if any	Not Applicable
	f.	Details of punishment undergone, if any	Not Applicable
	g.	Any other information required to be given	Not Applicable
2.	The reasons for the selection of the candidate. Selection shall be with reference to the qualifications, achievements and merit of the candidate, and not mere “winnability” at the polls (not more than 100 words)		The candidate’s extensive community service and deep understanding of local issues, coupled with his passion for rural development, make him a well-rounded and suitable representative for the area, equipped to address community needs and work towards sustainable progress. The proceedings initiated against him are falseand therefore deserve no consideration. His selection is founded on his commitment to social welfare, integrity, and demonstrated contributions to society, rather than on mere electoral considerations.
3.	Reasons as to why other individuals without criminal antecedents could not be selected as candidates (not more than 100 words)		Same as above.

(3) Name of the Constituency – 55-FARAKKA ASSEMBLY CONSTITUENCY

(4) Name of the candidate: Md. Amirul Islam

* In the case of election to Council of States or States or election to Legislative Council by MLAs, mention the election concerned in place of name of Constituency.

Signature of office bearer of the Political Party

Name and Designation



Derek O’Brien

National Working Committee Member

All India Trinamool Congress

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Information regarding individuals with pending criminal cases, who have been selected as candidates, along with the reasons for such selection, as also as to why other individuals without criminal antecedents could not be selected as candidates

(As per the Commission’s directions issued in pursuance of the Order dated 13.02.2020 of the Hon’ble Supreme Court in contempt petition (C) no. 2192 of 2018 in WP(C) No. 536 of 2011)

Name of Political Party: ALL INDIA TRINAMOOOL CONGRESS

*Name of the Election: GENERAL ELECTION TO THE LEGISLATIVE ASSEMBLY OF WEST BENGAL, 2026

Name of State/UT: WEST BENGAL

(1) Name of the Constituency - 254- Onda Assembly Constituency

Name of the candidate –Subrata Dutta

Sl.no.			
1.	Criminal antecedents		
i)	a.	Nature of the offences	Offences alleged under: 1.Sections 126(2)/115(2)/118(1)/117(2)/109/76/324(4)/303(2)/351(2)(3)/3(5) of B.N.S, 2023 2.Sections 147/148/149/337/338 of Indian Penal Code, 1860 and Sections 3/4 of E.S. Act 1908 3.Sections 341/323/325/308/379/427/34 of Indian Penal Code, 1860
	b.	Case no.	1.G.R. Case No. 1618 of 25 (arising out of PS Case No. 276/2025, dated 08/11/2025, PatrasayerPolice Station) 2.G.R. Case No. 1123 of 17 (arising out of PS Case No. 28/2017, dated 19/11/2017, PatrasayerPolice Station) 3.G.R. Case No. 496 of 17 (arising out of PS Case No. 92/2017, dated 14/05/2017, PatrasayerPolice Station)
	c.	Name of the Court	1. Learned A.C.J.M at Bishnupur 2. Learned A.C.J.M at Bishnupur 3. Learned A.C.J.M at Bishnupur
	d.	Whether charges have been framed or not (Yes/No)	1. No 2. No 3. No
	e.	Date of conviction, if any	Not Applicable
	f.	Details of punishment undergone, if any	Not Applicable
	g.	Any other information required to be given	Not Applicable
2.	The reasons for the selection of the candidate. Selection shall be with reference to the qualifications, achievements and merit of the candidate, and not mere “winnability” at the polls (not more than 100 words)		The candidate is an experienced grassroots political worker with strong public engagement. He serves as a voice for underprivileged and marginalized communities. He accessibility, close connection with the community, and consistent commitment to public service make him a suitable candidate for legislative responsibilities.
3.	Reasons as to why other individuals without criminal antecedents could not be selected as candidates (not more than 100 words)		Same as above.

(2) Name of the Constituency – 254- Onda Assembly Constituency

Name of the candidate: Subrata Dutta

* In the case of election to Council of States or States or election to Legislative Council by MLAs, mention the election concerned in place of name of Constituency.

Signature of office bearer of the Political Party

Name and Designation



Derek O’Brien

Member, National Working Committee

All India Trinamool Congress

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Information regarding individuals with pending criminal cases, who have been selected as candidates, along with the reasons for such selection, as also as to why other individuals without criminal antecedents could not be selected as candidates (As per the Commission's directions issued in pursuance of the Order dated 13.02.2020 of the Hon'ble Supreme Court in contempt petition (C) no. 2192 of 2018 in WP(C) No. 536 of 2011)

Name of Political Party: **ALL INDIA TRINAMOOL CONGRESS**

*Name of the Election: **GENERAL ELECTION TO THE LEGISLATIVE ASSEMBLY OF WEST BENGAL, 2026**

Name of State/UT: **WEST BENGAL**

(1) Name of the Constituency - **211- Chandipur Legislative Assembly Constituency**

Name of the candidate – **Uttam Barik**

Sl.no.	Criminal antecedents		
1.	Criminal antecedents		
i)	a.	Nature of the offences	Offences alleged under: 1.Sections 420/406of Indian Penal Code, 1860 2.Sections 341/383/420/421/120B/34 of the Indian Penal Code, 1860 3.Sections 427/323/307/354/379/34 of the Indian Penal Code, 1860
	b.	Case no.	1.G.R. Case No. 1616/2013 (arising out of FIR No. 151/2013, Janka Police Station, Khejuri). 2.G.R. Case No. 996/2013 (arising out of FIR No. 189/2013, Contai Police Station, Purba Medinipur). 3.S.C. Case No. 435/2020 (arising out of FIR No. 211/2011, Contai Police StationPurba Medinipur).
	c.	Name of the Court	1.Learned Additional Chief Judicial Magistrate, Contai. 2.Learned 2ndJudicial Magistrate, Contai 3.Learned 1st Track, 1st Court, Contai
	d.	Whether charges have been framed or not (Yes/No)	1. No 2. Yes, on 19.01.2021 3. No
	e.	Date of conviction, if any	Not Applicable
	f.	Details of punishment undergone, if any	Not Applicable
	g.	Any other information required to be given	Not Applicable
2.	The reasons for the selection of the candidate. Selection shall be with reference to the qualifications, achievements and merit of the candidate, and not mere “winnability” at the polls (not more than 100 words)		He is a determined social worker who remains highly responsive to the concerns of constituents, demonstrating a strong familiarity with local social and developmental issues. The candidate holds experience as a grassroots political worker, coupled with his deep understanding of community needs, makes him an ideal representative. His strong public engagement and accessibility have allowed him to effectively serve as a voice for the underprivileged, demonstrating his potential to be a dedicated and responsive legislator.The proceedings initiated against him are false, frivolous, and devoid of merit, and therefore deserve no consideration. His selection is founded on his commitment to social welfare, integrity, and demonstrated contributions to society, rather than on mere electoral considerations.
3.	Reasons as to why other individuals without criminal antecedents could not be selected as candidates (not more than 100 words)		Same as above.

(2) Name of the Constituency – **211- Chandipur Legislative Assembly Constituency**

Name of the candidate: **Uttam Barik**

* In the case of election to Council of States or States or election to Legislative Council by MLAs, mention the election concerned in place of name of Constituency.

Signature of office bearer of the Political Party
Name and Designation



Derek O'Brien
Member, National Working Committee
All India Trinamool Congress

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Information regarding individuals with pending criminal cases, who have been selected as candidates, along with the reasons for such selection, as also as to why other individuals without criminal antecedents could not be selected as candidates

(As per the Commission's directions issued in pursuance of the Order dated 13.02.2020 of the Hon'ble Supreme Court in contempt petition (C) no. 2192 of 2018 in WP(C) No. 536 of 2011)

Name of Political Party: **ALL INDIA TRINAMOOL CONGRESS**

***Name of the Election: GENERAL ELECTION TO THE LEGISLATIVE ASSEMBLY OF WEST BENGAL, 2026**

Name of State/UT: **WEST BENGAL**

(1) Name of the Constituency - **17- Jalpaiguri (SC) Assembly Constituency**

Name of the candidate –**Krishna Das**

Sl.no.			
1.	Criminal antecedents		
i)	a.	Nature of the offences	Offences alleged under: 1.Sections 341/325/506/34 of Indian Penal Code, 1860 2.Sections 341/323/325/506/34 of Indian Penal Code, 1860 3.Sections 448/427/379/34 of Indian Penal Code, 1860 4.Sections 341/323/325/34 of Indian Penal Code, 1860 5.Sections 143/447/506 of Indian Penal Code, 1860 6.Sections 143/186/341/353/506 of Indian Penal Code, 1860 7.Section 326 of Indian Penal Code, 1860 8.Sections 448/506/171C/171E/171F/34 of Indian Penal Code, 1860 9.Sections 323(3)/329(4)/115(2)/74/303(2)/351(2)/3(5)of Bhartiya Nyaya Sanhita Act, 2023 10.Sections329(4)/115(2)/117(2)/118(2)/74/109/351(2)/3(5) of Bhartiya Nyaya Sanhita Act, 2023 11.Sections 115(2)/126(2)/127(2)/351(2)/3(5) of Bhartiya Nyaya Sanhita Act, 2023
	b.	Case no.	1.G.R. Case No. 2316 of 08 (arising out of FIRNo. 145/ 08, dated 11.05.2008, Kotwali Police Station) 2.G.R. Case No. 4960 of 10 (arising out of FIR No. 996/ 10, dated 29.12.2010, Kotwali Police Station) 3.G.R. Case No. 3768 of 08 (arising out of FIR No. 206/ 08, dated 08.02.2008, Kotwali Police Station) 4.G.R. Case No. 2581 of 09 (arising out of FIR No. 481/ 09, dated 06.08.2009, Kotwali Police Station) 5.G.R. Case No. 2912 of 07 (arising out of FIR No. 513/ 07, dated 09.09.2007, Kotwali Police Station) 6.G.R. Case No. 653 of 01 (arising out of FIR No. 155/ 01, dated 08.05.2001, Kotwali Police Station) 7.G.R. Case No. 3795 of 10 (arising out of FIR No. 210/ 10, dated 04.10.2010, Rajganj Police Station) 8.G.R. Case No. 1677/24 (arising out of FIR No. 260/ 2024, dated 08.04.2024, Kotwali Police Station) 9.G.R. Case No. 5095/24 (arising out of FIR No. 803/24, dated 22.11.2024, Kotwali Police Station) 10.G.R. Case No. 4771 of 24, (arising out of FIR No. 640/24, dated 23.09.2024, Kotwali Police Station) 11.Case No. 41 of 26, dated 28.01.2026, Kotwali Police Station
	c.	Name of the Court	1.Learned J.M First Court, Jalpaiguri 2.Learned C.J.M Court, Jalpaiguri 3.Learned C.J.M Court, Jalpaiguri 4.Learned C.J.M Court, Jalpaiguri 5.Learned J.M Second Court, Jalpaiguri 6.Learned J.M Third Court, Jalpaiguri 7.Learned J.M Second Court, Jalpaiguri 8.Learned C.J.M Court, Jalpaiguri 9.Learned C.J.M Court, Jalpaiguri 10.Learned C.J.M Court, Jalpaiguri 11.Learned C.J.M Court, Jalpaiguri
	d.	Whether charges have been framed or not (Yes/No)	1. Yes 2. Yes 3. Yes 4. No 5. No 6. No 7. No 8. No 9. No 10. No 11. No
	e.	Date of conviction, if any	Not Applicable
	f.	Details of punishment undergone, if any	Not Applicable
	g.	Any other information required to be given	Not Applicable
2.	The reasons for the selection of the candidate. Selection shall be with reference to the qualifications, achievements and merit of the candidate, and not mere “winnability” at the polls (not more than 100 words)		The candidate is an experienced grassroots political worker with strong public engagement. He serves as a voice for underprivileged and marginalized communities. His accessibility, close connection with the community, and consistent commitment to public service make him a suitable candidate for legislative responsibilities.
3.	Reasons as to why other individuals without criminal antecedents could not be selected as candidates (not more than 100 words)		Same as above.

(2) Name of the Constituency – **17- Jalpaiguri (SC) Assembly Constituency**

Name of the candidate: **Krishna Das**

* In the case of election to Council of States or States or election to Legislative Council by MLAs, mention the election concerned in place of name of Constituency.

Signature of office bearer of the Political Party
Name and Designation

Derek O'Brien
Member, National Working Committee
All India Trinamool Congress

OMCs to pay discounted rates to refiners amid fuel price freeze

The oil marketing companies on March 26 fixed rates for petroleum products that are at discount of up to Rs 60/litre to their imported cost

NEW DELHI: In a first since fuel price deregulation, Indian state-run oil marketing companies will pay refineries a discounted price for petrol, diesel, aviation turbine fuel (ATF) and kerosene to limit mounting losses from a self-imposed freeze on retail fuel prices, sources said.

The oil marketing companies (OMCs) on March 26 fixed rates for petroleum products that are at a discount of up to Rs 60 per litre to their imported cost, two people with direct knowledge of the matter said.

The discounted rates, which are applicable with effect from March 16, will hit standalone refiners such as MRPL, CPCL and HMEL the most.



The discounted rates, which are applicable with effect from March 16, will hit standalone refiners such as MRPL, CPCL and HMEL the most

Highlights

» Global oil prices have risen from about \$70/ barrel to over \$100, but retail fuel prices have remained unchanged

» With no immediate end to the conflict in sight, OMCs have decided to fix a discount on the RTP

» For the second half of March, a discount of Rs 22,342 per kilolitre was fixed on diesel to bring down the RTP of Rs 85,349 per kl to Rs 63,007 per kl

International oil prices have risen from about \$70 per barrel before the Middle East conflict to over \$100, but retail petrol and diesel prices in India have remained unchanged, forcing OMCs to absorb the impact.

With no immediate end to the conflict in sight, OMCs have decided to fix a discount on the refinery transfer price (RTP) - the internal price at which refineries sell fuel to marketing arms - to effectively pay refineries less than the import-parity cost of the fuels like petrol and diesel.

For the second half of March, a discount of Rs 22,342

per kilolitre (Rs 22.34 per litre) was fixed on diesel to bring down the RTP of Rs 85,349 per kl to Rs 63,007 per kl.

For the first fortnight of April, the discount on diesel has been fixed at Rs 60,239 per kl to lower RTP from Rs 146,243 per kl to Rs 86,004 per kl.

On ATF, the RTP has been slashed to Rs 76,923 per kl from Rs 127,486 per kl after considering a discount of Rs 50,564 per kl. The RTP for kerosene after a discount of Rs 46,311 per kl has been fixed at Rs 77,534 per kl from Rs 123,845 per kl,

West Asia conflict caps home prices in top 7 cities in Jan–March: Anarock

NEW DELHI: India's top seven housing markets saw a muted 2 per cent growth in average prices during January-March against the previous quarter as sales fell amid negative consumer sentiments because of the West Asia conflict, according to Anarock.

Real estate consultant Anarock data showed that the average housing prices across seven major cities rose to Rs 9,456 per square feet in January-March from Rs 9,260 per square feet in the preceding quarter.

On an annual basis, the prices rose 7 per cent from Rs 8,868 per square feet in January-March 2025.

Anarock tracks primary (first sale) housing markets of seven cities — Mumbai Metropolitan Region (MMR), Delhi-NCR, Bengaluru, Pune, Hyderabad, Chennai and Kolkata.

Anarock pointed out that housing sales across these seven cities fell 7 per cent in volume terms and 6 per cent value-wise during January-March 2026 from the previous quarter. This kept prices under check to a large extent.

As per the data, the average housing price in Delhi-NCR appreciated 3 per cent

in January-March to Rs 9,620 per square feet from Rs 9,300 per square feet in the preceding quarter. Rates rose 15 per cent from Rs 8,330 per square feet in the same period last year.

In MMR, the rates grew 1 per cent to Rs 17,600 during January-March 2026 from Rs 17,350 per square feet in the preceding quarter. On an annual basis, the prices went up 4 per cent from Rs 16,900 per square feet in January-March 2025.

The average prices in Bengaluru rose 2 per cent to Rs 9,310 in January-March 2026 from Rs 9,100 per square feet in the preceding quarter. The city saw an 8 per cent annual appreciation from Rs 8,650 per square feet in the January-March 2025.

In Pune, the prices of residential properties rose 2 per cent to Rs 8,220 in January-March this year, from Rs 8,050 per square feet in the preceding quarter.

A 5 per cent increase was recorded from Rs 7,800 per square feet in the January-March period last year.

Hyderabad saw a 2 per cent price appreciation to Rs 7,990 per square feet in January-March quarter this year, from Rs 7,830 per square feet in the preceding quarter. The rates

grew 6 per cent annually from Rs 7,550 per square feet in January-March 2025.

In Chennai, the average housing prices grew just 1 per cent to Rs 7,165 per square feet during January-March this year from Rs 7,100 a square feet in the preceding quarter. The rates increased 4 per cent annually from Rs 6,900 per square feet in the January-March period last year.

The average housing prices in Kolkata went up 3 per cent in January-March 2026 to Rs 6,290 from Rs 6,120 per square feet in the preceding quarter. The rates grew 6 per cent annually from Rs 5,950 per square feet in January-March last year.

Anarock Chairman Anuj Puri noted that the "short-term tremors of the Iran War were clearly visible in the first quarter." He pointed out that the war-induced uncertainty has affected buying sentiments, particularly in March.

"The decline in sales also aligns with large numbers of prospective Middle East homebuyers, who invest significantly in Indian real estate, hitting the pause button under the war cloud," Puri said. He, however, noted that the long-term outlook for India's housing market remains positive.

IIFCL to double InvITs exposure to ₹6,000 crore this fiscal

NEW DELHI: State-owned India Infrastructure Finance Company Ltd (IIFCL) is aiming to double its exposure in Infrastructure Investment Trusts (InvITs) to Rs 6,000 crore during the ongoing fiscal year as part of its investment diversification strategy.

IIFCL has exposure of about Rs 3,000 crore across nine InvITs as of March 31, 2026.

"We hope to double our investment in InvITs during the current financial year. It should reach Rs 6,000 crore by the end of March 2027," IIFCL MD Rohit Rishi said.

Highlighting the importance of the infrastructure sector, he said, it is going to play a central role in sustaining the country's long-term economic growth and achieving the goal of Viksit Bharat by 2047.

Rishi emphasised India's resilience amid global uncertainties and underscored the central role of infrastructure in sustaining long-term economic growth. The expanding opportunities across transport, urban infrastructure, and clean energy is being supported by a strong policy push and a robust pipeline of projects.

Draft IPO filings surge to 38 companies in March 2026 on improving issuer sentiment

This marks a sharp jump from 22 filings in March 2025 and 16 in March 2024, data from the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) showed

NEW DELHI: As many as 38 companies, including SBI Funds Management and Manipal Health Enterprises, filed preliminary IPO papers with Sebi in March 2026, signalling improving issuer sentiment even as regulatory timelines contributed to the surge.

This marks a sharp jump from 22 filings in March 2025 and 16 in March 2024, data from the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) showed.

The momentum is expected to continue, with several high-profile companies, including the NSE and Reliance Industries' telecom arm Jio, preparing to submit their draft papers in the coming weeks, according to merchant banking sources.

In addition, Singapore-based Sembcorp Industries' Indian renewable energy arm, Sweden-based Modern Times Group's subsidiary PlaySimple, TPG-backed online lending

CLOSER LOOK

» Momentum is likely to continue, with several high-profile cos, including the NSE & Reliance's telecom arm Jio, preparing to submit their draft papers in coming weeks

» So far in 2026, 18 companies have launched IPOs, with 8 issues hitting the market in March alone

» Digital payments company PhonePe temporarily deferred its public market listing process due to the current geopolitical conflicts and market volatility

platform Fibe and Tiger Global-backed BatterySmart are also likely to file DRHPs soon, they added.

Of the 38 companies that filed their draft papers with Sebi, a total of 9 firms, including Zetwerk, SNVA Traveltech, Rediff.com India, Torrent Gas, Synergy Advanced Metals, Garuda Aerospace, and Sohan Lal Commodity Management, opted for the confidential filing route.

According to an Axis Capital report, as many as 64 companies have filed Draft Red Herring Prospectuses (DRHPs) with Sebi and are awaiting clearance, while 124 companies have already received regulatory approval but are yet to hit the market. Another 20 firms have filed confidential DRHPs since March 2025.

The report further noted that FY26 (up to March-end) saw 109 mainboard IPOs, of

which 69 listed above their issue price, while three companies were yet to debut on the exchanges as of March 31, 2026.

The IPO market is expected to gain further momentum in the first quarter of FY2026-27, supported by a robust pipeline, with a large number of companies both awaiting Sebi approval and holding valid approvals for launch, it added.

So far in 2026, 18 companies have launched IPOs, with 8 issues hitting the market in March alone despite volatile market conditions and geopolitical tensions.

On the other hand, digital payments company PhonePe temporarily deferred its public market listing process due to the current geopolitical conflicts and market volatility. However, Sameer Nigam, PhonePe's CEO, stated the company remains committed to a public listing in India.

Oil India ramps up crude output from Rajasthan's Thar desert

OUR CORRESPONDENT

JAIPUR: Amid heightened geopolitical tensions and uncertainty in global oil markets, Oil India Ltd has significantly ramped up crude production from Rajasthan's Thar desert, achieving a record output of 1,202 barrels per day (bpd) from the Jodhpur sandstone formation, officials said.

The state-run company has increased production by around 70 per cent compared to last year's 705 barrels per day, marking a major milestone in efforts to boost domestic output and strengthen energy security.

Officials said the crude oil produced in the Baghwala field in Jaisalmer is transported by tankers to Oil and Natural Gas Corporation (ONGC) facilities in Mehsana, Gujarat, from where it is sent via pipeline to the Koyali refinery operated by Indian Oil Corporation Ltd (IOCL).

In the financial year 2025-26, Oil India's Rajasthan field recorded an annual production of 43,773 metric tonnes of crude oil, up from 32,787 metric tonnes in the previous year, reflecting strong growth driven by technological advancements



and efficient operations.

Company officials said the success is largely attributed to the deployment of advanced recovery techniques, including Cyclic Steam Stimulation (CSS), a thermal enhanced oil recovery method used for extracting high-viscosity crude.

"This is a significant achievement, especially considering the challenging geological conditions of the Thar region. It underlines the potential of unconventional resources in contributing to India's energy needs," an official said.

The Baghwala oil field, located in the Bikaner-Nagaur sub-basin of the Rajasthan basin, is among the few onshore heavy oil fields in India. Oil India has completed CSS operations in 19 wells, around 72 per cent higher than last year, and drilled 13 new wells during the year, up from nine earlier.

The company has also

deployed advanced drilling and production technologies such as fishbone drilling and barefoot completion, being used for the first time in India's heavy oil reserves, along with electric downhole heaters, hydraulic sucker rod pumps, and high-temperature thermal wellheads to enhance production efficiency.

Officials said that due to the high viscosity of crude in the region, conventional extraction methods were not viable, prompting the adoption of innovative approaches such as diluent injection and artificial lift systems.

Oil India has been producing heavy crude from the Baghwala field since 2017. The field, discovered in 1991 and spread over 200.26 square kilometres, currently has 52 wells, of which 33 are operational.

The successful implementation of CSS technology, first piloted in 2018, has been a game-changer, enabling large-scale extraction and setting new benchmarks in thermal enhanced oil recovery in India.

Officials said the achievement will play a key role in reducing India's dependence on imported crude and enhancing long-term energy resilience.

Format C-7

(for political parties to publish in the newspapers, social media platforms & website of the party)

Information regarding individuals with pending criminal cases, who have been selected as candidates, along with the reasons for such selection, as also as to why other individuals without criminal antecedents could not be selected as candidates

(As per the Commission's directions issued in pursuance of the Order dated 13.02.2020 of the Hon'ble Supreme Court in contempt petition (C) no. 2192 of 2018 in WP(C) No. 536 of 2011)

Name of Political Party: ALL INDIA TRINAMOOOL CONGRESS

*Name of the Election: GENERAL ELECTION TO THE LEGISLATIVE ASSEMBLY OF WEST BENGAL 2026

Name of State/UT: WEST BENGAL

(1) Name of the Constituency - 253- Barjora Assembly Constituency

(2) Name of the candidate – Goutam Mishra

Sl.no.			
1.	Criminal antecedents		
i)	a.	Nature of the offences	Offences alleged under: Sections 498(A)/406/323/34 of Indian Penal Code, 1860
	b.	Case no.	G.R. Case No. 798 of 23 (arising out of FIR No. 17/2023, dated 02/08/2023, Bidhannagar Women Police Station)
	c.	Name of the Court	Learned A.C.J.M Court at Bidhannagar, North 24 Pargana
	d.	Whether charges have been framed or not (Yes/No)	Yes, on 20/09/2024 under Sections 498(A)/34 of Indian Penal Code, 1860
	e.	Date of conviction, if any	Not Applicable
	f.	Details of punishment undergone, if any	Not Applicable
	g.	Any other information required to be given	Not Applicable
2.	The reasons for the selection of the candidate. Selection shall be with reference to the qualifications, achievements and merit of the candidate, and not mere "winnability" at the polls (not more than 100 words)		The Candidate has been selected based on his active involvement in community outreach and a demonstrated commitment to addressing local issues. His visibility in public life, participation in organisational activities, and ability to engage meaningfully with constituents reflect his merit and leadership potential. He is also actively engaged in social and philanthropic initiatives within his constituency.
3.	Reasons as to why other individuals without criminal antecedents could not be selected as candidates (not more than 100 words)		Same as above.

(3) Name of the Constituency – 253- BARJORA ASSEMBLY CONSTITUENCY

(4) Name of the candidate: Goutam Mishra

* In the case of election to Council of States or States or election to Legislative Council by MLAs, mention the election concerned in place of name of Constituency.

Signature of office bearer of the Political Party

Name and Designation

Derek O'Brien

National Working Committee Member

All India Trinamool Congress

Moody’s cuts India’s economic growth estimates to 6% for FY27

West Asia accounts for 55% of oil & over 90% of India’s LPG imports

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Moody’s Ratings has slashed India’s economic growth estimates for the current fiscal to 6 per cent from 6.8 per cent earlier, saying the ongoing conflict in West Asia will moderate growth momentum and raise inflation risks.

In its credit opinion report on India, Moody’s said prolonged disruptions, particularly LPG shipments due to the conflict, would lead to near-term household shortages, higher fuel and transport costs, and spillovers to food inflation through India’s reliance on imported fertilisers. The region accounts for around 55 per cent of crude oil imports and over 90 per cent of liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) supplies to India.

“While inflation remains contained for now, geopolitical risks have tilted the inflation outlook to the upside,” Moody’s said while projecting inflation to average 4.8 per cent in FY27, up from 2.4 per cent in FY26.

With inflation risks re-emerging and growth remaining robust, policy rates are likely to be held steady or raised gradually in fiscal 2026–27, depending on the duration of geopolitical tensions and their pass-through to food and fuel prices, Moody’s said.



“WHILE INFLATION REMAINS CONTAINED FOR NOW, GEOPOLITICAL RISKS HAVE TILTED INFLATION OUTLOOK TO THE UPSIDE”

“In light of India’s economic exposure to the ongoing military conflict in the Middle East, we expect real GDP growth to moderate to 6 per cent in fiscal 2026–27 from 6.8 per cent earlier, driven by subdued private consumption, softer industrial activity and a weakening in the momentum of gross fixed capital formation amid elevated prices and higher input costs,” according to the Moody’s report, dated March 31.

Last month, the Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD) projected India’s GDP growth to

Highlights

- » With inflation risks re-emerging and growth remaining robust, policy rates are likely to be held steady or raised gradually in FY27
- » In March, OECD projected India’s GDP growth at 6.1% in FY27 from 7.6% growth in FY26
- » India’s real GDP growth remained robust at 7.5 per cent in calendar year 2025, up from 7.2 per cent in CY 2024

moderate to 6.1 per cent in the current fiscal from 7.6 per cent growth recorded in 2025–26.

Besides, an Economy Watch report by EY has said that India’s real GDP growth for FY27 could erode by around 1 percentage point, while retail inflation could rise by about 1.5 percentage points from their baseline estimates if the West Asia conflict persists through 2026–27.

Domestic rating agency Icrs expects the growth to moderate to 6.5 per cent in FY27, owing to the adverse impact of elevated energy prices and concerns around energy availability

amid the West Asia conflict.

It further said the government’s sustained emphasis on infrastructure spending and a gradual easing of trade barriers will continue to support investment activity.

India’s real GDP growth remained robust at 7.5 per cent in calendar year 2025, up from 7.2 per cent in CY 2024 and the highest among G-20 economies, driven primarily by a strong rebound in manufacturing.

Moody’s said elevated oil, gas and fertiliser prices would intensify pressures on targeted subsidies, resulting in higher outlays, alongside revenue erosion compared to the budget.

The recent cut in excise duty on petrol and diesel will hurt tax receipts. Besides, persistently high input costs weigh on household consumption and compress corporate profitability, softening GST collections and corporate income tax revenues.

“Taken together, we expect higher expenditure commitments and weaker revenue mobilisation to constrain fiscal space and slow the pace of fiscal consolidation in the absence of offsetting revenue measures or expenditure rationalisation,” it added. Moody’s expects gradual debt consolidation, consistent with the government’s medium-term objective of reducing cen-

tral government debt to around 50 per cent of GDP by 2030–31 from around 57 per cent of GDP in 2024–25.

In CY 2025, India’s current account deficit marginally narrowed to around 0.4 per cent of GDP from 0.9 per cent in the previous year, and is expected to remain around 1–1.5 per cent of GDP for 2026 and 2027.

The stable external position is largely attributed to a gradual increase in goods exports offset by high goods imports, particularly in imported fuels and raw materials. The agency expects goods and services exports to remain broadly stable, even as goods imports will expand on the back of higher global commodity prices, depending on the duration of the ongoing conflict in West Asia, widening India’s current account deficit.

It also expects India to face higher import costs, as it secures alternative and potentially more expensive supplies of fertilisers and gas. Trade disruptions affecting West Asia, a key market for India’s agricultural exports, will also dampen external demand, further contributing to a widening of the current account deficit. Remittance inflows form another vulnerability, as the Gulf region accounts for about 40 per cent of total such flows, Moody’s said.

Economists see RBI holding rates in April monetary policy review

OUR CORRESPONDENT

MUMBAI: The Reserve Bank is likely to keep the benchmark policy repo rate unchanged at 5.25 per cent in the April monetary policy review meeting, as the West Asia crisis is likely to push up inflation, according to economists.

The continuing geopolitical tensions in West Asia, volatility in commodity prices and sharp currency movement that have seen the rupee hit record lows have complicated the policy outlook, and its projections on growth, inflation and also the stance of policy will be keenly watched, the poll of over a dozen economists said.

“Given the uncertainty around crude oil prices and geopolitical developments, the RBI is likely to remain on pause in the April policy and closely monitor incoming inflation data before taking any further action,” said Aditi Nayar, Chief Economist at ICRA.

SBI’s chief economist Soumya Kanti Ghosh said while announcing the pause, the RBI will be careful in communicating its decision.

“India is not unscathed from the current crisis and is feeling the mercury rising. Rupee is already hovering above 93 per dollar, and crude oil is adamant above \$100 per barrel, resulting in a jump in imported inflation across states,” Ghosh said, adding that the projected “super El Nino” will also put pressure on inflation.

Dipti Deshpande, principal economist, Crisil, said

While announcing the pause, the RBI will be careful in communicating its decision, SBI’s chief economist Soumya Kanti Ghosh said

under the base case expectation that inflation stays close to the MPC’s target, the monetary policy may look through this supply shock and will keep rates on hold.

The central bank has so far reduced the repo rate by 1.25 per cent since last February, as the cool down in inflation offered it the space to work towards further boosting growth. However, the central bank kept the rate unchanged in the August, October and February 2026 monetary policies.

The six-member monetary policy committee is scheduled to start its April policy review meeting on Monday, and the final vote on one of the most challenging policy reviews will happen on Wednesday.

Economists noted that while retail inflation has moved closer to the RBI’s medium-term target of 4 per cent, the recent surge in global crude oil prices has raised concerns about potential second-round effects on domestic prices, particularly fuel, transportation, and core inflation components.

As per estimates, every \$10 increase in crude prices per

barrel stokes inflation by up to 0.60 per cent. Crude prices, which were in the \$60 per barrel vicinity for long, have hardened to over \$100 since the start of the conflict in late February. Additionally, the rupee has depreciated by over 4 per cent since the war, which has consequences for pushing up import inflation.

“We do not expect any change in repo rate or stance this time. The tone will be cautious, and what will be eagerly awaited is the RBI’s forecast of GDP and inflation under the prevailing uncertainty,” state-run lender Bank of Baroda’s chief economist Madan Sabnavis said.

HDFC Bank’s principal economist, Sakshi Gupta, however, advised that a rate decision based on short-term developments may not be prudent at this stage, especially when global commodity prices remain volatile. “The central bank would prefer to wait for clearer signals on the inflation trajectory,” said Gupta.

Several economists indicated that the RBI may reassess its inflation and growth projections in the upcoming policy to reflect evolving global risks.

There is a possibility that the central bank could revise its inflation forecast upward for the current financial year if crude oil prices remain elevated for a prolonged period.

Given the prevailing situation, the focus of the policy will turn towards managing inflation rather than supporting growth, the economists said.

‘RBI policy, West Asia conflict to drive markets this week’

NEW DELHI: The domestic stock market is expected to remain volatile this week as investors track the Reserve Bank’s monetary policy decision, key global macroeconomic data and the impact of the West Asia conflict, analysts said.

Movements in crude oil prices and foreign fund flows will also influence domestic equities, they added.

Vinod Nair, Head of Research, Geojit Investments Ltd, said the RBI’s Monetary Policy Committee (MPC) meeting will command centre stage domestically, with investors closely watching the central bank’s stance on inflation and growth.

In a holiday-shortened last week, the BSE benchmark Sensex declined 263.67 points, or 0.35 per cent, and the NSE Nifty fell 106.5 points, or 0.46 per cent.

Brent crude prices have remained elevated near \$107 per barrel, sustaining concerns around imported inflation. Currency pressures have also intensified, with the rupee weakening sharply before recovering towards Rs 93 against the US dollar, aided by RBI intervention, he added.

Foreign institutional investor (FII) selling remains another key overhang, with March witnessing intense outflows of Rs 1.2 lakh crore, among the highest monthly outflows in the last several years.

FPIs extend sell-off in April, pull out ₹19,837 crore in two sessions

NEW DELHI: Foreign Portfolio Investors (FPIs) continued to exit Indian equities, withdrawing Rs 19,837 crore (\$2.1 billion) in the first two trading sessions of April, weighed down by the West Asia conflict, rising crude oil prices, and persistent rupee depreciation.

This came following a record withdrawal of Rs 1.17 lakh crore (about \$12.7 billion) from domestic equities in March, making it the worst monthly outflow. Before this, FPIs pumped in Rs 22,615 crore in February, the highest monthly inflow in 17 months.

With the latest withdrawals, total FPIs outflow has reached Rs 1.5 lakh crore so far in 2026, according to NSDL data.

As per the data, FPIs continued to take out money in April, offloading equities worth Rs



19,837 crore in the cash market till April 2.

Market participants attributed the sustained selling pressure to global macroeconomic headwinds and heightened geopolitical uncertainty.

“Continuation of the war, crude again spiking to above \$100 level, the steady decline in the rupee and appreciation of the dollar triggered this record selling by FPIs,” said VK Vijayakumar, Chief Investment Strategist at Geojit Investments.

Moreover, the rupee has

depreciated by about 4 per cent since the war began, and fears of further depreciation have added to the weakness of the rupee, which, in turn, is triggering further selling by FPI, he added.

Additionally, elevated US bond yields have improved the relative attractiveness of fixed-income assets, prompting global investors to rebalance away from equities, said Himanshu Srivastava, Principal-Manager Research at Morningstar Investment Research India.

Vijayakumar said that sustained selling by the FPIs has made Indian market valuations fair and in some segments attractive, although FPI inflows can happen only when there is de-escalation on the war front, leading to a decline in crude oil prices.

NEW DELHI: The combined market valuation of six of the top-10 most valued firms declined by Rs 64,734.46 crore in a holiday-shortened last week, with Bharti Airtel taking the biggest hit, reflecting the broader weakness in the equities market.

Last week, the BSE benchmark Sensex declined 263.67 points, or 0.35 per cent, and the NSE Nifty fell 106.5 points, or 0.46 per cent.

The market valuation of Bharti Airtel eroded by Rs 29,993.07 crore to Rs 10,20,420.26 crore.

ICICI Bank’s valuation tanked by Rs 12,845.81 crore to Rs 8,70,705.49 crore.

Bajaj Finance lost Rs 11,169.36 crore from its market valuation, which stood at Rs 5,14,226.12 crore.

The market capitalisation (mcap) of HDFC Bank dropped by Rs 7,822.79 crore

Top 10 (BSE) Market Cap			
	₹ crore	As on April 2, 2026	Gain/Loss over March 27
RIL		18,28,034.07	▲ 3,518.45
HDFC Bank		11,56,195.90	▼ -7,822.79
Bharti Airtel		10,20,420.26	▼ -29,993.07
SBI		9,41,015.31	▼ -553.84
TCS		8,87,028.43	▲ 22,359.78
ICICI Bank		8,70,705.49	▼ -12,845.81
Infosys		5,27,409.43	▲ 12,374.76
Bajaj Finance		5,14,226.12	▼ -11,169.36
Larsen & Toubro		4,97,111.62	▲ 6,575.43
Hind Unilever		4,85,190.60	▼ -2,349.59

to Rs 11,56,195.90 crore, and that of Hindustan Unilever’s

mcap declined by Rs 2,349.59 crore to Rs 4,85,190.60 crore.

State Bank of India’s market capitalisation diminished by Rs 553.84 crore to Rs 9,41,015.31 crore.

In sharp contrast, the market valuation of Tata Consultancy Services (TCS) surged by Rs 22,359.78 crore to Rs 8,87,028.43 crore.

The mcap of Infosys soared by Rs 12,374.76 crore to Rs 5,27,409.43 crore, and that of Larsen & Toubro added Rs 6,575.43 crore to Rs 4,97,111.62 crore.

The market valuation of Reliance Industries gained Rs 3,518.45 crore to Rs 18,28,034.07 crore.

Reliance Industries retained the title of the most valued firm, followed by HDFC Bank, Bharti Airtel, State Bank of India (SBI), Tata Consultancy Services Ltd, ICICI Bank, Infosys, Bajaj Finance, Larsen & Toubro, and Hindustan Unilever.

NMDC to revise iron ore prices from April 5

NMDC registered its highest-ever iron ore production at 53 MT in FY26

NEW DELHI: The state-owned NMDC has revised the prices of its iron ore products, according to a regulatory filing with the National Stock Exchange of India.

In the filing made under the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015, the company said the revised prices will be effective from April 5, 2026.

According to the disclosure, the price of Baila Lump (65.5 per cent, 10–40 mm) has been fixed at Rs 5,300 per tonne, while Baila Fines (64 per cent, –10 mm) has been priced at Rs 4,500 per tonne.

“These prices are FOR



prices that are exclusive of Royalty, DMF, NMEDT, Cess, Forest Permit Fee, transit fee, GST, environmental Cess and other taxes,” the filing stated.

Earlier this week, NMDC also registered its highest-ever iron ore production at 53 million tonnes in the Financial year 2025–26, the Ministry of Steel said in a press release on Thursday.

The ministry noted that NMDC has emerged as the first company in the India mining history to surpass the 50 million tonnes annual production mark.

The company’s iron ore production jumped 51 per cent year-on-year to 5.35 million tonnes in March and posted a growth of a robust 40 per cent over the corresponding year in iron ore sales.

“The total production output reached 53.15 MT with a marvellous growth of 21 per cent, and sales reached 50.23 MT, with a 13 per cent jump, marking its best volumes since inception,” the Ministry said in its press release.

The Steel Ministry attributed its robust growth to NMDC’s major iron ore mines in Kirandul and Bachel in Chhattisgarh and Donimalai in Karnataka, recording their best-ever performance in company history.

“FY26 has also been a defining year of expansion and transformation for NMDC, with the inauguration of an international office in Dubai, the successful operationalisation of the first coal mine in Jharkhand and the commissioning of Deposit 4 at Bailadila in Chhattisgarh, further strengthening its production capabilities and diversification strategy,” the Ministry added.

Major ports record 915 MT cargo in FY26, surpass target of 904 MT

This marks 7.06% annual growth, reaffirming sector’s enhanced efficiency and sustained growth trajectory

NEW DELHI: In a significant achievement for India’s maritime sector, the Major Ports under the Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways have collectively handled 915.17 million tonnes of cargo during FY26, surpassing the annual target of 904 MT. This marks a year-on-year growth of 7.06 per cent, reaffirming the sector’s strong recovery, enhanced efficiency, and sustained growth trajectory. This milestone underscores the impact of transformative reforms and strategic investments undertaken by the Government of India to modernize port infrastructure,

enhance logistics efficiency, and strengthen India’s position as a leading maritime nation under the Maritime Amrit Kaal Vision 2047.

Union Minister of Ports, Shipping and Waterways, Sarbananda Sonowal, said, “The record cargo handling of over 915 million tonnes by our Major Ports is a testament to the Government’s unwavering commitment to strengthening India’s maritime sector. Guided by the vision of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, we are building world-class port infrastructure, improving efficiency, and enabling seamless logistics to

CLOSER LOOK

- » With inflation risks re-emerging and growth remaining robust, policy rates are likely to be held steady or raised
- » In March, OECD projected India’s GDP growth at 6.1% in FY27 from 7.6% growth in FY26India’s real GDP growth remained robust at 7.5 per cent

support India’s growing economy. This achievement reinforces our resolve to position India as a global maritime powerhouse under the Maritime Amrit Kaal Vision 2047.”

The performance reflects consistent growth across major ports, with Deendayal Port Authority emerging as

the top performer at 160.11 MT, followed by Paradip Port Authority at 156.45 MT, and Jawaharlal Nehru Port Authority (JNPA) at 102.01 MT. Other key ports including Visakhapatnam Port Authority, Mumbai Port Authority, Chennai Port Authority, and New Mangalore Port Authority also reg-

istered strong performance, contributing significantly to the overall cargo throughput. In terms of growth rate, Mormugao Port Authority recorded the highest increase at 15.91 per cent, followed by Kolkata Dock System at 14.28 per cent and JNPA at 10.74 per cent, reflecting improved efficiency and rising cargo volumes.

The sustained growth in cargo handling has been driven by capacity augmentation and modernization of port infrastructure, strengthened multimodal connectivity and seamless hinterland linkages, adoption of digital and

smart port initiatives, increased handling of key commodities including coal, crude oil, containers, fertilizers, and POL, as well as improved turnaround time and ease of doing business across ports. The Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways continues to advance a comprehensive maritime strategy focused on port-led development, logistics integration and sustainability. The record performance in FY26 reflects growing trade confidence and the effectiveness of policy measures aimed at enhancing operational efficiency, capacity utilization.

Gold imports rise 29% to \$69 bn in Apr–Feb 2025–26

NEW DELHI: India’s gold imports surged 28.73 per cent to \$69 billion during April–February FY26, driven by elevated prices, the commerce ministry data said. Imports had stood at \$53.52 billion in April–Feb FY25. The sharp rise widened the country’s trade deficit to \$310.60 billion in the 11-month period, up from \$261.80 billion a year ago.

Gold prices are currently hovering around Rs 1,51,500/10 grams in the national capital.

Switzerland remained the top source of imports with about 40 per cent share, fol-

lowed by the UAE (over 16 per cent) and South Africa (around 10 per cent). Gold accounts for more than 5 per cent of India’s total imports.

India, the world’s second-largest gold consumer after China, relies on imports largely to meet jewellery demand, impacting the current account deficit (CAD).

The CAD rose to \$13.2 billion (1.3 per cent of GDP) in December quarter, though it moderated to \$30.1 billion (1 per cent of GDP) during April–Dec 2025. Silver imports also rose 142.87 per cent to \$11.43 billion.

LSG BEAT SRH BY FIVE WICKETS

Shami sizzles, Pant dazzles as LSG open points account

HYDERABAD: Mohammed Shami asked probing questions not only to Sunrisers Hyderabad batters but also to the national selection committee with an opening spell for ages while skipper Rishabh Pant upped his game when it mattered to headline Lucknow Super Giants' thrilling five-wicket victory in an IPL match on Sunday.

In a spell that oozed skill and class in equal measure, Shami bowled an astounding 18 dot balls to finish with 2 for 9 in four overs which largely became responsible for Sunrisers Hyderabad being restricted to 156 for 9.

LSG rode on Aiden Markram's 27-ball-45 and skipper Rishabh Pant's 50-ball-68 not out to surpass the target with one ball to spare.

The chase got a touch tricky towards the end with 9 needed off the final over but Pant smote Jaydev Unadkat for two straight boundaries -- second a fore-hand tennis like slap before another lofted boundary over mid-off to finish the game in style.

It was an innings that had nine boundaries and his choice of strokes was measured on a slowish track where SRH spinners Harsh Dubey and Shvang Kumar made the ball talk.

But it was Shami, the 35-year-old artist, who set up the match in the LSG's bowling Powerplay itself. His scalps were the crack opening pair of Abhishek Sharma and Travis Head, dismissed off successive deliveries across two overs with different variation of slower deliveries.

Shami was ably supported by young Prince Yadav (2/34 in 4 overs), whose outswinger



Lucknow Super Giants' Mohammed Shami celebrates with teammates after dismissing Sunrisers Hyderabad's Travis Head during an IPL match against Sunrisers Hyderabad, at Rajiv Gandhi International Cricket Stadium, in Hyderabad on Sunday

14
There was a third act to the tale as SRH had another batting collapse losing five wickets for 14 runs in last 2.2 overs

(inswinger for Ishan Kishan) was the ball of the match.

While Pant would have fancied bowling SRH out for less than 100 after restricting them

to 26 for 4 at one stage, Heinrich Klaasen (62 off 41 balls) and all-rounder Nitish Kumar Reddy (56 off 33 balls) counter-attacked to add 116 runs for the fifth wicket.

But there was a third act to the tale as SRH had another batting collapse losing five wickets for 14 runs in last 2.2 overs.

During the chase, LSG did stutter in phases but Pant, who curbed his impetuosity showed glimpses of his vintage self but also concentrated on crossing the line.

Overlooked time and again, 35-year-old Shami sent a stern reminder to the national selection committee with an opening spell for the

ages that was pivotal to Lucknow Super Giants choking Sunrisers Hyderabad despite the Klaasen-Reddy stand.

The cerebral operator in Shami quickly understood that he would have to take the pace off the deliveries on this track and did so promptly.

He bowled four fullish blockhole deliveries to Head and allowed a single. When Abhishek took strike, the final delivery of the opening over was a loopy fuller delivery on the fifth stump which the opener tried to pitch. Instead of a conventional slip, a 'fly slip' or short third-man on the circle was stationed and Manimaran Siddharth took a smart diving catch.

UNDER 48KG CATEGORY

Boxer Meenakshi & Jaismine move to SFs

ULAANBAATAR: Indian women's boxing contingent continued its impressive run at the the Asian Boxing Championships as reigning world champions Meenakshi Hooda and Jaismine Lamboria stormed to the semifinals here on Sunday.

The pair's wins ensured the entire Indian women's contingent will finish on the podium.

In the men's section, triumphs for Lokesh, Akash, and Harsh Choudhary too made their way to the last-four stage.

Meenakshi produced a composed and commanding

display to defeat Japan's Yuka Sadamatsu by a unanimous 5-0 decision, controlling the women's 48kg category bout with sharp combinations and ring awareness.

Jaismine matched that intensity in the 57kg division, outclassing China's Ziyi Chen with an equally dominant 5-0 verdict to book her place in the semifinals.

In the men's section, Lokesh (85kg) booked his place in the next round with a clinical 5-0 win over Korea's Gichae Kim, showcasing control and precision throughout the bout.

India lose 0-5 to Aus in U20 Women's Asian Cup

PATHUM THANI: India suffered a crushing 0-5 defeat at the hands of Australia in the AFC U20 Women's Asian Cup 2026 at the Pathum Thani Stadium here on Sunday.

Skye Halmarick's (38', 39', 48') hat-trick put Australia in a commanding position, before Danella Brutus (54') and Daisy Brown (90+4') added two more for Australia. With this result, India currently sit at the bottom of Group C with zero points from their two games.

A win in their last group-stage match against Chinese Taipei on Wednesday can still

secure passage to the knock-out stage for Joakim Alexandersson's side.

While the final score may reflect otherwise, the Young Tigresses began on a positive note in the early exchanges, forging frequent counter-attacks against Australia's possession strategy.

Sulanjana Raul broke free down the left in the fourth minute, skipped past her marker and whipped in a low cross to Sibani Devi Nongmeikapam, who was shepherded to a difficult angle by the defenders, before being dispossessed.

Aizawl FC hold Sreenidi Deccan FC to 1-1 draw

The result saw the Deccan Warriors move up to 2nd in table

HYDERABAD: Aizawl FC displayed spirited performance to hold Sreenidi Deccan FC to a 1-1 draw in an Indian Football League match here on Sunday.

While Colombian forward David Castañeda Muñoz gave

the hosts the lead in the first half, an own goal by defender Jagdeep Singh restored parity late in the second period.

The result saw the Deccan Warriors move up to second in the table with 12 points from

seven matches, behind Diamond Harbour FC, who have a game in hand.

Aizawl FC remain fifth with nine points from the same number of games. Sreenidi dominated proceedings from kick-off

and created early opportunities through a series of free-kicks in dangerous areas. Muñoz fired one wide, while Romawia struck the crossbar with another, offering a glimpse of what was to follow.

Rain threat looms large as KKR seek to avoid 3rd straight loss

KOLKATA: Yet to open their account, embattled Kolkata Knight Riders could face an added challenge from the rain gods when they take on Punjab Kings in their IPL clash here on Monday.

According to the IMD weather bulletin, there is a high likelihood of rain impacting the match, which could also turn into a truncated affair.

With their match against Lucknow Super Giants next here -- a game that too carries a rain forecast -- weather could further compound KKR's early-season worries.

Incidentally, KKR's corresponding home fixture against PBKS last season on April 26 was also hit by rain, with both teams forced to settle for a point each.

The Shreyas Iyer-led Punjab Kings had posted 201/4 before KKR reached 7/0 when rain dashed hopes of a result.

There has been persistent cloud cover since morning following a "low-pressure trough stretching from Bihar to Manipur, passing over North Bengal, Assam and Bangladesh", as per the IMD.

"The state is likely to witness another round of Kalbaishakhi storms, with the possibility of hail and thunderstorms from Sunday through Thursday.

All-round RCB outclass CSK by 43 runs

BENGALURU: Tim David, skipper Rajat Patidar and Devdutt Padikkal went ballistic with marauding knocks while bowlers maintained fine lines as Royal Challengers Bengaluru crushed Chennai Super Kings by 43 runs in an IPL match here on Sunday.

Padikkal (50, 29 balls) and David (70 off 25b) gave a towelling to the clueless Super Kings bowlers in an exhibition of mind-blowing range-hitting, and Patidar supported them with an unbeaten 19-ball 48.

The end result of their collective belligerence was RCB's imposing total of 250 for three.

The Super Kings continued to be wimpy with the bat too, finishing at 207 all out in 19.4 overs as the five-time winners sank to their third straight defeat this season.



Royal Challengers Bengaluru's Virat Kohli (right), celebrates with Phil Salt after taking the catch of Chennai Super Kings' Noor Ahmad during an IPL match in Bengaluru on Sunday

Once Sanju Samson, captain Ruturaj Gaikwad and Ayush Mhatre walked back

with just 30 on the board, CSK's chase was doomed. Pacer Jacob Duffy (2/58) did the bulk of

damage in this phase, getting rid of Samson and Gaikwad as both fell to Padikkal at first slip.

Samson continued to misfire in the IPL for his new franchise post his inspired batting in the T20 World Cup.

The Kerala batter tried to be cute against Duffy, steering the ball with a perpendicular bat, whereas he should have attempted the easier option of a cut from that particular body position. He just managed a feeble nudge to Padikkal.

Mhatre's wicket gave veteran pacer Bhuvneshwar Kumar his 200th IPL wicket, the second bowler to achieve the feat after Yuzvendra Chahal. Sarfaraz Khan offered brave resistance with a 25-ball 50 but the target was way beyond them on the night.

Format C-7

(for political parties to publish in the newspapers, social media platforms & website of the party)

Information regarding individuals with pending criminal cases, who have been selected as candidates, along with the reasons for such selection, as also as to why other individuals without criminal antecedents could not be selected as candidates (As per the Commission's directions issued in pursuance of the Order dated 13.02.2020 of the Hon'ble Supreme Court in contempt petition (C) no. 2192 of 2018 in WP(C) No. 536 of 2011)

Name of Political Party: ALL INDIA TRINAMOOOL CONGRESS

*Name of the Election: GENERAL ELECTION TO THE LEGISLATIVE ASSEMBLY OF WEST BENGAL, 2026

Name of State/UT: WEST BENGAL

(1) Name of the Constituency - 205 Panskura Paschim Assembly Constituency

Name of the candidate – Siraj Khan

Sl.no.		
1.	Criminal antecedents	
i)	a.	Nature of the offences
		Offences alleged under Sections: 1. u/s 317 CRTC 2. Nil 3. Nil
	b.	Case no.
		1.GR No. 213/19 (arising out of FIR No. GRN No. 755/19, Tamluk Police Station) 2.FIR No- 0102014(A)0032014 3.ST Case No. 109/2025,Tamluk PS.
	c.	Name of the Court
		1. Tamluk Court 2. CBI Court Asansol 3. Tamluk Court
	d.	Whether charges have been framed or not (Yes/No)
		1. No 2. No 3. No
	e.	Date of conviction, if any
		Not Applicable
	f.	Details of punishment undergone, if any
		Not Applicable
	g.	Any other information required to be given
		Not Applicable
2.	The reasons for the selection of the candidate. Selection shall be with reference to the qualifications, achievements and merit of the candidate, and not mere "winnability" at the polls (not more than 100 words)	
	The candidate is an experienced grassroots political worker with strong public engagement. He serves as a voice for underprivileged and marginalized communities. His accessibility, close connection with the community, and consistent commitment to public service make him a suitable candidate for legislative responsibilities.	
3.	Reasons as to why other individuals without criminal antecedents could not be selected as candidates (not more than 100 words)	
	Same as above.	

(2) Name of the Constituency – 205- Panskura Paschim Assembly Constituency

Name of the candidate: Siraj Khan

* In the case of election to Council of States or States or election to Legislative Council by MLAs, mention the election concerned in place of name of Constituency.

Signature of office bearer of the Political Party
Name and Designation

Derek O'Brien
Member, National Working Committee
All India Trinamool Congress

OFFICE OF THE CHIEF ENGINEER P.W.D UJJAIN ZONE UJJAIN
No 0734-2524462 E-Mail cepwdujjain@mp.nic.in
Tender Notice
NIT OF 01 GEN/CE/2026-27UJJAIN DATE 01-04-2026
ONLINE PERCENTAGE RATE TENDER FOR THE WORK MENTIONED BELOW ARE BEING INVITED. THE TENDER HAS/HAVE BEEN UPLOADED ON THE E-PROCUREMENT SYSTEM OF PUBLIC WORKS DEPARTMENT ON THE PORTAL WWW.MPTENDERS.GOV.IN TENDER DETAILS ARE AS BELOW:-

S. No.	Division Name	Tender ID No.	Name of work	Cost of Project (PAC) (Rs. In lacs)	Time Period
1	SHAJAPUR	2026_PWDRB_496513_pack1	HADLAYKALAN GOSHALA TO BANKA KHEDI ROAD LENGTH 10.14 KM INCLUDING POLE SHIFTING DIVISION SHAJAPUR	833.50	12 Months Including Rainy Season
2	SHAJAPUR	2026_PWDRB_496514_pack1	CONSTRUCTION OF KUMER TO DHABLA HUSSIANPUR VIA HADLAYKHURD ROAD, LENGTH- 10.45 KM INCLUDING ELECTRIC POLE SHIFTING WORK DIVISION SHAJAPUR	1035.53	12 Months Including Rainy Season
3	RATLAM	2026_PWDRB_496515_pack1	CONSTRUCTION OF PALAS FANTA TO HIMMATGARH ROAD LENGTH 6.55 KM INCLUDING EXTERNAL ELECTRIFICATION WORK DIVISION RATLAM	675.42	12 Months Including Rainy Season

THE DOCUMENT CAN ONLY BE PURCHASED ONLINE FROM THE ABOVE WEBSITE AFTER MAKING ONLINE PAYMENT. THE LAST DATE & TIME FOR PURCHASE OF DOCUMENT AND ONLINE BID SUBMISSION ON LINE IS DATED 21-04-2026 UP TO 17:30 PM. DETAILED NIT AND OTHER DETAILS CAN BE VIEWED ON THE ABOVE MENTIONED PORTAL. AMENDMENTS TO NIT, IF ANY, WOULD BE PUBLISHED ON WEBSITE ONLY, AND NOT IN NEWSPAPER.

CHIEF ENGINEER
P.W.D UJJAIN ZONE UJJAIN
G11133/26
"स्वभाव स्वच्छता, संस्कार स्वच्छता"

Format C-7

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Information regarding individuals with pending criminal cases, who have been selected as candidates, along with the reasons for such selection, as also as to why other individuals without criminal antecedents could not be selected as candidates

(As per the Commission’s directions issued in pursuance of the Order dated 13.02.2020 of the Hon’ble Supreme Court in contempt petition (C) no. 2192 of 2018 in WP(C) No. 536 of 2011)

Name of Political Party: ALL INDIA TRINAMOOOL CONGRESS

*Name of the Election: GENERAL ELECTION TO THE LEGISLATIVE ASSEMBLY OF WEST BENGAL 2026

Name of State/UT: WEST BENGAL

(1) Name of the Constituency - 217- Ramnagar Assembly Constituency

(2) Name of the candidate – Akhil Giri

Sl.no.			
1.	Criminal antecedents		
i)	a.	Nature of the offences	Offences alleged under: 1. Section 188of Indian Penal Code, 1860 2. Sections 341/186/504/117/353 of the Indian Penal Code, 1860 3. Sections 143/341/427/379/506 of the Indian Penal Code, 1860
	b.	Case no.	1. SPL Case No. 20/2024 (arising out of Digha P.S. No. 35/2016, Digha Police Station, Purba Medinipur). 2. SPL Case No. 03/2022 (arising out of Marishda P.S. Case No. 27/2009, dated 25.03.2009, Marishda Police Station, Purba Medinipur). 3. G.R. Case No. 450/1994 (arising out of Contai P.S. Case No. 161/1994, dated 12.07.1994, Contai Police Station, Purba Medinipur)
	c.	Name of the Court	1. Learned 2nd Judicial Magistrate, Bidhannagar. 2. Learned 2nd Judicial Magistrate, Bidhannagar. 3. Learned 2nd Judicial Magistrate, Contai.
	d.	Whether charges have been framed or not (Yes/No)	1. Yes, on 22.05.2025 2. Yes, on 24.07.2025 No
	e.	Date of conviction, if any	Not Applicable
	f.	Details of punishment undergone, if any	Not Applicable
	g.	Any other information required to be given	Not Applicable
2.	The reasons for the selection of the candidate. Selection shall be with reference to the qualifications, achievements and merit of the candidate, and not mere “winnability” at the polls (not more than 100 words)		As a dedicated social worker, the candidate has spent years addressing community needs and empowering marginalized groups. His compassionate approach and ability to bring people together have made a tangible difference in many lives, making him a beacon of hope and an ideal representative for the area.
3.	Reasons as to why other individuals without criminal antecedents could not be selected as candidates (not more than 100 words)		Same as above.

(3) Name of the Constituency – 217 – RAMNAGAR ASSEMBLY CONSTITUENCY

(4) Name of the candidate: Akhil Giri

* In the case of election to Council of States or States or election to Legislative Council by MLAs, mention the election concerned in place of name of Constituency.

Signature of office bearer of the Political Party

Name and Designation



Derek O’Brien

National Working Committee Member

All India Trinamool Congress

Format C-7

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Information regarding individuals with pending criminal cases, who have been selected as candidates, along with the reasons for such selection, as also as to why other individuals without criminal antecedents could not be selected as candidates

(As per the Commission’s directions issued in pursuance of the Order dated 13.02.2020 of the Hon’ble Supreme Court in contempt petition (C) no. 2192 of 2018 in WP(C) No. 536 of 2011)

Name of Political Party: ALL INDIA TRINAMOOOL CONGRESS

*Name of the Election: GENERAL ELECTION TO THE LEGISLATIVE ASSEMBLY OF WEST BENGAL 2026

Name of State/UT: WEST BENGAL

(1) Name of the Constituency - 206- Moyna Assembly Constituency

(2) Name of the candidate – Chandan Mondal

Sl.no.			
1.	Criminal antecedents		
i)	a.	Nature of the offences	Offences alleged under: 1. Sections 143/188/269/270/271of Indian Penal Code, 1860 2. Sections 143/448/427/34 of the Indian Penal Code, 1860 3. 147/148/149/186/355/427 of the Indian Penal Code, 1860 4. 147/148/149/341/323/325/326/307/506 of the Indian Penal Code, 1860
	b.	Case no.	1. Moyna P.S. Case No. 138/2020 dated 05.06.2020, Moyna Police Station. 2. Moyna P.S. Case No. 70/2021 dated 24/03/2021, Moyna Police Station. 3. Moyna P.S. Case No. 73/2021 dated 24/03/2021, Moyna Police Station. 4. Moyna P.S. Case No. 84/2023, Moyna Police Station
	c.	Name of the Court	1. Learned Chief Judicial Magistrate, Purba Medinipur 2. Learned Chief Judicial Magistrate, Purba Medinipur 3. Learned Chief Judicial Magistrate, Purba Medinipur 4. Learned A.D.J. 4th Court, Purba Medinipur
	d.	Whether charges have been framed or not (Yes/No)	1. No 2. No 3. No 4. Yes, on 15/07/2024
	e.	Date of conviction, if any	Not Applicable
	f.	Details of punishment undergone, if any	Not Applicable
	g.	Any other information required to be given	Not Applicable
2.	The reasons for the selection of the candidate. Selection shall be with reference to the qualifications, achievements and merit of the candidate, and not mere “winnability” at the polls (not more than 100 words)		The candidate brings extensive grassroots experience and strong public engagement, consistently serving as a voice for marginalized communities. His accessibility, deep community connect, and unwavering commitment to public service underscore his readiness for legislative responsibilities.
3.	Reasons as to why other individuals without criminal antecedents could not be selected as candidates (not more than 100 words)		Same as above.

(3) Name of the Constituency – 206- MOYNA ASSEMBLY CONSTITUENCY

(4) Name of the candidate: Chandan Mondal

* In the case of election to Council of States or States or election to Legislative Council by MLAs, mention the election concerned in place of name of Constituency.

Signature of office bearer of the Political Party

Name and Designation



Derek O’Brien

National Working Committee Member

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Information regarding individuals with pending criminal cases, who have been selected as candidates, along with the reasons for such selection, as also as to why other individuals without criminal antecedents could not be selected as candidates

(As per the Commission’s directions issued in pursuance of the Order dated 13.02.2020 of the Hon’ble Supreme Court in contempt petition (C) no. 2192 of 2018 in WP(C) No. 536 of 2011)

Name of Political Party: ALL INDIA TRINAMOOOL CONGRESS

*Name of the Election: GENERAL ELECTION TO THE LEGISLATIVE ASSEMBLY OF WEST BENGAL 2026

Name of State/UT: WEST BENGAL

(1) Name of the Constituency - 76 - Jalangi Assembly Constituency

(2) Name of the candidate – Babar Ali

Sl.no.			
1.	Criminal antecedents		
i)	a.	Nature of the offences	Offences alleged under: Section 326 of Indian Penal Code, 1860.
	b.	Case no.	G.R.No. 1532/2012 (arising out of PS Case No 471/2012, dated 22.04.2012, Berhampore Police Station)
	c.	Name of the Court	Learned J.M 2nd Court, Murshidabad
	d.	Whether charges have been framed or not (Yes/No)	Yes, on 18.12.2013
	e.	Date of conviction, if any	Not Applicable
	f.	Details of punishment undergone, if any	Not Applicable
	g.	Any other information required to be given	Not Applicable
2.	The reasons for the selection of the candidate. Selection shall be with reference to the qualifications, achievements and merit of the candidate, and not mere “winnability” at the polls (not more than 100 words)		
3.	Reasons as to why other individuals without criminal antecedents could not be selected as candidates (not more than 100 words)		

(3) Name of the Constituency – 76 - JALANGI ASSEMBLY CONSTITUENCY

(4) Name of the candidate: Babar Ali

* In the case of election to Council of States or States or election to Legislative Council by MLAs, mention the election concerned in place of name of Constituency.

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(As per the Commission’s directions issued in pursuance of the Order dated 13.02.2020 of the Hon’ble Supreme Court in contempt petition (C) no. 2192 of 2018 in WP(C) No. 536 of 2011)

Name of Political Party: ALL INDIA TRINAMOOOL CONGRESS

*Name of the Election: GENERAL ELECTION TO THE LEGISLATIVE ASSEMBLY OF WEST BENGAL 2026

Name of State/UT: WEST BENGAL

(1) Name of the Constituency - 66- Khargram (SC) Assembly Constituency

(2) Name of the candidate – Ashis Marjit

Sl.no.			
1.	Criminal antecedents		
i)	a.	Nature of the offences	Offences alleged under: Sections 189/504/505(1b)/506 of Indian Penal Code, 1860
	b.	Case no.	G.R. Case No. 658 of 15 (arising out of PS Case No. 108/15, dated 28/06/15, Margram Police Station, District-Birbhum)
	c.	Name of the Court	Learned A.C.J.M at Rampurhat (Birbhum)
	d.	Whether charges have been framed or not (Yes/No)	No
	e.	Date of conviction, if any	Not Applicable
	f.	Details of punishment undergone, if any	Not Applicable
	g.	Any other information required to be given	Not Applicable
2.	The reasons for the selection of the candidate. Selection shall be with reference to the qualifications, achievements and merit of the candidate, and not mere “winnability” at the polls (not more than 100 words)		
3.	Reasons as to why other individuals without criminal antecedents could not be selected as candidates (not more than 100 words)		

(3) Name of the Constituency – 66- KHARGRAM (SC) ASSEMBLY CONSTITUENCY

(4) Name of the candidate: Ashis Marjit

* In the case of election to Council of States or States or election to Legislative Council by MLAs, mention the election concerned in place of name of Constituency.

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(As per the Commission’s directions issued in pursuance of the Order dated 13.02.2020 of the Hon’ble Supreme Court in contempt petition (C) no. 2192 of 2018 in WP(C) No. 536 of 2011)

Name of Political Party: ALL INDIA TRINAMOOOL CONGRESS

*Name of the Election: GENERAL ELECTION TO THE LEGISLATIVE ASSEMBLY OF WEST BENGAL 2026

Name of State/UT: WEST BENGAL

(1) Name of the Constituency - 60-Sagardighi Assembly Constituency

(2) Name of the candidate – Bayron Biswas

Sl.no.			
1.	Criminal antecedents		
i)	a.	Nature of the offences	Offences alleged under: Sections 448/427/379/506/34 of Indian Penal Code, 1860
	b.	Case no.	G.R. Case No. 664of 23 (arising out of PS Case No.89/ 23, dated 20.3.23, Samsherganj Police Station)
	c.	Name of the Court	Learned A.C.J.M at Jangipur
	d.	Whether charges have been framed or not (Yes/No)	No
	e.	Date of conviction, if any	Not Applicable
	f.	Details of punishment undergone, if any	Not Applicable

	g.	Any other information required to be given	Not Applicable
2.	The reasons for the selection of the candidate. Selection shall be with reference to the qualifications, achievements and merit of the candidate, and not mere “winnability” at the polls (not more than 100 words)		The candidate is an experienced grassroots political worker with strong public engagement. His accessibility, close connection with the community, and consistent commitment to public service make him a suitable candidate for legislative responsibilities. He serves as a voice for underprivileged and marginalized communities.
3.	Reasons as to why other individuals without criminal antecedents could not be selected as candidates (not more than 100 words)		Same as above.

(3) Name of the Constituency – 60-SAGARDIGHI ASSEMBLY CONSTITUENCY

(4) Name of the candidate: Bayron Biswas

* In the case of election to Council of States or States or election to Legislative Council by MLAs, mention the election concerned in place of name of Constituency.

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Name of Political Party: ALL INDIA TRINAMOOOL CONGRESS

*Name of the Election: GENERAL ELECTION TO THE LEGISLATIVE ASSEMBLY OF WEST BENGAL, 2026

Name of State/UT: WEST BENGAL

(1) Name of the Constituency - 69– Bharatpur Assembly Constituency

Name of the candidate –Mustafijur Rahaman

Sl.no.			
1.	Criminal antecedents		
i)	a.	Nature of the offences	Offences Alleged Under: 1. Sections 302/34 of IPC, 1860 2. Sections 143/323/427/34 of IPC, 1860 3. Sections 147/148/149/153(A)/333/308/427/506of IPC, 1860 and Section 9 of M.P.O Act ,1972
	b.	Case no.	1. G.R Case No. 946/16 (in connection to P.S. Case No. 100/16, dated 21.05.16,Salar Police Station Murshidabad) 2. GR Case No. 1241/14 (in connection to P.S. Case No. 190/14, dated 10.06.14, Salar Police Station, Murshidabad) 3. GR Case No. 1418/12 (in connection to P.S. Case No. 128/12, dated 14.09.12, Salar Police Station, Murshidabad)
	c.	Name of the Court	1.Learned A.C.J.M, Kandi Court, Murshidabad 2.Learned A.C.J.M, Kandi Court, Murshidabad 3.Learned A.C.J.M, Kandi Court, Murshidabad
	d.	Whether charges have been framed or not (Yes/No)	1. No 2. No 3. No
	e.	Date of conviction, if any	Not Applicable
	f.	Details of punishment undergone, if any	Not Applicable
	g.	Any other information required to be given	Not Applicable
2.	The reasons for the selection of the candidate. Selection shall be with reference to the qualifications, achievements and merit of the candidate, and not mere “winnability” at the polls (not more than 100 words)		The candidatehasdemonstrated public service, experience, and commitment to social welfare.His strong grassroots presence and nuanced understanding of constituency level issues equip him for effective representation. Accordingly, the selection is grounded in merit, a proven record of public service, and suitability for legislative responsibilities, rather than considerations of mere electoral winnability.
3.	Reasons as to why other individuals without criminal antecedents could not be selected as candidates (not more than 100 words)		Same as above.

(2) Name of the Constituency – 69– BHARATPUR ASSEMBLY CONSTITUENCY

Name of the candidate: Mustafijur Rahaman

* In the case of election to Council of States or States or election to Legislative Council by MLAs, mention the election concerned in place of name of Constituency.

Signature of office bearer of the Political Party

Name and Designation



Derek O’Brien

Member, National Working Committee

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Information regarding individuals with pending criminal cases, who have been selected as candidates, along with the reasons for such selection, as also as to why other individuals without criminal antecedents could not be selected as candidates (As per the Commission’s directions issued in pursuance of the Order dated 13.02.2020 of the Hon’ble Supreme Court in contempt petition (C) no. 2192 of 2018 in WP(C) No. 536 of 2011)

Name of Political Party: ALL INDIA TRINAMOOOL CONGRESS

*Name of the Election: GENERAL ELECTION TO THE LEGISLATIVE ASSEMBLY OF WEST BENGAL, 2026

Name of State/UT: WEST BENGAL

(1) Name of the Constituency - 210- Nandigram Assembly Constituency

Name of the candidate –Pabitra Kar

Sl.no.			
1.	Criminal antecedents		
i)	a.	Nature of the offences	Offences alleged under: 1.Sections34/323/325/326/341/506of the Indian Penal Code, 1860; 2.Sections 34/307/323/325/341/427/506 of the Indian Penal Code, 1860; 3.Sections34/307/323/325/341/379/427/506of Indian Penal Code, 1860; 4.Section 379of the Indian Penal Code, 1860; 5.Sections 34/323/427/448/506 of the Indian Penal Code, 1860; 6.Sections 34/323/447/506 of the Indian Penal Code, 1860; 7.Section 126 of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023
	b.	Case no.	1. G.R. Case No. 1912/2023 2. G.R. Case No. 402/2021 3. S.C. Case No. 141/2021 4. G.R. Case No. 88/2020 5. C.R. Case No. 272/2020 6. C.R. Case No. 192/2020 7. P.R. Case No. 689/2026
	c.	Name of the Court	1.Learned ACJM Haldia, Purba Medinipur 2.Learned ACJM Haldia, Purba Medinipur 3.Learned ADJ Haldia, Purba Medinipur 4.Learned ACJM Haldia, Purba Medinipur 5.Learned JM Haldia, Purba Medinipur 6.Learned ACJM Haldia, Purba Medinipur 7.Learned Executive Magistrate Haldia, Purba Medinipur
	d.	Whether charges have been framed or not (Yes/No)	1. No 2. No 3. No 4. No 5. No 6. No 7. No
	e.	Date of conviction, if any	Not Applicable
	f.	Details of punishment undergone, if any	Not Applicable
	g.	Any other information required to be given	Not Applicable
2.	The reasons for the selection of the candidate. Selection shall be with reference to the qualifications, achievements and merit of the candidate, and not mere “winnability” at the polls (not more than 100 words)		The candidate is an experienced grassroots political worker with a strong record of public engagement. He has consistently acted as a voice for underprivileged and marginalized communities. His accessibility, close ties with the local population, and sustained commitment to public service demonstrate his suitability for undertaking legislative responsibilities.
3.	Reasons as to why other individuals without criminal antecedents could not be selected as candidates (not more than 100 words)		Same as above.

(2) Name of the Constituency – 210- NANDIGRAM ASSEMBLY CONSTITUENCY

Name of the candidate: Pabitra Kar

* In the case of election to Council of States or States or election to Legislative Council by MLAs, mention the election concerned in place of name of Constituency.

Signature of office bearer of the Political Party

Name and Designation



Derek O’Brien

Member, National Working Committee

All India Trinamool Congress



Roshan lauded filmmakers who try to deliver a new experience to the audience

HRITHIK REACTS TO CRITICISM OVER RAMAYANA'S VFX

NEW DELHI: Bollywood star Hrithik Roshan expressed his thoughts on the ongoing debate over VFX in Ranbir Kapoor-starrer 'Ramayana' and lauded filmmakers who try to deliver a new experience to the audience.

Roshan shared a note on his 'Instagram' handle and said several filmmakers, including his father Rakesh Roshan, risk the money and efforts to deliver to the audience an experience they have never had before.

The actor, who is set to step into the director's shoes with 'Krrish 4', named films such as 'Kalki', 'Baahubali' and 'Ramayana' and said the makers of these movies are heroes that 'have the guts and vision' according to him.

"Today, some special humans among us, like the makers of films like 'Kalki', 'Baahubali' and 'Ramayana', (also my dad for 'Koi Mil Gaya' and 'Krrish', of course) are my heroes. They have the guts and vision to do what's never been done - all for the love of cinema so that we - the audience get to experience something never watched before," he wrote in the lengthy caption.

He added, "From my point of



view, they risked all that money and years and years of effort just so another 11-year-old kid could feel what I felt. To me, that's noble. The intention by itself deserves applause! I am proud of my fellow Indians. What would I give to be a part of such dreams even as an assistant... But this post is not about me; it's about us, the audience. Thing is, it takes thousands of our artistes working round the clock for multiple years to bring VFX-heavy films to life, so the least we can do is bash them with some better awareness."

His comments came following the teaser release of Ranbir Kapoor's film 'Ramayana', which has got mixed reactions with some users criticising it for appearing like a video game and also the concerns over casting choices and character portrayals. The film is directed by Nitesh Tiwari and features Kapoor in the role of Ram and Sai Pallavi as Sita.

The actor is set to step into the director's shoes with 'Krrish 4'

'Peaky Blinders' will enter new era with Jamie Bell

LOS ANGELES: The world of 'Peaky Blinders' is set to expand as creator Steven Knight has announced a sequel series, set in post-war Birmingham in the 1950s and featuring the next generation of the Shelby family.

Jamie Bell, known for featuring in films such as 'Jumper', 'Snowpiercer', 'Rocket Man' and 'All of Us Strangers', has been cast in the lead role of Duke Shelby, son of Tommy Shelby.

Also joining the cast for the show, which has received an order for two new six-episode seasons, are 'Stranger Things' alum Charlie Heaton as co-lead, as well as actors Lashana Lynch, Jessica Brown Findlay and Lucy Karczewski.

Oscar winner Cillian Murphy headlined the original series, which started on the 'BBC' but became a worldwide phenomenon after landing on 'Netflix', as Tommy Shelby, a World War I veteran who rises from being a local gang leader in Birmingham to businessman and ultimately a Member of Parliament.



After the show ended its six-season run on 'BBC' and 'Netflix' in 2022, the actor recently reprised the role in 'Peaky Blinders: The Immortal Man' with Oscar nominee Barry Keoghan essaying the role of Duke Shelby.

The sequel series, which will be written by Knight, will pick up 10 years after the events that ensued in 'The Immortal Man'.

"In this new era of 'Peaky Blinders', a decade after World

War Two, the race to rebuild Birmingham becomes a brutal contest of mythical dimensions. This is a city of unprecedented opportunity and jeopardy. At its blood-soaked heart is Duke Shelby (Jamie Bell): older, wiser, more ambitious and most certainly more dangerous," read the official logline.

The series has started production in and around Digbeth Loc. Studios in Birmingham.

Janhvi recalls the horror of finding her morphed images online

The actress recently spoke about the darker realities of growing up in the spotlight

Janhvi Kapoor recently spoke about the darker realities of growing up in the spotlight, recalling a traumatic experience from her teenage years. In a recent conversation, she shared how she first came across a morphed, sexually explicit image of herself while still in school.

On Raj Shamani's podcast, Janhvi recalled being just 15 years old when the incident occurred. While attending an IT class at school, she realised that male classmates were looking at a pornographic website. To her horror, the site featured a deepfake-style image of her face morphed onto someone else's body.

"I remember I was in my IT class and I saw boys in my class looking at this site and there was a photo of me on it," she shared. Janhvi described the experience as isolating, noting that at such a young age, she felt she had to 'rationalise' the lack of morality on social media because of her family's fame.

While the initial incident happened years ago, Janhvi emphasised that the problem has only evolved with the rise of Artificial Intelligence. She expressed deep concern over how AI-generated visuals are now used to create false narratives.

She added, "I am not at peace with it. There are visuals of me out there, even shared by official news pages, which are completely AI. I have never worn those clothes or been photographed like that." The actress noted that even reputable news pages occasionally share AI visuals of her in outfits she has never worn.

This, she argues, poses a professional threat and said, "It gets circulated as if it's something I've put out. That creates a certain kind of impression. Suppose tomorrow I go to a director and I say, 'Listen, I am not comfortable wearing this'. They can point to a morphed image and say, 'But you've done it before.'"

She emphasised that the problem has only evolved with the rise of AI



Nearly four decades later, Kamal Haasan's 'Vishwaroopam', already certified by the CBFC, was halted by district collectors in Tamil Nadu

vate moment of a woman caught between ambition and longing. It is precisely this kind of intimacy that made the film feel dangerous in 1975. The resemblance between Sen's character and then-Prime Minister Indira Gandhi, right as the Emergency was being declared, was apparently too close for comfort. 'Aandhi' returned to screens only after the political weather changed. Today, it is considered a masterwork. At that time, it was considered a problem.

Nearly four decades later, Kamal Haasan's 'Vishwaroopam', already certified by the CBFC, was halted by district collectors in Tamil Nadu following protests over its portrayal of a jihadi network, with law and order cited as justification. The irony is worth sitting with. A film whose entire thesis was about mistaken assumptions was itself the subject of one.

What makes the Hind Rajab case particularly striking is its nakedness. A documentary carrying raw footage of a six-year-

old Palestinian girl's death in Gaza during Israel's 2024 Rafah offensive was rejected by the CBFC in early 2025 without even a pretext.

Three films. Three different eras. Three competing anxieties. Political, communal and diplomatic. What I find myself returning to is not the fact of censorship, but the question of framing. 'Aandhi' was banned when the suspension of norms was openly declared. The 'Vishwaroopam' halt came dressed in the language of public order. The 'Hind Rajab' rejection didn't bother with a legal framework at all.

What changes across these cases is how power chooses to explain itself. The lights go out. But the projector keeps spinning.

Darshim Saxena is a screenwriter and film analyst. She is the founder and host of 'The Second Seat', a conversation space for creators and audiences dedicated to cinema beyond box office narratives



Fresh eyes on aviation's most enduring enigma

Young author Miraya Bharat's 'MH370: Where Answers Disappear' unravels the enigmatic disappearance of Malaysia Airlines Flight MH370 with a striking blend of scientific clarity and literary grace

AUTHOR



DR SATYAPRAKASH SHARMA

In an age when most teenagers are busy with school assignments and social media, 13-year-old Miraya Bharat has accomplished something extraordinary: she has written a book on one of modern aviation's most haunting mysteries - the disappearance of Malaysia Airlines Flight MH370.

'MH370: Where Answers Disappear', published by the international publisher 'BriBooks' in March 2026, is the second book by Miraya Bharat from Madhya Pradesh and daughter of senior IAS officer Bharat Yadav and Dr Pri-

yanka Yadav. What could easily be seen upon reading as a thoughtful, atmospheric narrative humanises one of modern aviation's greatest mysteries while demonstrating remarkable maturity and narrative craft for someone so young.

The book opens on the evening of March 8, 2014, at Kuala Lumpur International Airport, where Miraya vividly captures the ordinary rhythms of departure - passengers settling in, parents checking on children, flight attendants moving through the cabin. The Boeing 777, carrying 239 souls including Captain Zaharie Ahmad Shah and First Officer Fariq Abdul Hamid, exudes the quiet anticipation of a long-haul flight - until, somewhere between departure and arrival, everything changes.

Spanning nine chapters, the book follows the known timeline with clarity and emotional depth. Early chapters set the human stage, while later sections - including 'Disappearance from Radar', 'The 180-Degree Turn', 'Signals to the Sky' and 'The Seventh Arc' - trace the technical unravelling, from the



The book opens on the evening of March 8, 2014, at Kuala Lumpur International Airport, where Miraya vividly captures the ordinary rhythms of departure

sudden loss of transponder signals and the plane's turn over the Malay Peninsula to the faint Inmarsat 'handshakes' plotting its likely path into the southern Indian Ocean.

Miraya explains complex elements - radar data, satellite pings, ocean currents and drift modelling - without overwhelming the reader, highlighting the 'Seventh Arc', where the plane likely ran out of fuel. Her account of the multinational search efforts from 2014 to 2018 is poignant: despite ships, aircraft and specialised drones scouring

vast areas, only a handful of debris pieces washed ashore in the Indian Ocean years later.

The young author presents leading theories with fairness, from deliberate action on board to sudden decompression or mechanical failure, while noting the lack of definitive evidence - no distress call, communication or black boxes recovered. Even recent private searches, including Ocean Infinity's campaigns through 2025-2026, failed to locate the fuselage. As of early 2026, the mystery remains

unsolved 12 years on.

What elevates Miraya's book beyond a simple retelling is its empathetic core. She doesn't treat the passengers and crew as mere statistics. Brief, sensitive passages imagine their final hours - some sleeping, others lost in thought, conversations drifting softly, the quiet hum of engines providing an illusion of normalcy. This human focus prevents the narrative from becoming cold or purely technical. At the same time, the prose maintains a measured tone, avoiding sensationalism or conspiracy-laden speculation that has marred some other accounts of MH370.

The book's novelistic style, with cinematic descriptions of the night sky, tilting wings and endless ocean, makes the story accessible to general readers. For a 13-year-old, Miraya's command of pacing, structure and language is impressive, reflecting her deep research. In concluding sections like 'Truth Lost in Fragments', she considers the limits of technology and the enduring pain for the victims' families.

In her afterword, Miraya clarifies that she didn't aim to solve the mystery or present new evidence. Her goal was to blend factual reporting with imaginative reconstruction, helping readers 'feel closer to the real events' and grasp the human dimension behind the headlines. Acknowledging the balance between imagination and reality, she describes the book as 'a story containing imagination with reality', a self-awareness that is both refreshing and mature.

While the book may not break new ground or challenge official findings and occasionally favours atmosphere over technical detail, these are minor points given the author's age. For newcomers to the MH370 story, it is an engaging introduction. For those familiar, it offers a poignant reminder of human lives at its centre.

Writing a second book at 13 is rare and on a complex, emotionally charged topic like MH370, even more so. Miraya's achievement reflects curiosity, disciplined research and creative persistence,

producing a work that is both accessible and respectful.

The book may not provide closure or end the global fascination with the vanished flight, but it succeeds in illuminating the sequence of events, honouring those on board and highlighting why the mystery endures. The plane's final resting place along the silent Seventh Arc remains unknown, leaving questions about the 180-degree turn, autopilot engagement and the chain of events that turned a routine flight into an enduring enigma.

As Miraya notes, some mysteries endure far longer than expected. Her book, though written by a young author, delivers a timeless message: behind every vanished signal and silent ocean arc are real people, real stories and a shared human longing for truth.

In the end, this volume signals the promise of a talented young author. She makes a complex, tragic chapter in aviation history feel immediate and human and for that, 'MH370: Where Answers Disappear' deserves attention and praise.